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A Taxonomy of Theory of Change Applications: An Empirical Study in the Third Sector

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Author: **Chiara Rossetti**

Student ID: 250819

Advisor: Marika Arena

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Abstract

In recent years, impact assessment has become a central element for Third Sector Organisations (TSOs), which are required to demonstrate their ability to create value and generate substantial change in the contexts in which they operate. Among the tools frequently used today is the Theory of Change (ToC), which has become increasingly important in academic and professional debate in support of planning, learning and impact reporting. Despite the widespread use of this tool, there remains a significant gap between its theoretical applications and the concrete ways in which it is adopted at the organisational level.

In this context, the thesis set out to analyse how ToC is used by TSOs and to develop an interpretative taxonomy of its applications and relative level of maturity. Starting from a review of the literature, the key dimensions that allow the different ways of using ToC to be interpreted were identified, considering aspects such as the degree of contextualisation of the analysis, causal articulation, methodological integration, temporal and functional orientation, and stakeholder involvement.

The empirical analysis was conducted through a multiple case study comprising eighteen projects funded by the Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, collecting data through document analysis and semi-structured interviews. The results highlight significant heterogeneity in the practices adopted by the organisations, with different configurations of ToC use depending on the depth of causal analysis, integration into decision-making processes and stakeholder involvement. The positioning of the practices found in the empirical analysis is influenced by factors such as managerial attitudes, organisational structures and the institutional context. No intrinsically superior level of maturity emerges, but rather configurations that are more or less consistent with the characteristics of the project and the evolutionary stage of the organisation. The proposed taxonomy provides an interpretative key for systematically reading the different uses of ToC and provides useful guidance for institutions and funders in designing impact assessment processes that are proportionate and consistent with organisational capabilities.

Key-words: Theory of Change; Logical Framework Approach; Impact Assessment; Taxonomy; Third Sector Organisations.

Abstract in italiano

Negli ultimi anni la valutazione d'impatto è diventata un elemento centrale per gli Enti del Terzo Settore (ETS), chiamati a dimostrare la propria capacità di creare valore e generare dei cambiamenti sostanziali nei contesti in cui operano. Tra gli strumenti oggi frequentemente utilizzati, si annovera la Theory of Change (ToC), che ha assunto crescente rilevanza nel dibattito accademico e professionale a supporto di pianificazione, apprendimento e rendicontazione d'impatto. Nonostante la diffusione di questo strumento, permane un divario significativo tra le sue applicazioni teoriche e le modalità concrete con cui viene adottato a livello organizzativo.

In questo contesto, la tesi si è posta l'obiettivo di analizzare come la ToC viene utilizzata dagli ETS, e sviluppare una tassonomia interpretativa delle sue applicazioni e del relativo livello di maturità. A partire da una revisione della letteratura, sono state identificate le dimensioni chiave che consentono di interpretare le diverse modalità di utilizzo della ToC, considerando aspetti quali il grado di contestualizzazione dell'analisi, l'articolazione causale, l'integrazione metodologica, l'orientamento temporale e funzionale e il coinvolgimento degli stakeholder.

L'analisi empirica è stata condotta attraverso uno studio di caso multiplo che comprende diciotto progetti finanziati dalla Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, raccogliendo i dati attraverso analisi documentale e interviste semi-strutturate. I risultati evidenziano una significativa eterogeneità nelle pratiche adottate dagli enti, con configurazioni di utilizzo della ToC differenziate in funzione della profondità dell'analisi causale, dell'integrazione nei processi decisionali e del coinvolgimento degli stakeholder. Il posizionamento delle pratiche riscontrate nell'analisi empirica è influenzato da fattori quali le attitudini manageriali, le strutture organizzative degli enti e il contesto istituzionale. Non emerge un livello intrinsecamente superiore di maturità, ma configurazioni più o meno coerenti con le caratteristiche del progetto e la fase evolutiva dell'organizzazione. La tassonomia proposta fornisce una chiave interpretativa per leggere in modo sistematico i diversi usi della ToC e fornisce indicazioni utili per gli enti e per i soggetti finanziatori nella progettazione di processi di valutazione d'impatto proporzionati e coerenti con le capacità organizzative.

Parole chiave: Theory of Change; Logical Framework Approach; Valutazione d'Impatto; Tassonomia; Enti del Terzo Settore.

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Introduction

In recent years, the topic of impact assessment has taken on an increasingly central role in the academic debate and in the management practices of organisations operating in the third sector. The growing demand for accountability and attention to the effective generation of change has gradually shifted the focus from simply monitoring the activities carried out to analysing the results produced and the effects generated in the medium to long term. In this context, impact assessment tools are not only technical reporting devices, but have become genuine strategic management tools.

Among the tools that have gained particular prominence in this context is the Theory of Change (ToC). Originally developed within the tradition of theory-driven evaluation and organisational learning, the ToC seeks to articulate how and why change is expected to occur, making explicit the causal mechanisms, assumptions, contextual conditions and non-linear dynamics underlying social interventions. Its diffusion across philanthropic foundations, development agencies and Third Sector Organisations (TSOs) reflects its perceived capacity to navigate complexity and to connect planning, evaluation and strategic reflection. Despite its increasing institutionalisation, the tool has been extensively discussed in the academic and professional literature: numerous studies have examined its conceptual foundations, highlighted its strengths in dealing with complexity, stakeholder multiplicity and non-linear causality, and promoted it as a strategic and learning-oriented framework for impact evaluation. It has been applied across a wide range of fields, often with the aim of demonstrating how its explicit articulation of assumptions and intermediate outcomes can enhance the quality and credibility of evaluation processes. At the same time, critical contributions have pointed out that the ToC risks becoming overly formalised, simplified or reduced to a bureaucratic requirement when not properly implemented.

Overall, the literature has largely converged toward a shared understanding of how the ToC should be constructed and applied in order to realise its full analytical and strategic potential. However, empirical evidence simultaneously reveals that, in practice, ToC applications can vary significantly: different projects exhibit different levels of articulation, contextual integration, methodological integration and

stakeholder engagement, resulting in heterogeneous configurations of use. While this heterogeneity is acknowledged in empirical studies, there is still a lack of a systematic framework capable of explaining why such different configurations emerge and how they relate to organisational characteristics and contextual conditions. In other words, the literature documents variation, but does not conceptualise it. This gap between normative prescriptions and observed practices constitutes the central problem addressed by this thesis.

This research addresses this problem by examining how and in what forms the Theory of Change is enacted within TSOs. It develops and empirically applies an interpretative taxonomy designed to classify recurring configurations of use and to analyse the organisational and contextual conditions associated with different levels of maturity. In line with this objective, the study addresses the following research questions:

1. How is the Theory of Change concretely used within Third Sector projects?
2. What organisational and contextual conditions shape these configurations of use?
3. What managerial and governance implications emerge from different configurations of ToC application?

Building on a literature review of planning and evaluation models, the taxonomy is structured around five fundamental dimensions: context sensitivity, causal architecture articulation, degree of methodological integration, functional and temporal orientation, and stakeholder involvement. This taxonomy is not intended as a normative grid, but as an analytical tool that allows different practices to be placed along a continuum, avoiding dichotomous readings between “correct use” and “misuse”.

To move beyond conceptual elaboration, the proposed taxonomy is subsequently tested through empirical analysis, allowing its analytical robustness to be examined in real organisational settings.

The empirical investigation is conducted through a qualitative multi-case study of 18 projects funded by the Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto (FCVA). The analysis is based on project documentation and semi-structured interviews with representatives of the organisations (a total of 36 meetings were held, including an introductory alignment meeting and one semi-structured interview per project), with the aim of reconstructing the concrete ways in which ToC is used and understanding the underlying motivations, constraints and organisational dynamics.

The results show that the adoption of ToC in the analysed TSOs is not a binary condition defined by the mere presence or absence of the tool, but rather a continuum of differentiated configurations. There are different ways of using the ToC, which vary in terms of the level of formalisation, depth of causal analysis, integration with monitoring systems, and degree of stakeholder participation. These differences are influenced by factors such as the organisation's previous experience with evaluation tools, available resources, the nature of the project, and the willingness to overcome cognitive limitations.

The contribution of the research is twofold. At a theoretical level it develops a multidimensional taxonomy that systematises the heterogeneous uses of the Theory of Change and reframes evaluative maturity as a situated and relational construct. By organising configurations along a continuum rather than into rigid categories, the study moves beyond normative prescriptions and offers an integrated framework capable of capturing hybrid and transitional forms of practice. In doing so, it advances a contingency-based understanding of maturity, showing that coherence with organisational and contextual conditions is more meaningful than progression toward increasing technical sophistication. The study bridges literature-based systematisation with qualitative empirical analysis, demonstrating the interpretative robustness of the taxonomy through its application to real organisational cases. At a managerial level, it provides guidance for both TSOs and funding bodies in calibrating evaluation practices according to organisational capacities, project characteristics and institutional expectations, emphasising proportionality and contextual adequacy over formal complexity.

The thesis is structured as follows. After outlining the main approaches to planning and impact assessment, with particular attention to the Theory of Change, a review of the empirical literature and the research gap that motivates the study is presented. Subsequently, the proposed taxonomy is introduced and the methodological design adopted is described. The final chapters report the results of the empirical analysis and discuss their theoretical and managerial implications, highlighting limitations and possible future developments.

1 Impact evaluation in the Third Sector: complexity and methodological challenges

The assessment of intervention effectiveness has become a central component of contemporary governance and organisational decision-making for Third Sector Organisations. As competition for funding and other critical resources intensifies, impact evaluation has become a necessary condition for accessing such resources. However, these organisations increasingly operate in dynamic and multi-actor environments — characterised by interacting actors, emergent dynamics, and contextual uncertainty — which pose significant methodological challenges. Traditional evaluation models, often grounded in linear causal assumptions and standardised indicators, frequently prove to be insufficient to capture the multifaceted nature of social change.

Within this evolving landscape, the concept of social impact has progressively shifted from a regulatory and predictive exercise toward a broader governance-oriented practice. Impact assessment has expanded beyond ex-ante estimation to include ongoing monitoring, management, and strategic learning across the lifecycle of social interventions.

This chapter examines the institutionalisation of impact evaluation in the Third Sector, explores the characteristics of complexity and their implications for evaluation practice, and reviews the principal methodological approaches and criteria that inform contemporary impact assessment frameworks.

1.1. The institutionalisation of impact evaluation in the Third Sector

The origin and the definition of the concept of “social impact” are not univocal; they are the result of an evolution that, over several decades, saw the progressive shift from

the traditional philanthropic approach, mainly based on ethical principles and value-based missions, to more structured and formalised methodologies able to quantify, measure and report the changes produced by public, private and third sector interventions (Grieco et al., 2015; Jönsson, 2013).

The original understanding of social impact is given by Burdge and Vanclay in 1996:

“Social impact assessment can be defined as the process of assessing or estimating, in advance, the social consequences that are likely to follow from specific policy actions or project development, particularly in the context of appropriate national, state, or provincial environmental policy legislation.” (Burdge & Vanclay, 1996, p. 59).

According to them the social impact assessment was born as a predictive exercise, aimed to anticipate the consequences of specific action policies or projects, in particular in the framework of environmental regulations.

Later, Vanclay himself broadened the concept to include management, monitoring and attention to sustainability and equity:

“Social Impact Assessment includes the processes of analysing, monitoring and managing the intended and unintended social consequences, both positive and negative, of planned interventions (policies, programs, plans, projects) and any social change processes invoked by those interventions. Its primary purpose is to bring about a more sustainable and equitable biophysical and human environment.” (Vanclay, 2003, p. 6).

With this statement, the author highlights that social impact evaluation cannot be limited to the ex-ante provisions, it should instead include processes of analysis, monitoring and ongoing management of social consequences, whether positive or negative, intentional or unintentional, with a view to contributing to a more equitable and sustainable human and biophysical environment.

These definitions underline two key elements: on one side, the plural nature of the concept which takes on different nuances depending on the theoretical and operational context; on the other side, its progressive shift from a technical and regulatory activity to a broader governance and development management approach.

1.1.1. From philanthropic logic to impact accountability

The evolution of the concept of social impact within the Third Sector reflects a broader transformation in the way social value is understood and governed.

In its original phase, the philanthropic and non-profit world operated on values of solidarity and common good, without analytical instruments able to translate such principles in observable and quantifiable results. Traditional accounting was limited to the representation of use of financial and patrimonial resources, excluding social or environmental effects produced by organisations, in fact, those effects were considered only in exceptional cases, for example reputational damages, reductions in shareholders' value, and therefore were not the subject of systematic measurement (Lingane & Olsen, 2004).

From the 1980s and 1990s onwards, growing awareness of these limitations intersected with broader institutional transformations. The emergence of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and the diffusion of performance-oriented management practices contributed to expanding the evaluation perspective. Organisations increasingly began to consider the impacts of their activities not only in economic terms, but also in social and environmental dimensions, giving rise to a progressive institutionalisation of reporting practices oriented toward transparency and accountability (Lombardo et al., 2019). In parallel, reforms associated with New Public Management introduced standardised approaches to results-based management, reinforcing a culture of measurement and comparability across sectors (Trasciani & Petrella, 2025). Within this evolving landscape, innovative tools emerged to operationalise social value in more structured ways. Approaches such as Social Return on Investment (SROI), sought to monetise the social and economic value generated by interventions, translating complex outcomes into financial terms understandable to funders and policymakers (Jönsson, 2013; Lombardo et al., 2019). Similarly, Emerson's (2003) notion of "blended value" emphasised that economic, social, and environmental dimensions of value are inherently interconnected¹. These developments marked a shift toward performance-based representations of impact, aligning Third Sector practices with broader managerial logics.

Within this context, the transformation also reshaped the meaning of accountability. Social impact evaluation progressively became an accountability information strategy through which organisations demonstrate to whom they are accountable, for what

¹ Emerson (2003) argues that the traditional conception of economic and social value being distinct or even in conflict with each other must be overcome. An approach of this type, in fact, remains anchored to a linear and static measurement logic, which attempts to "freeze" the value at a given moment, without grasping its dynamic and transformative nature.

outcomes, and how resources are used. The measurement and communication of social outcomes thus extend beyond philanthropic transparency, becoming mechanisms through which organisations manage legitimacy, negotiate stakeholder expectations, and secure ongoing support. In this sense, impact evaluation has been described as a widely accepted “rational myth”: a practice that confers institutional legitimacy and signals professional credibility, even when its implementation is complex and resource intensive (Handley, 2025).

Today, social impact assessment constitutes a central pillar of reporting and strategic management within the Third Sector. Demonstrating impact is frequently a prerequisite for accessing funding and maintaining stakeholder trust, and it plays a crucial role in sustaining organisational legitimacy (Vanclay, 2024; Golini et al., 2017). At the same time, the emphasis on measurable performance reflects a broader cultural shift: from mission-centred narratives rooted in solidarity to structured accountability systems grounded in evidence, comparability, and results. This institutionalisation of impact evaluation provides the backdrop against which contemporary methodological frameworks have developed and continue to evolve.

1.1.2. Why impact evaluation matters for Third Sector Organisations

For Third Sector Organisations (TSOs), impact evaluation is no longer a peripheral technical exercise but a structural condition for survival, legitimacy, and strategic development. In increasingly competitive funding environments, the ability to demonstrate measurable outcomes often determines whether organisations can access and sustain external resources. As highlighted in recent research on social impact evaluation in small non-profit organisations, impact reporting frequently becomes a prerequisite for attracting donors, foundations, and institutional partners (Handley, 2025). This generates a structural paradox: organisations with limited resources may struggle to implement sophisticated evaluation systems, yet without documented evidence of impact they are significantly less likely to secure new funding opportunities. Impact evaluation thus becomes intertwined with organisational sustainability.

Beyond funding access, social impact evaluation operates as a multidimensional accountability mechanism. Third Sector Organisations are accountable upward to funders and regulators, downward to beneficiaries and communities, and internally to boards and staff. These accountability directions often involve competing

expectations and normative tensions (Handley, 2025; Trasciani & Petrella, 2025). Impact evaluation provides a structured framework through which organisations articulate for whom they are accountable, for what outcomes, and how resources are translated into social value. In doing so, it transforms mission statements into communicable evidence, aligning internal governance with external scrutiny.

The relevance of impact evaluation is also closely linked to issues of legitimacy and trust. In contexts where public confidence in institutions is fragile and funding is contingent upon demonstrated effectiveness, reporting on social impact contributes to constructing organisational credibility. As observed in studies of non-profit accountability systems, impact evaluation functions not only as a measurement device but as a recognised institutional practice that signals professionalism and stewardship (Handley, 2025). Empirical studies further show that non-financial performance dimensions, such as stakeholder satisfaction, perceived social image, and goal achievement, are central to organisational effectiveness in Third Sector institutions (Gehring, 2024; Bejarano-Chalá et al., 2025). Measuring impact therefore reinforces social legitimacy by making visible the value created beyond financial statements.

At the managerial level, impact evaluation enhances strategic decision-making and organisational learning. Structured monitoring and assessment practices support clearer mission definition, alignment between strategy and objectives, and more deliberate management of social initiatives. Comparative research on social initiatives has shown that organisations engaging in systematic assessment practices tend to exhibit stronger alignment between mission and strategy and more structured managerial processes (Koljatic & Silva, 2010). In this sense, impact evaluation enables leaders to move from intuition-based management toward evidence-informed governance, facilitating adaptation and long-term effectiveness.

Finally, impact evaluation plays a crucial role in rendering visible forms of public value that escape traditional financial metrics. Recent research on non-economic public value creation emphasises that organisations generate multidimensional contributions — including empowerment, knowledge diffusion, social cohesion, and long-term community benefits — that cannot be reduced to purely monetary indicators (Greven et al., 2025). Systematic assessment allows these dimensions to be articulated, documented, and communicated, reinforcing the organisation's broader societal role. Impact evaluation thus becomes a mechanism through which organisations translate

intangible social contributions into recognisable forms of value, without reducing them solely to monetary terms.

Taken together, these dimensions explain why impact evaluation has become structurally embedded in the governance of Third Sector Organisations. It is not merely a reporting obligation, but a central component of how contemporary non-profits define, justify, and sustain their social mission.

1.2. Complexity in social interventions

Impact evaluation in the Third Sector unfolds within environments that are rarely stable or linear. Social and community-based interventions are embedded in dynamic systems characterised by multiple interacting actors, contextual contingencies, and evolving objectives. Understanding the nature of complexity is therefore a necessary step before addressing the specific challenges that evaluation faces in such settings.

1.2.1. Defining complexity in social and community contexts

Social initiatives and development interventions are always embedded in specific contexts. These contexts exist along a spectrum, ranging from relatively simple situations, characterised by stable cause–effect relationships and easily observable dynamics, to highly complex environments marked by interacting variables, emergent behaviours, and radical uncertainty (Verhoeff et al., 2025).

An intervention can be defined as complex when it involves a high number of interacting elements, when the behaviours required from practitioners and beneficiaries are multiple and difficult to coordinate, and when outcomes unfold across different levels with considerable variability (Connell & Kubisch, 1998; Dawson & Suich, 2025). In healthcare settings, for example, complexity may derive from the interaction of multiple conditions, treatments, and professional roles. In community-based initiatives, trajectories of change are intertwined with economic, political, cultural, and relational dimensions. Unlike simple contexts, which can often be analysed through linear input–output models, complex settings are better described as social-ecological systems (Dawson & Suich, 2025). In such systems, relationships are neither linear nor proportional: small changes may generate disproportionate effects, while significant interventions may produce limited or delayed observable outcomes. Outcomes rarely stem from isolated variables; rather, they emerge from the dynamic

interaction of multiple factors (Spangenberg, 2014). Moreover, system boundaries are fluid: projects constantly interact with their broader social, political, and economic environments, which in turn influence their trajectory (Chasanah et al., 2024).

The distinction between simple and complex situations has been further elaborated in the literature on complexity science. The Cynefin framework (Snowden & Boone, 2007), for instance, differentiates between simple, complicated, complex, chaotic, and disordered domains according to the nature of cause–effect relationships. While simple and complicated contexts allow for analysis based on known or discoverable causal patterns, complex contexts are characterised by emergent and only retrospectively understandable relationships. In such environments, action must often precede full understanding, and learning occurs through iterative adaptation rather than through the application of predefined best practices.

Taken together, these characteristics (non-linearity, interdependence, fluid boundaries, stakeholder multiplicity, and emergent dynamics) illustrate why social and community-based interventions cannot be adequately understood through deterministic and mechanistic models alone. Instead, they require analytical perspectives capable of accommodating uncertainty, contextual variability, and the evolving nature of social change.

1.2.2. Implications for evaluation: from challenges to criteria

The characteristics described above translate into specific challenges for evaluation practice: when interventions operate within complex social systems, evaluation cannot be conceived as a purely technical exercise aimed at measuring predefined outputs; rather, it must confront structural difficulties that shape both the design and interpretation of evidence.

A first and central challenge concerns attribution: the capacity to determine the extent to which observed changes can be attributed to a specific intervention rather than to external influences. In contexts characterised by multiple interacting variables and simultaneous initiatives, isolating the net effect of a single action becomes inherently problematic (Dawson & Suich, 2025). Particularly in community-based and multi-actor interventions, outcomes often result from the interplay of organisational decisions, stakeholder behaviours, contextual shifts, and external events. Under such conditions, establishing clear-cut causal boundaries is rarely straightforward.

This structural difficulty directly informs the first evaluative criterion: the need for credible causal reasoning. The question is no longer simply whether an outcome can be strictly attributed to an intervention, but how convincingly the contribution of that intervention can be articulated. Traditional counterfactual approaches, such as Randomized Controlled Trials (RCTs), have been regarded as the “gold standard” for attribution (Copestake, 2024; Maxwell, 2004). Yet in complex social settings, their application is often constrained by practical, ethical, and conceptual limitations (Connell & Kubisch, 1998; Tsantila et al., 2023). Moreover, experimental designs may determine whether change occurred without fully explaining the mechanisms through which it unfolded (Trampusch & Palier, 2016).

In response, methodological reflection has progressively shifted from a strict attribution logic toward a contribution-oriented perspective. Rather than seeking definitive proof that an intervention alone produced a given outcome, evaluation increasingly aims to construct plausible, evidence-informed explanations of how change occurred (Weiss, 1995). As Connell and Kubisch (1998) argue, this involves reconstructing the links between activities, intermediate results, and longer-term outcomes, demonstrating how these connections are supported by empirical evidence and coherent theoretical assumptions. From this standpoint, attribution becomes less a matter of definitive proof and more a process of reasoned inference supported by triangulation and contextual analysis. As Pawson (2006) suggests, this reflects a broader epistemological shift from linear causality toward a configurational understanding in which outcomes emerge from interacting factors.

A second challenge derives from the non-linearity of change processes. Interventions rarely unfold through simple cause–effect chains; instead, they may trigger feedback loops, chain reactions, and tipping points that reshape trajectories in unpredictable ways (Rogers, 2008). Impacts may emerge gradually, unexpectedly, or in forms not originally anticipated (Verhoeff et al., 2025). This dynamic complicates the interpretation of results and requires evaluative frameworks capable of accommodating emergent and adaptive pathways rather than assuming linear progression.

This structural feature directly informs the criterion of causal logic. In complex social contexts, evaluation cannot rely on implicit or overly simplified representations of how change is expected to occur; rather, it requires explicit articulation of the causal

pathways linking inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes, and broader impacts. Traditional linear models, such as the Logical Framework Approach, structure causality through hierarchical sequences that provide clarity and managerial coherence (Barau & Olukosi, 2011; Russo & Rindone, 2023). However, their rigidity has been criticised for oversimplifying social dynamics and obscuring what Vogel (2012) terms the “missing middle” (i.e. the poorly articulated transition between outputs and outcomes) (Bakewell & Garbutt, 2005; Gasper, 2000).

In complex settings, cause–effect relationships are often understood only retrospectively and may depend on contextual contingencies and interacting mechanisms (Snowden & Boone, 2007). As illustrated by the iceberg model (Apgar et al., 2017), visible outcomes are frequently shaped by underlying structures, patterns, and assumptions that remain unexamined unless made explicit. From this perspective, robust causal logic does not imply linear determinism, but rather the capacity to render assumptions transparent, to acknowledge multiple and interacting pathways, and to subject causal hypotheses to continuous scrutiny. Accordingly, in complex social interventions, causal reasoning becomes less an exercise in linear engineering and more a reflective process of hypothesis formulation and iterative learning (Funnell & Rogers, 2011).

Third, the multiplicity of stakeholders introduces another degree of normative complexity: social interventions frequently involve beneficiaries, practitioners, funders, volunteers, and community actors, each holding different expectations and criteria for success. As De Wit (1988) suggests, project success is partly a social construct, shaped by the perceptions and satisfaction of key actors involved. In Third Sector settings, where legitimacy and community trust are central, the perceived value of an intervention may be as significant as formally measured outcomes. Evaluation must therefore navigate diverse and sometimes competing interpretations of impact.

This normative plurality directly affects what is considered measurable and meaningful. The criterion of measurability therefore extends beyond the technical question of data availability to include the selection of outcomes that reflect different stakeholder perspectives. Traditional evaluation approaches tend to privilege “hard” indicators, which are tangible and easily quantifiable metrics such as economic outputs or employment data (Dawson & Suich, 2025; Castiglioni et al., 2020). However, in many social and Third Sector contexts, the most significant effects manifest in “soft”

forms that are intangible, relational, or subjective. These may include changes in social cohesion, empowerment, trust, individual aspirations, or psychological well-being (Castiglioni et al., 2020).

Guidelines in Social Impact Assessment explicitly recommend considering this broader spectrum of effects. Vanclay (2003, p. 8), for instance, argues that assessment should encompass impacts on people's lifestyles, culture, health, well-being, and even their fears and aspirations. Such dimensions are particularly relevant in community-based interventions, where long-term change unfolds through relational and behavioural processes rather than solely through immediately observable outputs.

The distinction between tangible and intangible outcomes further complicates measurement: immediate economic benefits do not necessarily translate into perceived improvements in well-being (Kuvan & Akan, 2005), while intangible factors such as fairness, recognition, or empowerment may be decisive for long-term sustainability (Scholtz & Slabbert, 2018). This multiplicity of meanings calls for evaluative designs that can integrate both quantitative and qualitative evidence, as well as incorporating stakeholder voices into the definition of relevant outcomes.

Although proxy indicators and monetisation strategies, such as those adopted in SROI methodologies (Lombardo et al., 2019; Lingane & Olsen, 2004), attempt to make intangible effects comparable, they also introduce elements of subjectivity and risk reducing complex social processes to simplified numerical representations (Ruff, 2021; Jönsson, 2013). For this reason, the literature often adopts a hierarchy of effects, distinguishing between outputs, outcomes, and impacts (Clark et al., 2004; Atsalikorn et al., 2023), thereby recognising that different types of change require different forms of evidence.

In this light, measurability in complex social contexts becomes not only a technical issue, but also a normative and participatory one: it requires explicit reflection on whose perspectives are being measured, which dimensions of change are prioritised, and how different forms of evidence can be integrated into a coherent evaluative framework.

Finally, temporality represents a further structural challenge. Many meaningful effects of social interventions materialise only in the medium or long term and may not be immediately observable at the conclusion of a project (Rode et al., 2022). Short-term indicators may capture outputs or intermediate outcomes, but systemic

transformations often require extended time horizons (Verhoeff et al., 2025). This temporal layering complicates the alignment between funding cycles, reporting requirements, and the actual rhythms of social change.

This temporal challenge directly informs the criterion of adaptability. If change processes evolve over time and cannot be fully anticipated *ex ante*, evaluation cannot be confined to static assessments conducted at predefined milestones. Rather, it must function as a dynamic and iterative process, capable of accompanying implementation and responding to emerging evidence. In complex settings, evaluation should not merely verify compliance with initial objectives but support ongoing learning and strategic adjustment. Rigid planning frameworks that emphasise baselines and endlines often produce *ex-post* judgements that are useful for accountability yet limited in their capacity to inform improvement (Rode et al., 2022). As Gasper (2000) observes, instruments such as the Logical Framework Approach may risk becoming “lock-frames” when their initial structure discourages revision once objectives and indicators have been fixed. However, uncertainty is intrinsic to complex social systems, and evaluation must therefore enable adaptive strategies rather than assume stability (Copestake, 2024).

Within this perspective, adaptability entails the capacity to revise assumptions, adjust pathways, and reinterpret evidence in light of contextual shifts. Frameworks that treat intervention logic as a revisable hypothesis are better suited to supporting iterative learning (Connell & Kubisch, 1998). In this sense, adaptability transforms evaluation from a retrospective reporting mechanism into a continuous feedback process embedded within organisational practice.

Taken together, the challenges of attribution, non-linearity, stakeholder multiplicity, and temporality illustrate why evaluation in complex social contexts cannot rely solely on rigid and linear models. They clarify the need for structured yet flexible frameworks capable of making causal assumptions explicit while remaining open to revision.

1.3. Overview of impact evaluation approaches

The methodological challenges discussed above have led both scholars and practitioners to develop an increasingly diversified range of evaluation tools. Despite the proliferation of models, the literature confirms that a single, universally accepted,

classification system is still missing (Grieco et al., 2015), primarily because every categorisation depends on the specific variable or analytical lens chosen by the researcher (Copestake, 2024; Maas & Liket, 2011). Therefore, to clarify the distinct contributions of different approaches, the overview below organises the main methodological families according to the primary evaluation challenges discussed above in this chapter.

Quantitative methods aim to establish causal links through experimental or quasi-experimental designs: Randomized Controlled Trials (RCTs) and difference-in-difference models represent classical examples of strategies able to estimate the impact by comparing treatment and control groups (Copestake, 2025); nevertheless, when these instruments are applied to complex contexts their effectiveness is reduced, due to high costs, methodological rigidity, difficulties in replicating controlled conditions, and, in some cases, ethical issues (Dawson & Suich, 2025). For these reasons, the literature developed in parallel qualitative approaches, oriented towards capturing the procedural and interpretative dimension of the interventions. Techniques such as the Most Significant Change² method, in-depth interviews and focus groups, allow evaluators to build subjective narratives and to bring unexpected changes to light, enhancing the perspectives of the actors involved (Davies & Dart, 2005; Lecomte et al., 2024; Yin, 1992, in Weiss, 1995). These approaches represent the traditional division between numerical causal inference and narrative/contextual understanding: Table 1.1 shows that quantitative methods aim at attribution through counterfactuals, while qualitative methods capture complexity, stakeholder perspectives, and unintended outcomes.

In the last decades, the tendency has been not to contrast these two methods, but to integrate them, giving rise to the so-called mixed methods approaches, where quantitative and qualitative elements are combined complementarily. It is possible to distinguish between quantitative prevalence models (quant-led), in which qualitative data support the robustness of statistical analysis (Castiglioni et al., 2020), and qualitative prevalence models (qual-led), in which numerical data reinforce interpretations based mainly on theoretical and narrative logics (Copestake, 2025).

² According to Davies & Dart (2005), the MSC is a participatory monitoring and evaluation method based on collecting stories of change from the field and jointly discussing the most significant ones. It engages stakeholders throughout the programme, fostering reflection and a shared focus on the impact.

Another area that has become increasingly important is that of theory-based approaches, which focus on the explication and verification of causal logics underpinning an intervention. As underlined by Matta et al. (2024), “TBE is a term that describes a family of approaches to the evaluation of interventions that have as a common denominator the use of an explicit theory as an instrument for answering questions about whether a program works, and also how and why it does” (p. 111). This set includes widely used tools such as the Theory of Change, born as a process that clarifies assumptions and makes explicit intermediate steps (Connell & Kubisch, 1998; Vogel, 2012), the Logical Framework Approach, which organises objectives in a linear hierarchy of goal, purpose, outputs and activities (Bakewell & Garbutt, 2005; Barau & Olukosi, 2011), and the Realist Evaluation, which emphasises the relationship between context, mechanisms and outcomes (Pawson & Tilley, 1997).

Along with these methodological families, approaches oriented towards quantifying and monetising the value generated by interventions have become widespread, attributable to the category of value-based methods. Among them, the Social Return on Investment (SROI) is one of the most common: it calculates a ratio between value created and resources invested, trying to attribute an economic dimension to social and environmental benefits (Lombardo et al., 2019). The difference with respect to classical approaches such as the Cost-Effectiveness Analysis (CEA) lies in the fact that SROI explicitly includes non-market dimensions and introduces stakeholder involvement in the definition of outcomes (Lingane & Olsen, 2004).

Finally, it is important to remember that the assessment process is strongly influenced by institutional frameworks, which establish standardised criteria for evaluation. The OECD offers useful tools, as the Glossary of Key Terms in Evaluation or the PESTOL model (Project Evaluation on Strategic, Tactical and Operational Levels) that identifies relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, impact and sustainability as key elements in the evaluation (Zidane et al., 2016), along with guidelines that serve as intergovernmental standards for learning purposes (Rode et al., 2022; Vanclay, 2003). Similarly, the European Union has systematised the use of tools such as Project Cycle Management and Logical Framework to ensure uniformity and transparency in the allocation and monitoring of structural funds (Golini et al., 2017; Russo & Rindone, 2023). Table 1.1 highlights the approaches that aim at monetising or standardising impact, providing tools for accountability and comparability across contexts.

Family	Most relevant tools	Challenge addressed	Key contribution
Quantitative	Randomized Controlled Trials (RCTs)	Attribution (isolating net effect)	Establish counterfactuals, provide strong causal inference
	Quasi-Experiments (before–after, matching, diff-in-diff)	Attribution	Offer feasible alternatives when RCTs are not possible; balance rigour with practicality
Qualitative	Case studies	Stakeholder multiplicity	Provide in-depth understanding of processes and contextual factors
	Most Significant Change (MSC)	Stakeholder multiplicity; unintended outcomes	Collect and select stories of significant change, stimulating reflection and shared learning
	Focus groups & interviews	Stakeholder multiplicity	Capture diverse perspectives, facilitate participatory evaluation
Theory based	Theory of Change (ToC)	Non-linearity; stakeholder multiplicity; temporality	Make assumptions explicit, map intermediate outcomes, foster iterative learning
	Logical Framework Approach (LFA)	Attribution; accountability	Provide structured hierarchy of objectives
	Realist Evaluation (RE)	Non-linearity; attribution	Identify “ <i>what works for whom, in what circumstances, and why</i> ”
Value-based methods	Social Return on Investment (SROI)	Attribution (deadweight, displacement); temporality	Monetise social/environmental value; stakeholder-centred; calculate social value ratios
	Cost-Benefit Analysis (CBA)	Attribution; accountability	Compare monetary costs and benefits to assess efficiency (Monton et al., 2025)
	Cost-Effectiveness Analysis (CEA)	Efficiency; temporality	Compare alternative costs to achieve common outcomes (Monton et al., 2025)
Policy frameworks	OECD DAC criteria	All challenges (standardisation)	Establish five standard criteria: relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, impact, sustainability
	EU PCM & LFA	Attribution; accountability; temporality	Enforce structured planning and transparency in funding allocation

Table 1.1 - Overview of impact evaluation approaches

Taken together, this overview shows the plurality of methodological approaches available for impact evaluation, highlighting that in complex social contexts, the choice of method cannot be universal or prescriptive, but must be aligned with the nature of the intervention, the organisational setting, and the specific evaluative purpose.

1.4. The relevance of LFA and ToC in Third Sector evaluation

The plurality of evaluation approaches outlined above reflects the complexity of social interventions and the multiplicity of evaluative challenges faced by Third Sector Organisations (TSOs). However, not all methodological families respond equally to the structural conditions under which TSOs operate. In contexts characterised by limited resources, intangible outcomes, non-linear change processes, and multi-layered accountability pressures, certain approaches prove particularly relevant. Among the wide range of available tools, the Logical Framework Approach (LFA) and the Theory of Change (ToC) stand out as especially suitable for Third Sector settings. Unlike purely counterfactual designs, which focus primarily on establishing whether an impact has occurred, these approaches emphasise the articulation of how and why change is expected to unfold. In doing so, they respond directly to the core challenges of complexity discussed in the previous sections.

TSOs frequently operate in unstable social environments, pursuing long-term improvements in areas such as education, health, inclusion, or community well-being, outcomes that are often intangible and difficult to measure exclusively through economic indicators. For this reason, evaluation in these contexts requires frameworks that move beyond linear sequencing and explicitly explore causal mechanisms, underlying assumptions, and contextual conditions. Such frameworks must be capable of mapping intermediate outcomes and clarifying the links between operational activities and long-term impact, providing a structured yet flexible representation of change processes.

Moreover, these organisations must balance multiple forms of accountability: they are accountable upward to funders, downward to beneficiaries, and internally to boards and staff. The Logical Framework has become widely institutionalised as a tool for upward accountability, offering a structured matrix that summarises objectives, activities, indicators, and assumptions in a format that facilitates monitoring and

comparability. The Theory of Change, in turn, supports learning-oriented and participatory forms of accountability, enabling organisations to involve stakeholders in articulating and revising their underlying assumptions about change.

Finally, in increasingly competitive funding environments, TSOs must demonstrate not only that impact is measurable, but that it is theoretically grounded and strategically coherent. Articulating robust models strengthens the credibility of an intervention by making explicit the logical connections between activities and expected outcomes, even when experimental designs are not feasible. Similarly, the use of frameworks such as the LFA and the ToC enhances organisational transparency and legitimacy, signalling methodological awareness and strategic clarity to external stakeholders.

Taken together, these characteristics explain why LFA and ToC occupy a central position in contemporary Third Sector evaluation practices. They offer a balance between the methodological rigour required by funders and the reflective flexibility needed to navigate complex social change processes. For this reason, the following chapter examines these two approaches in greater depth, analysing their conceptual foundations, structural characteristics, and underlying assumptions.

2 Logic Models for Impact Evaluation: Theory of Change and Logical Framework Approach

The realm of impact evaluation, particularly for complex interventions, necessitates robust conceptual tools to articulate pathways of change and measure programmatic effectiveness. Among the most prominent tools, there are the Theory of Change, not as a discrete invention but rather as a conceptual evolution within the broader tradition of theory-driven evaluation, and the Logical Framework Approach, originally developed as a structured methodology to enhance planning, implementation and monitoring in development projects. While both aim to clarify the logical relationships between activities, outputs and intended outcomes, they differ substantially in the origins, structure and approach.

This chapter examines each approach in depth and provides a comparative overview based on the literature review.

The process of article selection was conducted with the aim of building a literature base that was both comprehensive and relevant to the objectives of this thesis. The initial database chosen was Scopus, which provides extensive coverage of peer-reviewed journals and offers advanced filtering options across different disciplines; thanks to its interdisciplinary nature, it allows the inclusion of contributions not only from development studies and social science, but also from economics, management and engineering.

The search was initially restricted to works published *after 2015*, in order to focus on recent developments and avoid relying on outdated sources. Moreover, the following filters were applied:

- Subject Area: *Social Sciences; Business, Management and Accounting; Engineering; Economics, Econometrics and Finance;*
- Document type: *Article and Review;*

- Language: *English*.

Studies such as book chapters or conference papers were excluded to ensure a consistent level of academic quality and conclusiveness within each document studied.

Eight initial queries were defined to capture different perspectives on the use of impact assessment tools.

- Q1: *"Logical Framework" OR "LFA" AND "Impact Assessment"*;
- Q2: *"Logical Framework Approach" OR "LFA" AND evaluat**;
- Q3: *"Theory of Change" OR "ToC" AND "Social Impact"*;
- Q4: *"Theory of Change" OR "ToC" AND "Impact Assessment"*;
- Q5: *"Theory of Change" OR "ToC" AND "Logical Framework" OR "LFA"*;
- Q6: *"Social Value Chain" OR "SVC" AND "Impact Assessment"*;
- Q7: *"Social Value Chain" OR "SVC" AND "Logical Framework" OR "LFA"*;
- Q8: *"Social Impact Assessment" AND methodology*.

These queries produced a wide set of results, which were screened by title and abstract to assess their relevance.

In a second phase, the review process was expanded through snowballing, the technique that systematically analysed the references cited in the initial articles. This strategy enabled the inclusion of older key studies that did not appear in the initial Scopus results but were repeatedly cited by influential contributors. This step broadened the scope of the review. Duplicates were removed and non-accessible sources were excluded to maintain consistency.

As the literature review progressed, three central dimensions emerged as particularly relevant for the purpose of this thesis:

1. the adoption and applicability of ToC and LFA in complex contexts;
2. their integration with other impact evaluation tools;
3. the incorporation of counterfactual logic as a methodological element.

A complementary search was carried out to identify further articles that addressed these dimensions, ensuring that the final dataset of literature not only reflects general applications of ToC and LFA, but also provides a sufficiently broad and diverse foundation to examine both the practical uses and the evolving debates surrounding these two models.

2.1. Origins, structure and objectives of the Theory of Change

The origin of the Theory of Change (ToC) can be traced to the broader tradition of theory-driven-evaluation, not as a discrete innovation but rather as a conceptual evolution in response to the limitations of traditional theory-based evaluation models in capturing complexity of social change processes.

From the 1930s, the need began to arise to better understand how complex interventions work, alongside the desire to explore the implicit logic behind them, how they interact with context and how they can be improved through evidence-informed learning. The growing interest matured in the next decades leading to significant contributions from Kirkpatrick in the 1950s, Huey-tsyh Chen in the 1980s and especially Carol H. Weiss in the 1990s. The latter laid the theoretical foundation for what would later become known as the Theory of Change (Chen & Rossi, 1987; Weiss, 1972, 1995; Coryn et al., 2011; De Silva et al., 2014; Breuer et al., 2015).

In his work “Evaluation Research: Methods of Assessing Program Effectiveness” of 1972, Weiss states that all social programmes inherently operate on a theory, which means they are all based on explicit or implicit theories about how and why the program will work. The challenge is that these theories are often implicit or tacit, with participants proceeding intuitively rather than having carefully thought the underlying assumptions. By making these theories explicit, evaluations can become more rigorous and meaningful.

However, the formalisation and the diffusion of the Theory of Change occurred in the 1990s, thanks to the work of Aspen Institute Roundtable on Community Change. The paper aimed to respond to the evaluation challenges faced by Comprehensive Community Initiatives (CCIs), complex and multi-level interventions with the objective to produce systemic social change; in fact, traditional evaluation options were judged insufficient to capture the depth and interrelationship of these initiatives. For this reason, the authors, Connell and Kubisch proposed the new framework (Connell & Kubish, 1998), rooted in Weiss earlier conceptualisations. They defined the ToC “*simply and elegantly as a theory of how and why an initiative works*” but extended it into a systematic and cumulative framework that connects activities, intermediate outcomes, long-term goals and contextual conditions. Moreover, they highlighted that

this was not an invention but an evolution of ideas from Weiss, Chen, Bickman, Patton, Yin, and others who had long advocated for evaluation grounded in a theory.

To capture the essence of the theory, Weiss used a quote from Kurt Lewin: “*nothing as practical as a good theory*”, sustained later by Connell and Kubish to explain that well-articulated theories are not just academic exercises but essential tools for planning, implementation, and evaluation, especially in complex and dynamic social settings.

Since its initial development, the Theory of Change has been increasingly adopted across multiple disciplines, including community development, philanthropy, public health, education, and impact investing (Jackson, 2013). Organisations like ActKnowledge and the Centre for Theory of Change have played a key role in advancing the diffusion of this approach, while simultaneously offering guidance on its implementation within diverse sectors (De Silva et al., 2014). Major international donors, such as the Gates Foundation, DfID and Comic Relief, have institutionalised ToC in their planning and evaluation practices, acknowledging its dual value as both a strategic tool and a mechanism for fostering continuous learning (Breuer et al., 2015).

When applying the Theory of Change to an intervention, its structure is typically presented both as a visual map (Figure 2.1) – or a diagram – and narratively, accompanied by a detailed written explanation. The visual representation is crucial to outline the causal pathways through which change is expected to occur, while the narrative summary helps to explain these pathways, describe assumptions and provide contextual information.

The key elements for the development are:

- The impact of the programme. At the very top a ToC usually shows the overall “vision”, which represents the real-world change an initiative aspires to bring into being. This is the ultimate long-term goal, towards which the intervention may contribute but often cannot achieve solely on its own.
- The long-term outcomes, these portray the key changes expected to be achieved by the program itself, consisting of the primary focus for evaluation.
- The short/medium-term outcomes are the sequential, logical steps or preconditions that must occur to achieve the long-term ones. They describe the change in behaviours, attitudes, and skills that result directly from the program's activities. ToCs typically distinguish between proximate outcomes (immediate

results), intermediate outcomes (mid-term changes), and long-term outcomes (final program-attributable results).

- The causal pathways, which illustrate the logical sequence through which inputs and activities lead to outputs, and subsequently, to intermediate and long-term outcomes, culminating in the desired impact. By explaining *how* the intervention works, they constitute the Theory of Change's heart.
- The outputs, the direct, immediate, concrete and measurable results created directly from the activities, such as products or services.
- The activities and intervention components, they denote the concrete actions taken, the operations, procedures, processes and events implemented, utilising resources (inputs) to achieve its objectives. The ToC connects these intervention components directly to the expected outcomes, explaining how change happens within the program's context.

The Theory of Change's structure shows a strong similarity with the Social Value Chain (SVC), a model which extend the traditional economic value chain with the aim to include the social dimension in interventions (Bjorndal et al., 2014; Camoletto et al., 2017; Ainsworth et al., 2023). The SVC describes in a sequential form the process thought which resources and activities are transformed into outputs, outcomes and impacts, following the equivalent causal ToC logic. What differentiates the two tool is the specific focus on social values and on non-monetary impacts, measurement and analysis objects at the same level with the economic aspects (Ainsworth et al., 2023).

From a theoretical point of view the SVC is intended as a process of creating growing social value, articulated in phases on social innovation and inclusion, benefits' sharing and emancipation of communities (Kassim & Habib, 2020). In parallel, it can function as a framework for selecting key stakeholders and impact categories, such as human, social, natural and economic capital, allowing more systematic evaluation of a project or organisation social performance (García-Muiña et al., 2022).

In this sense, the Social Value Chain offers a linear descriptive base, useful to map how activities generate value and to identify evaluation points along the chain. The Theory of Change, while sharing its logical structure, it represents an extension and evolution of it: it enriches the model by introducing the explication of assumptions, the analysis of contextual factors and the involvement of stakeholders in a participative process. Therefore, if the SVC offers the "backbone" for the sequential representation of social

value, the ToC transforms this linearity in a theoretical and adaptive framework, able to explain the change mechanisms, support the continuous learning and guide strategic decisions in complex contexts.

The ToC is often developed using a backward mapping approach, a method widely used in project management where the desired result is determined first, and then, the steps to achieve that outcome are planned in reverse order. Therefore, the approach starts with the long-term objectives or desired vision and then it works backward to identify the necessary intermediate outcomes, causal pathways, and activities required to achieve those objectives.

During all this process, the assumptions about what needs to be in place for the Theory of Change to occur are made explicit, as well as the contextual factors influencing the ToC. The former are a crucial element in the ToC, showing the conditions that need to be true for the causal pathways to operate as expected and for the desired impact to be achieved. Identifying the assumptions helps in testing them during evaluation and understanding potential barriers to implementation. The latter – the contextual factors – are considered throughout the program's development, monitoring, evaluation and learning as external elements that can positively or negatively influence the intervention and its outcomes.

Moreover, for every expected step or precondition on the causal pathway, specific, measurable indicators – that can be both qualitative and quantitative – are identified to empirically test whether change has occurred.

Ideally, the development process is typically collaborative and participatory: it involves stakeholders (e.g., program staff, management, service users, experts, evaluators) whose insights are crucial for a deeper understanding of program mechanisms and uncertainties; their engagement provides improving quality, feasibility and ownership of the ToC. The degree and the methods can vary, some ToCs are co-created, while others are developed by evaluators or funders alone; they can involve workshops with stakeholders, consultations with experts and service users or internal discussion with program staff.

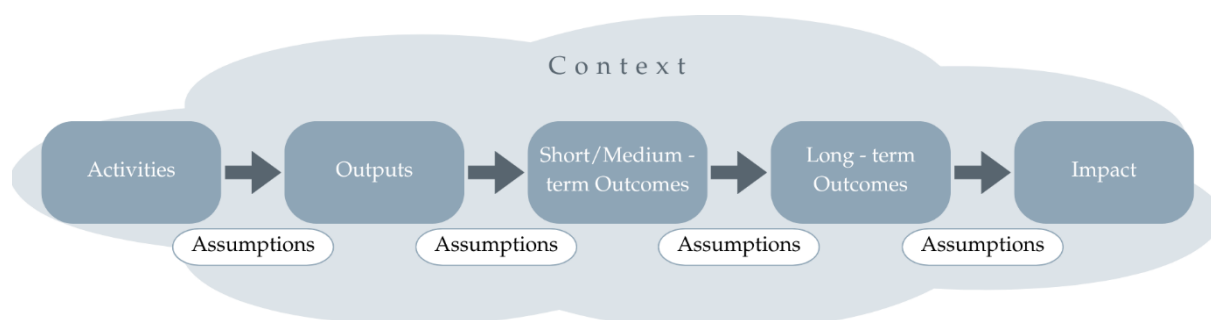


Figure 2.1 - Theory of Change, visual map

As mentioned above, the ToC approach emerged as a pragmatic response to several core needs, such as: to explain the causal basis for interventions, not just that they are correlated; to capture intermediate outcomes and understanding the “missing middle” between program activities and long-term impact; to account for contextual factors and their mediation or moderation of intervention effects; to enhance stakeholder engagement and reflection through participatory theory-building; to enable the adaptive learning throughout the program cycle.

For this reason, the ToC was specifically designed to overcome the limitations of precedent tools which were often considered too mechanistic, linear and narrow in explanatory focus: although they drew a picture of inputs, outputs and outcomes, they rarely included evidence about how to achieve the desired changes.

Understanding the structure of the Theory of Change clarifies *how* the model works, but to fully catch its value it is important to consider its intended purpose and examine the *why* the model it is used. The ToC’s objectives reveal its role as a practical, adaptive and analytical tool that goes beyond simply mapping activities and outcomes.

One of the main objectives of the Theory of Change is the understanding of causal mechanisms and pathways, to assist in defining what an intervention is and how it should be delivered. In fact, by beginning with the end in mind and working with backward induction, it helps to uncover what needs to be done; this process leads to the definition of what the program wants and how it intends to achieve its end. This involves digging into the intervening mechanism that connect program activities to outcomes.

Another central purpose of the analysed tool is guiding intervention design and development: the ToC’s method of application results in the clarification of the program’s goal, objectives and strategies from the outset, supporting the design of

contextually suitable strategy adapted to local needs, ensuring interventions are explicitly designed to be embedded with their local context, taking into account available resources and potential political or social issues.

Furthermore, ToC plays a crucial role in making underlying assumptions explicit. It requires articulating the conditions that must hold true for the causal pathways to achieve its intended impact, helping to identify potential barriers and necessary pre-conditions. This is particularly important because historically, only a minority of impact evaluation explicitly outline these assumptions, highlighting a significant gap in generating robust evidence.

The ToC also excels at integrating context into the intervention's theory: by telling designers and evaluators to consider the social and economic background, it aids track how these factors may facilitate or not the implementation and the outcome. The focus on context is fundamental for adapting programs to diverse settings and understanding why interventions may have heterogeneous effects.

In terms of monitoring and evaluation, the discussed methodology provides a comprehensive framework throughout the program cycle: it guides the selection of most appropriate and relevant outcomes and helps in defining specific and measurable indicators for each step, allowing for precise understanding of the intervention's progress and which components are the most critical.

Moreover, the ToC fosters an iterative learning and adaptation process. It should be viewed as a "working hypothesis," subject to regular revision and refinement as new information emerges or contextual factors change. This dynamic approach supports continuous program adjustments and improvements during implementation.

The participatory nature of ToC development often involving different stakeholders helps achieve a deeper understanding of program mechanisms, fosters a shared vision, builds consensus, and secures buy-in from all involved parties. It also significantly improves internal organisational communication and facilitates external dissemination and advocacy. The participatory process ensures that the intervention is more relevant, feasible, and sustainable, aligning the program with the demands of society and its stakeholders.

Finally, the clarity and comprehensive nature of a well-developed ToC are crucial for generating evidence that can inform policy decisions, support the effective scaling of successful interventions, and ensure their transferability to diverse contexts, thereby

contributing to broader development goals. A deep understanding of the mechanisms is key for convincing decision-makers to implement interventions more widely. ToCs allow for a structured approach to informing the selection of outcomes and related evaluation measures for future iterations or similarly structured programs, making the resulting ToC a valuable example for developing theoretical frameworks for complex interventions.

2.2. Origins, structure and objectives of the Logical Framework Approach

The origin of the Logical Framework Approach (LFA) dates to 1969, when the consulting firm Practical Concepts Incorporated for the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) developed it in response to the increasing demand for improved planning, monitoring and evaluation of international development (ID) projects, which often lacked clear objectives definition and measurable outcomes (Practical Concepts Incorporated, 1979). The introduction of the new framework aimed to ensure that all project activities contribute coherently to clearly defined goals with a top-down approach.

If the development of the Logical Framework originated with the USAID in the late 1960s, its actual conceptual foundation lies in earlier planning techniques for the US military, which was then adapted for the US space agency NASA, particularly during the preparation of the moon travels.

In the following years, numerous international institutions started to use and adapt the framework: European organisations started to use the tool in the 1980s, and lately, in the 1990s it was required by many donors for grant applications. Recent studies confirm the widespread adoption of LFA in international development projects and NGOs highlighting both benefits and limitations (Golini et al., 2017; Golini et al., 2018; Rodríguez-Rivero et al., 2020; Rodríguez-Rivero et al., 2021)

To illustrate the extent of the diffusion, the United States has applied the general planning process since 1993 with the Government Performance and Results Act (WH, 1993) and the European Union has adopted it to allocate and monitor structural funds (European Commission, 2004).

As the Logical Framework expanded across countries and institutions, it gradually evolved showcasing broader shifts in the history of international development planning. From its original formulation in the 1969, three successive generations³ have been developed between the 1970s and the early 2000s.

The first generation has been born with the objective to provide a common vision and understanding of the project, resulting in a 4x4 matrix known as the Logframe (LF). The four rows were identified as “Goal”, “Purpose”, “Outputs” and “Inputs”, while the four columns as “Narrative Summary”, “Objectively Verifiable Indicators”, “Means of Verification” and “Assumptions”. This structure intended to summarise the why of an intervention, what are the results and outputs and how to reach them, and the base assumption to fulfil to carry out the project. Despite the LFA proved to be an effective tool, some pitfalls led first to its decline, and then to the proposition of a second version. The main shortcoming was the confusion around the terminology: the difference between goals and purposes was not clear to most; the objectively verifiable indicators were often misunderstood and difficult to determine; the assumptions were often ill-defined. The main focus was the LF as final result undermining the dynamic nature of projects and also the lack of stakeholder involvement compromised its validity.

By the early-to-mid 1980s, a second generation of the LFA was proposed with many improvements initiated by the German Technical Cooperation (German Technical Cooperation, 1987, 1989). A more practical, participative and systematic method, called the ZOPP approach (from the German, Zielorientierte Projektplanung) or, in English, the GOPP (Goal-Oriented Project Planning) Approach, was composed of six steps: (1) situation analysis, (2) stakeholders’ analysis, (3) problem analysis, (4) objective analysis, (5) alternative analysis, and (6) activities planning. Although the stakeholder involvement increased, the terminology remained unclear and the

³ The concept of generation was introduced in Sartorius, 1996. According to Sartorius (1996), the first-generation LFA is characterised mainly by the logframe as a result. The second generation puts more emphasis on the team process leading to the logframe, while the third generation can be identified mainly by its application to international research projects, the recognition of the need for better training, and the availability of integrated and easy-to-use software for its implementation. However, here the classification is based more on the terminology used in the logframe and the steps of the approach.

objectively verifiable indicators difficult to obtain, keeping the rigidity and the difficulty to integrate the tool with others.

In the mid-to-late 1980s, a third generation of the LFA emerged thanks to the renewed interest of many development organisations, providing support to systematic thinking while promoting creative and participative analysis. Today this generation is widely recognised and used as an effective project design, evaluation, and management tool, thanks to the high level of stakeholder involvement, and the priority of acknowledging the process leading to the LF more than the LF per se as result. However, there are still some problems that persist today, such as the uncommon and unclear terminology and the lack of integration with other project management tools. These aspects will be discussed more in detail in the next chapter, meanwhile, Table 2.1 provides a summary of the evolution of the three generations of the Logical Framework Approach.

	1 st Generation	2 nd Generation	3 rd Generation
Main aspect	LF as final result	A process leading to the LF	Defined steps adapted to the organisation
Improvements		- Steps leading to the development of the LF - Major stakeholders' involvement	- Better defined steps leading to the development of the LF - Training available
Limitations	- Unclear terminology - OVIs difficult to determine - Lack of stakeholders' involvement - Rigidity - No clear process	- Unclear terminology - OVI difficult to determinate - Rigidity - No integration with other PM tools	- Uncommon and unclear terminology - OVI difficult to determinate - No integration with other PM tools - Unclear responsibility in the process

Table 2.1 - Evolution of the three generations of the Logical Framework Approach

Source: Couillard et al., 2009

After having traced the LFA's historical development through its three generations, it is essential to examine the structural core. Despite the various adaptations the approach has undergone over time, the primary tool underpinning the LFA is the Logical Framework Matrix, the Logframe, which structure has remained central and recognizable. It is organised in a 4x4 matrix, where each row corresponds to a

hierarchical level of project objectives and each column to elements that elaborate, validate and contextualised those objectives. (Table 2.2).

The rows, the hierarchical levels of the logic model, are organised top-down as follow:

- *Goal (Impact)* is the higher level, most of the time long-term oriented, development objective toward which the project is expected to contribute; it is not under direct control of the intervention, but it provides the overall vision and justification.
- *Purpose (Outcome)*, which represents the main objective and immediate effect that the project aims to achieve at the end; compared to the previous, this outcome is more specific and measurable, and it can be directly connected to the project's outputs.
- *Output*, the set of concrete deliverables resulting from the lifespan of the project, these are the tangible products and services that the activities are expected to produce.
- *Activities (Inputs)*, which describe the actual task, the processes and the resources allocation necessary to produce the outputs; they can be referred to human, financial and material means required to implement the project.

The columns have a more explanatory nature, in fact, they are:

- *Narrative summary*, which is a brief description of the intended actions and results for each row.
- *Objectively Verifiable Indicators (OVIs)*, they can be quantitative or qualitative measures with the aim to specify what evidence is required to verify the reach of the objectives at each level; OVIs are central for monitoring and evaluation, serving as benchmarks of progress.
- *Means of Verification (MoV)*, that can be referred also as Sources of Verification, this column outlines the sources and methods used to collect information about the indicators, they can be reposts, databases, surveys, field visits or any documentation providing evidence of progress.
- *Assumptions*, constituting the critical external conditions that could affect progress from one level of the framework to the next; they are outside the direct control of the project, and they reflect the uncertainty and the complexity serving as a prompt for proactive risk management.

	Narrative Summary	Objectively Verifiable Indicators (OVIs)	Means of Verification (MoV)	Assumptions
Goal (Impact)				
Purpose (Outcome)				
Output				
Activities (Input)				

Table 2.2 - Logframe Matrix

The matrix generation and filling guide developers to think systematically about the project's internal logic, causal pathways, and the conditions that must be met for success at each stage. The defined structure allows for precise definition of the "theory of action" (or "program theory"), making implicit knowledge explicit, and facilitating a better understanding of how and why certain parts of an intervention are effective.

The core objective of the Logical Framework Approach can be summarised as the purpose to provide a clear and comprehensive overview of a project intervention, encompassing its design, planning, management, monitoring and evaluation throughout its entire lifecycle (Coleman 1987; Gasper 1997).

The instrument is built to assure logical coherence within a project, in fact, the vertical logic connects the activities through outputs and outcomes to the overall goal, ensuring that lower-level achievement (the activities) contribute directly to higher-level objectives (the outputs, purposes and the impact). On the other hand, the horizontal logic guarantees that each objective is paired with traceable indicator, valid verification sources and assumptions. Thanks to that, the LFA outlines the *why* (goal/impact), *what* (outcomes/outputs), and *how* (activities/inputs) of a project as one of its primary aims: the systematisation and structuring of the planning process. Furthermore, the rigorous logical structure helps to identify any missing link or inconsistency, allowing for remedial stops to be taken before or during implementation, thereby reducing the risk of failure.

Beyond planning, the LFA is designed to make monitoring and evaluation (M&E) effective: the robust framework tracks progresses and achievements making it suitable throughout the project cycle, from identification to ex-post evaluation, harmonising

information flows among project managers, staff, implementing agencies and funding organisations. To the latter it serves as indispensable tool to justify investments and grant application requirements, thanks to the provision of a clear set of expectations for what the work should achieve and a framework for reporting on progress and impact.

Finally, the Logical Framework serves to enhance clarity and communication among stakeholders: not only it promotes a shared vision and understanding of the project which is critical for successful collaboration and design-making, but also it fosters stakeholder participation and involvement at any level, especially during the problem analysis and objective setting stages.

Ultimately, the LFA's objectives extend to improving overall project performance and impact: if applied comprehensively and used with care it can significantly enhance a project's chances of achieving its intended outcomes and generating sustainable benefits for target populations.

2.3. Comparison between Theory of Change and Logical Framework Approach

Building on the fundamental understanding of both the Theory of Change (ToC) and the Logical Framework Approach (LFA) detailed in the previous sections of this chapter, this section delves into a comprehensive comparison between these two remarkable models for impact evaluation. While the main objective of both tools is to bring clarity and structure to the intervention planning and assessment, there are substantial differences ranging from their origins, distinct structures and application methodology.

A first considerable differentiation lies in how the evolution shape their structural configuration and the way each model is represented in practice.

The construction of ToC is typically presented as both a visual map, or diagram, and a narrative explanation: the first is crucial to outline the causal pathways of change, the latter, provides detailed clarification, describes assumptions and offers contextual information. The Theory of Change relies on a flexible format, allowing multiple causal pathways, different level of interventions and feedback loops which better reflect the complex reality of how interventions achieve impact.

Conversely, the Logframe is presented by a rigid 4x4 matrix which intends to summarise the why (goal/impact), what (purpose/outcomes, outputs), and how (activities/inputs), and the "base assumptions" necessary to carry out the project. This emphasises both a vertical logic – connecting activities through outputs and outcomes to the overall goal – and a horizontal logic – pairing each objective with traceable indicators, valid verification sources and assumptions.

Beyond their structural features, the two approaches diverge also in the way they involve stakeholders: they both engage with them, but with different emphases and historical experiences.

The strong stakeholders' engagement and reflection through participatory theory-building is crucial to develop the ToC by ensuring shared vision and improving the interventions' design to be more relevant, feasible and sustainable. Also, ToC purposes are to include internal organisation understanding, stakeholder communication, monitoring and evaluation (M&E), program development, adaptation and continuous learning: it is seen as a framework to set the stage for evaluation planning rather than an evaluation approach itself.

As for the LFA, the later generations surely put a lot of effort into the team process and stakeholders' involvement, given the fact that it was a central highlighted pitfall in the first versions. Today the Logical Framework is widely adopted by governmental agencies and NGOs because that is a prerequisite for funding from donors; for this very reason the LFA can be seen as a "brand" or "packaging" to satisfy funders, rather than an internally valued "thinking tool" for planning or learning as it is its primary purpose.

The role and engagement of stakeholders influence how each approach handles causality and outcomes, which represent a key distinction in ToC and LFA:

- The Theory of Change emerged specifically to explain the causal basis for interventions focusing, not just on correlation, but on how and why they work, capturing intermediate outcomes and understanding the "missing middle" between program activities and long-term outcomes. The "backward induction" approach leads to outcome-based evaluations rather than merely objective-based ones.
- The Logical Framework also describes the causal hierarchy, but a widespread criticism is to not always making explicit how the various components causally

link to achieve the ultimate goal. In fact, critics argue that, due to its linear cause-effect assumptions, the tool may not be suited for complex social development processes where relations are unpredictable and characterised by non-linearity (Uwizeyimana, 2020; Vadrevu et al., 2024). The LFA tends to focus heavily on intended effects and objectives, potentially neglecting unintended effects or unforeseen routes of change.

Finally, differences in the treatment of causality and outcomes are linked to each model flexibility, adaptation and integration with other evaluation systems.

The ToC can be described as inherently method-neutral, meaning it does not prescribe specific types of evaluation methods, making it flexible and suitable to be combined with other evaluative approaches, such as Realist Evaluation (RE) or path analysis (Bick et al., 2021; Matta et al., 2024).

Regarding the LFA, its static nature forms the basis of another common criticism: the difficulty in adapting during a project's life cycle or integrate with other project management tools. While there have been "reformulations" and "new versions" of LFA proposed to overcome these weaknesses, such as incorporating a time dimension or better defining indicators and means of verification, these limitations persist in practice.

The table below (Table 2.3) summarises the key comparative aspects between ToC and LFA.

Aspects	Theory of Change	Logical Framework Approach
Origins and conceptual underpinning	Evolved within the tradition of theory-driven evaluation to address the limitations of earlier models and to explain how and why interventions work.	Developed for USAID to improve planning, monitoring and evaluation by addressing weaknesses in project design in international development contexts.
Primary purpose	Clarify causal pathways, including intermediate outcomes.	Provide a structured, standardised framework for project planning, monitoring and reporting.
Structural configuration	Combination of visual map/diagram and detailed narrative. Flexible, allowing multiple causal pathways, feedback loops, and varying levels of intervention.	Rigid 4×4 matrix summarising goals, purposes/outcomes, outputs, and activities, paired with indicators, means of verification, and assumptions.
Stakeholders' engagement	Strong emphasis on participatory theory-building to ensure shared vision and relevance.	Stakeholder involvement improved in later versions. Engagement often driven by donor requirements rather than intrinsic organisational learning.
Logic of causality	Explicitly articulates causal links, assumptions and context: it uses backward induction to define outcomes before activities.	Describes a vertical and horizontal logic, but causal linkages may be implicit.
Approach to outcomes	Captures both intended and unintended outcomes, focusing on outcome-based evaluation rather than only objective achievement.	Focuses mainly on intended objectives, it may overlook unintended outcomes or alternative pathways of change.
Flexibility and adaptability	Method-neutral, easily combined with other evaluation approaches.	Static format and limited adaptability during project life cycle.

Table 2.3 - Main differences between ToC and LFA

3 Review of ToC and LFA's Applications

Building on the conceptual foundations outlined in Chapter 3, this chapter shifts the focus from the theoretical model of the Theory of Change (ToC) and the Logical Framework Approach (LFA) to their applications in real-world contexts based on the literature review. While the previous discussion focused on the origins, structures and objectives, here the aim is to understand how the two models have actually been applied and interpreted in real-world settings.

The empirical literature is examined across a set of recurring analytical dimensions that account for the diversity of applications observed. These dimensions capture how the Theory of Change and the Logical Framework Approach are differently interpreted, adapted and operationalised in practice. This approach makes it possible to go beyond a mere description of individual cases to highlight broader patterns of use: from linear, compliance-oriented applications to more sophisticated, learning-oriented, theory-based projects. Particular attention is given to the practical challenges emerging from empirical evidence and to how these challenges inform the evolution of both approaches; to the reasons why ToC is increasingly considered the reference tool in impact evaluation; and to the blurred boundaries between some uses of ToC and LFA.

Finally, the chapter concludes by pointing out gaps in the literature and by suggesting the need for a taxonomy of uses that can guide research and practice.

3.1. Case selection

The purpose of this section is to provide a concise overview of the empirical base underpinning the analysis and to introduce the scope of variation observed across the selected studies.

Among the literature selected following the criteria outlined in Chapter 3, only contributions that provided explicit insights into evaluation practices, methodological

approaches or conceptual discussion about Theory of Change and Logical Framework Approach were analysed in this chapter.

The corpus includes a diversified set of empirical applications of the Theory of Change and the Logical Framework Approach, drawn from academic and institutional sources, which together illustrate how these tools have been operationalised in a wide range of domains. Table 3.1 shows an overview of the empirical applications.

The review reveals heterogeneity in the application fields; however, in this thesis the literature will be analysed according to five analytical dimensions that better explain and capture the recurring patterns of variation in how ToC and LFA are designed and used.

Article	Model	Application field
Addoah et al., 2025	Theory of Change (ToC)	Analysis of deforestation policies in cocoa-producing companies in Ghana and Côte d'Ivoire
Apgar et al., 2017	Theory of Change (ToC)	Coastal-marine system in the Pacific, Malaita Province, Solomon Islands, focused on sustainable agriculture
Barau & Olukosi, 2011	Logical Framework Approach (LFA)	Agricultural development project; a proposed irrigation project supported by CIDA in northern Ghana
Barkat, 2019	Theory of Change (ToC)	Evaluation of a widening participation programme at the University of Birmingham (AEP)
Barnett et al. 2018	Theory of Change (ToC)	Social impact of Venture Capital Trust Fund (VCTF) investments in SMEs in Ghana
Bick et al., 2021	Theory of Change (ToC)	MapSan experiment on shared sanitation in Maputo, Mozambique
Burchett et al., 2024	Theory of Change (ToC)	Structural interventions for contraceptive use among adolescents
Camoletto et al., 2017	Theory of Change (ToC) / Social Value Chain (SVC)	Social housing (SH) initiatives in Italy. Case studies: 'Sharing' (Turin), 'Luoghi Comuni' (Turin), 'Figino Borgo Sostenibile' (Milan)
Chang, 2015	Logical Framework Approach (LFA)	Development of an evaluation framework for telemedicine programs, utilising LFA and a Fishbone Diagram
Chasanah et al., 2024	Logical Framework Approach (LFA)	Microfinance project (Revolving Loan Fund - RLF) in the district of Tegal, Central Java, Indonesia
Copestake, 2024	Theory of Change (ToC)	Impact assessment using mixed methods in international development
Couillard et al., 2009	Logical Framework Approach - Millenium (LFA-M)	The model has been successfully implemented at the Canadian Space Agency (CSA) and the Canadian Nuclear Safety Commission (CNSC). In one specific case, it was used to provide a concise overview of the Steam Generator

		Tubes Research Project (probabilistic assessment of leakage rates).
De Silva et al., 2014	Theory of Change (ToC)	Improvement of the Medical Research Council (MRC) framework for complex interventions
Gasper, 2000	Logical Framework Approach (LFA)	Planning and evaluation for a project on human rights and local police
Ledda et al., 2024	Logical Framework Approach (LFA)	Analysis of consistency between sectoral plans and climate change adaptation (CCA) objectives in Sardinia, Italy
Matta et al., 2024	Theory of Change (ToC)	Evaluation of a nationwide professional development (PD) programme in the education sector
Mayaud & Cosco, 2025	Theory of Change (ToC)	Assessment of the impact of paratransit services, for the elderly and disabled, on health
McLellan, 2019	Theory of Change (ToC)	China office of the International Forestry Foundation (IFF-China), focused on research for development (agroforestry)
Montano et al., 2024	Theory of Change (ToC)	EU-Interreg sustainable tourism initiative (EXPERIENCE project) in a pilot region
Ruff, 2021	Theory of Change (ToC) Social Return on Investment (SROI)	Impact assessment of "Our House" which provides stable housing and a sense of belonging to its tenants
Ruiz Lozano et al., 2021	Theory of Change (ToC) Social Return on Investment (SROI)	ROMI programme of the Fundación Secretariado Gitano (FSG) for the labour inclusion of the Romani population in Córdoba, Spain
Russo & Rindone, 2023	Logical Framework Approach (LFA)	Transport planning, in particular maritime passenger transport services in the Strait of Messina (Southern Italy, EU)
Sands & Aunger, 2024	Theory of Change (ToC)	Hand hygiene intervention (Mainspring study) in two medical-surgical teaching hospitals in the United States
Tsantila et al., 2023	Theory of Change (ToC)	Complex mental health interventions in the workplace (MENTUPP)
Vadrevu et al., 2024	Theory of Change (ToC)	Systematic review of Impact Evaluations (IEs) analysing the usage of TOCs and causal pathways in routine immunisation programmes in Low- and Middle-Income Countries (LMICs)
Vogel, 2012	Theory of Change (ToC)	International development; review of the use of ToC
Weitzman et al., 2002	Theory of Change (ToC)	Evaluation of the Urban Health Initiative (UHI) focused on enhancing the confidence of causal attribution within a comprehensive citywide health initiative

Table 3.1 - Overview of empirical cases

3.2. Theory of Change and Logical Framework

Approach: analysis of empirical cases

In this section, the selected literature is analysed through five analytical dimensions that allow the understanding of the application variety observed in the usage of the Theory of Change and the Logical Framework Approach.

The objective is not to describe each empirical study, but rather to highlight the differences and similarities that emerge from the various studies, emphasising how the two instruments are adapted and interpreted in different assessment contexts.

The review focuses on the following elements:

1. the sensitivity to the context;
2. the causal architecture;
3. the methodological and model integration;
4. the functional and temporal orientation;
5. the stakeholder engagement.

Through these elements, it is possible to distinguish between the most linear and prescriptive applications, typical of logframes and some ToCs, and more articulated and reflexive approaches.

This examination makes it possible to identify the underlying logic that determines the evolution of the two models laying the foundations for the taxonomy that will be developed in the next chapter. The analysis moves from the most external and contextual aspects of evaluation frameworks to the most internal and operational ones, in order to reflect the transition from environmental and structural features towards process-oriented and participatory dynamics, allowing for a comprehensive understanding of how ToC and LFA function across multiple levels of analysis.

3.2.1. Context sensitivity

The first dimension considered, the context sensitivity, assesses the extent to which the Logical Framework Approach and the Theory of Change incorporate the characteristics of the environment in which an intervention operates. It examines if the models treat contextual conditions (including institutional settings, socio-economic dynamics, cultural norms, resource availability, and multi-actor configurations) as a

neutral background or as structural variables that shape assumptions, mechanisms and outcomes.

Context-sensitive models explicitly embed environmental contingencies into the architecture of the theory, recognising variability, uncertainty and evolving system conditions; context-blind models, in contrast, assume stable and universal causal pathways, overlooking how contextual factors modify the plausibility, intensity or direction of change.

In the Logical Framework Approach, context sensitivity tends to manifest primarily through alignment across governance levels and coherence with pre-established plans, while contextual factors remain largely external to the structure of the logframe: local constraints, power relations, organisational capacities, cultural norms and forms of uncertainty are not incorporated into the causal logic but treated as surrounding conditions.

Empirical applications in the literature confirm this dynamic. In the irrigation and rural development project in Ghana (Barau & Olukosi, 2011), the LFA manages the context almost exclusively through the Important Assumptions column, which lists political, economic and institutional factors as “external conditions” to be verified. These elements do not fit into the vertical logic: they function as a simple warning mechanism regarding the validity of causal links, but do not explain how local socio-economic dynamics actually influence the mechanisms of transformation.

A similar limitation emerges in the Project for the Promotion of Human Rights and Democracy (Gasper, 2000): in the presence of stakeholders with divergent priorities and unstable political contexts, the logframe imposes a linear hierarchy of converging objectives, assuming a consensus that does not exist in many public interventions. The approach struggles to consider unintended paths, unforeseen effects and the impact of power relations or civil conflicts on the production of results. The result is an orderly but overly simplified representation, incapable of capturing the non-linear and contingent nature of change.

Therefore, the LFA treats contextual factors as external risks that can interfere with the causal chain, but not as dynamic variables that shape it from within; as a result, sensitivity to context remains limited and predominantly reactive, rather than analytical and incorporated into the very structure of the theory of change.

The Theory of Change reveals a broader spectrum of outcomes, from context-blind to context-sensitive. In less mature practices, the theory is formalised but weakly

operationalised: theory-driven reports dedicate limited space to the description of the context and the relationship between environmental factors, assumptions and results remains underdeveloped. Reviews signal how, even recognising in principle the role of local constraints and resources, many assessments do not explain how these conditions enter the explanation of change (Coryn et al., 2011).

The social housing “Our House” case, regarding a British organisation involved in housing support programmes for vulnerable people (Ruff, 2021), is an emblematic example: the adherence to a linear ToC device, centred on measurable transformations and target outcomes, made invisible decisive contextual dimensions — such as housing stability and heritage maintenance — that, for residents, constitute the most relevant and immediate outcomes; the model, overlooking the context, omits what the context makes essential.

In more developed and iterative practices, however, the ToC becomes deeply embedded in context: mechanisms are differentiated across settings, assumptions are derived from local contingencies, and multi-level dynamics are incorporated within the causal architecture. Under these conditions, the ToC is progressively adapted to reflect evolving environments, resource variations and socio-political conditions, enabling situated and contingent explanations of change.

In immunisation programmes in Low-and Middle-Income Countries (LMICs), Vadrevu et al., 2024 treat the context as a structural variable rather than a neutral backdrop. The review inspects whether evaluations incorporate context at three stages: program development, monitoring & evaluation, and learning. Rather than designing interventions, the study acts as a quality check on whether immunisation initiatives meet context-sensitivity “standards”, assessing how well programmes document and use contextual information to inform assumptions and causal pathways.

The PRIME programme, regarding the integration of mental health into primary care across five countries (De Silva et al., 2014), illustrates a strongly contextualised approach: a cross-country ToC provided an overall frame, while district-level ToCs were developed for each setting to capture local feasibility, resources and cultural acceptability. The district ToCs led to different, context-specific intervention choices, as replacing government health staff with trained community rehab workers where politically necessary, showing how embedding ToCs at subnational levels differentiates mechanisms across contexts.

Another example is given by the Aquatic Agricultural Systems (AAS) research (Apgar et al., 2017) that combined ToC with participatory action research to support learning in complex socio-ecological systems. The multi-hub experience demonstrated that what is transformative in one site may not be in another: local institutional roles, partnership dynamics and emergent pathways shaped outcomes. Making such emergent trajectories visible enabled adaptive responses and catalysed locally relevant change.

To conclude, context sensitivity distinguishes models that assume generalisable mechanisms from those that integrate environmental contingencies into their explanatory structure. The LFA, by design, privileges coherence and accountability across levels of governance while remaining relatively insensitive to contextual variability; the ToC can range from generic, weakly contextualised representations to dynamic and situated theories that continuously renegotiate assumptions, mechanisms and indicators in response to local conditions.

3.2.2. Causal architecture

The causal architecture dimension analyses the extent to which the evaluation model makes explicit, justifies, and organises the causal mechanisms linking activities to outputs, outcomes and impacts. It considers two elements: the formal structure of causal connections and how much the causal links are supported and justified by theoretical, empirical or experiential reasoning.

On the structural side, the dimension captures how change is organised: whether causal sequences are merely linear and descriptive or articulated through feedback loops, enabling conditions, intermediate states and contextual dependencies. On the justificatory side, it evaluates if causal links are simply assumed, or if they rest on explicit assumptions, empirical evidence, experiential insights, conceptual references or testable hypotheses.

In this sense, the dimension does not reward theoretical complexity per se, but the clarity, coherence and credibility with which causal reasoning is developed: a model reaches higher levels of maturity when it explains why and how change occurs, and when its causal propositions can be examined, questioned and potentially validated.

The Logical Framework was conceived as an instrument to ensure logical coherence and transparency in project planning, building the causality as a sequential chain of events: the so-called "*vertical logic*" establishes a mandatory progression in which the

resources invested in the project are transformed into products, the products contribute to the achievement of specific objectives, and these, in turn, contribute to the achievement of the overall goal. Such a setting, translated into the classical logframe as shown in the Agricultural Project Component of the Proposed Northern Region Rural Integrated Programme (NORRIP), implies a mechanistic view of change, where the causal relationship is linear, controllable and verifiable through objective indicators; the internal project's coherence is ensured by checking the correspondence between one level and the next: each result must be logically traceable to the activities that precede it. This is very useful for the management and monitoring of well-defined projects with clearly defined objectives, but it tends to reduce complexity, treating reality as a sequence of predictable events arranged in chronological order (Barau & Olukosi, 2011).

Similarly, in more recent applications, such as transportation planning for passenger maritime services in the Messina Strait by Russo and Rindone (2023), the LFA's logic continues to be based on sequential relationships, where inputs and activities systematically precede outputs and final results, reinforcing the idea of deterministic and easily measurable causality.

Moreover, in the case of mainstreaming climate change adaptation into sectoral plans (Ledda et al., 2024) the theoretical function of the LFA stays mainly verification-related: the theoretical reasoning is translated into a formal validation process, which is useful for ensuring strategic alignment, but not for exploring the chain of mechanisms that determine the effectiveness of an intervention

In the case of Theory of Change, the causal settings results to be more flexible but this potentiality is not always fully exploited: numerous empirical applications, especially in contexts where the ToC is adopted to respond to reporting requests or as a communication tool for funders, the model tends to replicate the same linearity of the logframe (Coryn et al., 2011).

In the "Our House" case (Ruff, 2021), for example, the ToC map is reduced to a simple chain of inputs, activities, outputs and outcomes, arranged horizontally, suggesting an orderly sequence of transformations rather than a network of dynamic relationships, limiting itself to explaining the logical steps without delving into the mechanisms that connect them. The result is a descriptive model, useful for clarifying general hypotheses of change but incapable of reflecting the real complexity of interactions between actors, contexts and processes.

In some experiences, the ToC remains implicit, meaning that the theory that guides decisions and actions is not formally represented, but can be inferred from the practices and insights of the actors involved. The literature refers to these as “Implicit ToCs” or “Implicit Theories”: they represent existing aspirations of the actors in a programme (e.g., scientists in a research project) and reflect how they conceptualise and practise their work; actors do not use the formal structure prescribed by ToC but they still imagine the future effects of their work and pursue them following an unspoken structure that is rarely made explicit (McLellan, 2021).

By contrast, in its most advanced applications, the Theory of Change is shaped as a theory-driven tool capable of representing causality in a generative and non-linear way, of formulating and testing causal hypotheses based on a combination of empirical evidence, theoretical knowledge and contextual data. It does not merely list the input–result passages, but it articulates the interconnections between different levels of change, recognising the presence of multiple paths and mutual feedback, justifying each link by a rationale based on previous research, consolidated theories or experimental data. Here the ToC applies the backward mapping, starting from long-term objectives and going back to the intermediate conditions and activities necessary to achieve them, until identifying the preconditions and mechanisms that make their implementation possible.

This approach is applied, for example, in the MENTUPP project, in the healthcare and organisational fields, which aims to improve mental health in the workplace through integrated interventions at the individual, organisational and community levels; here the ToC makes it possible to make visible the bidirectional and circular relations between results, highlighting how the change can emerge from simultaneous multi-level interactions rather than a simple linear progression (Tsantila et al., 2023).

The presence of multiple causal paths and feedback mechanisms represents a crucial step towards overcoming the deterministic view of traditional models, because change becomes the result of a combination of factors that interact within open and dynamic systems. In this sense the ToC becomes an interpretative model capable of capturing the multiple causes and equifinality of social processes, recognising that similar results can be achieved through different paths and that the trajectories of change can vary depending on the context. For this reason, the logical chain analysis does not focus on verifying the intervention's linearity, but on understanding the mechanisms that

connect actions, resources and results, and the conditions that determine their effectiveness.

Some methodologically integrated approaches reinforce the analytical capacity, combining the ToC with assessment tools oriented towards exploring causal mechanisms, such as Process Tracing or Realist Evaluation: these methods, applied in the EXPERIENCE European project, dedicated to promoting sustainable and inclusive tourism, allow evaluators to break down the chain and empirically verify hypotheses of causal links, highlighting how change derives from the interaction between actors, resources and contexts rather than from a simple sequence of actions (Montano et al., 2024). In this architecture the ToC represents a dynamic and revisable system of hypotheses, capable of adapting to new evidence and integrating qualitative and quantitative perspectives. Institutional literature itself, starting with the DFID Theory of Change Review (Vogel, 2012), emphasises that ToC must include a multiplicity of paths of change and actors involved, recognising the complexity of interactions between policies, contexts and processes.

In summary, the dimension of causal architecture highlights the presence of different tools' application, going from a logic of sequentiality to a logic of systemicity: the LFA tends to favour linear causality, which is useful for planning and reporting but limited in its explanatory power, while the ToC is able to represent the complexity of social processes, including mechanisms, conditions and feedback that account for the real ways in which change manifests itself, but in some cases such potential is not exploited.

3.2.3. Methodological and model integration

Methodological and model integration refers to the degree to which the evaluation device facilitates or requires integration with other evaluation approaches and data systems, as the combined use of quantitative and qualitative approaches, mechanism-oriented explanatory designs (e.g. Process Tracing, Realist Evaluation), counterfactual analyses or statistical models for hypothesis testing; and how this combination enables triangulation of results and informed review of the theory of action. It assesses whether the LFA or ToC acts as an isolated conceptual map or as part of a broader evaluative architecture that links theory, evidence and verification. The higher the integration, the greater the model's potential for empirical testing of causal links, for cross-validation of evidence and for learning along the cycle of the intervention.

In the Logical Framework Approach the methodological and model integration tends to be low. In fact, the LFA was born as a design and governance tool for objectives: it excels at defining indicators, means of verification and criteria of judgement for efficiency, effectiveness and impact, but the logical matrix itself, does not impose or guide the adoption of evaluative designs capable of testing mechanisms or of systematically combining different methods.

In applications such as the evaluation for agricultural project, the logframe provides to evaluators with an ordered structure to collect data and verify the objectives-results chain coherence, but the integration remains mostly organisational centred on measuring and reporting of specific parameters, rather than inferential construction (Barau & Olukosi, 2011). Also, in applications where the LFA is coupled with other instruments, as in the evaluation of telemedicine services (Chang, 2015) where the LFA is supported by cause-and-effect diagrams to order domains such as technology, quality, cost and satisfaction, the emphasis remains on formalising a structured and replicable approach; the articulation between methods and sources is designed to make evaluation efficient, not to support complex analytical strategies oriented towards discovering mechanisms.

In summary, the Logical Framework facilitates procedural cohesion of evaluation and the definition of metrics but hardly elevates the design to explanatory or counterfactual proof.

Regarding the Theory of Change, the majority of empirical evidence shows low and medium levels of integration: the theory is represented and sometimes used to define indicators, but the drawings do not provide for real testing of causal links nor for triangulation rich in process data.

The review on immunisation programmes in LMICs (Vadrevu et al., 2024) highlights that the ToC or a causal diagram appears only in a minority of the studies and, when present, are often not integrated in the heart of the analysis: quasi-experimental designs based on national surveys prevail and the absence of competing process evaluations prevents observing how the intervention influences intermediate hubs such as human resources, supervision or training. A similar deficiency emerges in the intervention for adolescent contraception (Burchett et al., 2024): even when the theory is formalised, rarely it is refined considering the data produced by the evaluation, a sign that the ToC sometimes remains an isolated conceptual framework, not yet based on empirical feedback cycles. In these cases, the methodological and model integration

is limited to an alignment between theoretical representation and indicators, without the design deliberately collecting rich process data or combining sources and methods to stress hypothetical links.

At the opposite extreme, are located the strongly integrated applications, where the ToC acts as a linkage between hypothesis, methods and data.

A first example regards the integration with the counterfactual analysis in the theory-driven evaluation: in the Urban Health Initiative (UHI) (Weitzman et al., 2002), the Theory of Change defined the intermediate/final expectations and outcomes and a comparison with control group was integrated to estimate the overall causal effect. This combination of ToC and comparative design compensates for the limits of each method: the counterfactual quantifies the effect, the theory explains the paths and orients the reading of the deviations between expected and observed.

A second profile is defined by the process evaluation of the MapSan trial on environmental hygiene in Mozambique (Bick et al., 2021) that use quantitative models to test the causal chain of the ToC. In the evaluation the multiple pathways map was subjected to path analysis to statistically verify the hypothesised structure, identify mediators and attribute deviations to weaknesses in theory or implementation. Here the theory becomes “accountable” to empirical proof, because each link in the chain is accompanied by measurable indicators and a coherent estimation strategy.

Finally, high levels of integration emerge in the mechanistic theorisation supported by the integration of data and theories in Matta et al. (2024) in the evaluation of the Swedish professional development programme Boost for Mathematics (BfM), in which, the ToC specifies the essential parts of the programme (teaching materials, collegial discussions, classroom practices) and guides a multi-source collection of evidence (videos, transcripts, tests). This study explicitly discusses methodological integration in two forms, which is necessary for mechanistic theorisation: data integration and theory integration. The former transforms unstructured materials into analysable variables, while the latter — combining, for example, curriculum and peer learning theories — allows formulating a unified mechanism on how engagement facilitation generates changes in student outcomes.

In summary, this dimension highlights that mapping is not the same as explaining. The LFA designs, optimises and measures, but rarely triggers analytical configurations able to test mechanisms or to systematically integrate multiple methods. The ToC, on the other hand, can remain a descriptive device if it is not deployed into a design that

claims its verifiability, but fully unfolds its potential when it becomes the engine of integration between theory, methods and data: it guides the choice of evidence, makes explicit the points to be stressed empirically, it orients the use of complementary quantitative and qualitative techniques and institutionalises review cycles in response to what the data reveal.

3.2.4. Functional-temporal orientation

This dimension examines how an evaluation model conceives, structures and uses the knowledge it generates, analysing both the primary function assigned to evaluation and the degree to which this function enables iterative learning and strategic adaptation. It captures whether the framework is designed mainly to ensure accountability and compliance by privileging performance reporting, standardised indicators and fixed ex-ante/ex-post cycles, or whether it operates as a learning infrastructure capable of informing sense-making, revising causal assumptions and adjusting the intervention while it unfolds.

From a functional perspective, it investigates what primary purpose is attributed to the evaluation framework and how this purpose guides the design, analytical depth and data collection. In the literature, different orientations can be found: models oriented towards compliance that tend to produce information on immediate outputs and expected outcomes, focusing on verification of planned results; and models oriented towards learning that generate deeper insights into mechanisms, contextual conditions and uncertainties, requiring designs that support causal inquiry and process-sensitive data.

From a temporal and operational standpoint, the dimension assesses the extent to which the model supports adaptation. Static configurations treat evaluation as a one-way reporting device, whereas adaptive configurations embed feedback loops, iterative data collection and cycles of revision, allowing the intervention to evolve in response to evidence, emerging constraints or unexpected pathways of change.

The existence of distinct models ranging from fixed and prescriptive ones and dynamic and reflective systems captures a long-standing debate in evaluation: whether frameworks are used to prove success – as control tool, with ex-ante/ex-post logic and standardised indicators – or to improve understanding and effectiveness – as a sense-making device capable of guiding cycles of investigation, reflection and adaptation.

In the Logical Framework Approach, historically, a “fixed” conception of the project prevails: its original purpose is managerial and administrative, it was originally conceived as a project management tool, developed to ensure logical coherence transparency and comparability between projects founded by international agencies, therefore, its evaluation purpose focuses on accountability. The LFA’s matrix formalises a predetermined trajectory of outputs and outcomes and, once approved, tends to become rigid in a results contract that leaves little room for substantial recalibrations, in fact, one of the major criticism it has to face, is the absence of a temporal dimension related to the static nature of the model, prioritising the vertical consistency and accountability over real-time adaptive management (Ledda et al., 2024). The acknowledgement that projects operate under conditions of uncertainty and that the tool requires inevitable adjustments has led to some attempts to update the framework. One example is the *Logical Framework Approach–Millennium (LFA-M)* proposed by Couillard et al. (2009)⁴. However, these revisions affect a system which, due to its origins and institutional uses, remains strongly oriented towards providing a “static view” useful for governance by objectives and formal control of results. Practically, the logframe better performs when the context is relatively stable and changes can be anticipated and channelled within indicators and means of verification defined in advance; when, on the other hand, the environment is dynamic and the mechanisms of change are uncertain or emerging, the rigidity of the framework slows down learning and adaptation, shifting the focus from discovery to compliance (Ledda et al., 2024; Couillard et al., 2009).

An example is given by the project to implement maritime passenger services in the Strait of Messina: the Logical Framework was used to linearly represent the design phases, intermediate results and final objectives of the intervention, allowing the correspondence between the allocated resources (around 30 million euros per year) and the performance obtained to be monitored; the primary objective was to ensure administrative transparency, accountability in public spending and the ability to compare with other transport plans (Russo & Rindone, 2023).

The same tension on the matter can be found in the Theory of Change, that, although it was designed as a tool for strategic analysis and reflection, it can be used in a reductive way when reporting needs prevail. When this happens, the ToC risks being

⁴ The *Logical Framework Approach–Millennium (LFA-M)* (Couillard et al., 2009) will be discussed in more detail later in this chapter.

frozen in the “*future perfect of quantitative targets*” (McLellan, 2021), which is a set of pre-defined quantitative targets pre-defined that absorb the space of impermanence and compress the exploratory horizon of the model. In such cases, the framework ceases to function as a revisable tool and becomes a grid of requirements that directs action towards what is most easily measurable in the short term, at the expense of sacrificing qualitative, procedural or long-term dimensions (Case ToC 2: M&E of the Food Security Fund by McLellan, 2021).

Some other studies outline how the ToC is often applied as a static design document useful for outlining the objectives and intervention logic being approved, and rarely it is updated based on the data collected during implementation. This is the case of the structural interventions on adolescent contraception (Burchett et al., 2024), where a ToC is constructed to justify the theoretical plausibility of programmes but not to empirically verify their theory of change, resulting in a formalisation oriented towards reporting to donors, which neglects the dynamic dimension of the process and the possibility of reviewing the model in light of the evidence generated.

Similarly, in the University of Birmingham's AEP, the ToC is mainly used as a framework for the ex-post evaluation of programme effectiveness: the theory guided the definition of research questions and data collection, but the overall function of the framework remained oriented towards verifying the results achieved rather than generating learning for subsequent phases (Barkat, 2019).

In contrast with those approaches, some ToC applications fully demonstrate their potential as a learning and causal investigation tool. In these applications, the ToC is conceived as a living document: an operational theoretical framework that is constructed, tested and modified in successive iterations, integrating learning cycles from piloting, process monitoring and formative evaluation.

The integration with the Medical Research Council's framework for complex interventions (De Silva et al., 2014) is a good example of this logic: development, feasibility, evaluation and implementation are not rigidly sequential phases but moments that interact with each other; the weakest hypotheses in the causal chain are tested with targets during the feasibility and piloting phase, and the theory is refined accordingly, to be presented for formal evaluation in a version that is already informed by evidence.

Institutional literature also highlights this perspective, with the “*ToC thinking*”, described as an organisational framework that should be regularly reviewed

considering monitoring, changes in context and strategic refocusing; when learning justifies deviations from the plan, resources should be transparently reallocated to what works (Vogel, 2012).

An example consistent with adaptability emerges in the *Mixed-methods impact evaluation in international development practice* paper, by Copestake (2024). In qual-led settings, the evaluation design is explicitly aimed at timely learning and adaptive management: ToC review cycles, driven by dense qualitative feedback, support incremental adjustments and problem-driven iterative adaptation, a logic particularly suited to open-ended programmes and policies that require exploration and gradual adjustment rather than confirmation of rigid hypotheses. In this application, the ToC is not a static outcome of planning, but a mechanism of collective sense-making that makes visible the tensions between theory and practice and institutionalises deliberate spaces for review in the governance of the programme.

Between the two extremes, there are hybrid applications, where external accountability and internal learning coexist and reinforce each other: this is the case observed in the ROMI Programme (Fundación Secretariado Gitano, Spain), dedicated to the work and social inclusion of a roma population (Ruiz Lozano et al., 2021). The evaluation approach, based on the combination of Social Return on Investment and Theory of Change, made it possible to quantify the social value generated by the programme, but also to initiate an internal process of reflection and improvement: while responding to the objectives of transparency and reporting to funders, the path of building the ToC was participated and oriented towards understanding individual and collective paths of change, facilitating the identification of strategic levers for future inclusion policies.

Another example of dual function emerges in the rural development and natural resources management (AAS) sector in the Barotse Floodplain in Zambia: the use of ToC was intended for both design (looking forward to describe how the change was expected to occur) and evaluation (looking backward to describe how the change had occurred). This dual temporal orientation implies that ToC is a dynamic process and a product, used to build models of change that make the underlying assumptions explicit and allow the programme to be learned and adapted (Apgar et al, 2017).

In conclusion, the evaluation purpose of the framework shapes the methodological profile of the intervention: an accountability orientation tends to privilege compliance logics, standard indicators, reporting-aligned time windows, and a data architecture

centred on immediate outputs and outcomes; a learning orientation requires deeper designs, explication of mechanisms and conditions, selection of process-sensitive intermediate indicators, use of mixed methods and suitable techniques to test uncertain causal links, iterative data collections and feedback devices.

While the purpose of the LFA is confined in the reporting and accountability, the ToC can be oriented to both and the choice is not neutral, it determines what questions are asked, what data is collected and what evaluative knowledge becomes possible.

3.2.5. Stakeholder engagement

Stakeholder engagement considers the role of beneficiaries, implementers, funders and evaluators in the design and theorisation of the framework. It distinguishes between top-down approaches, where the logic model is defined by external experts, and participatory or dialogic processes, where diverse actors co-construct the causal model. Participation shapes both the legitimacy and the ontological diversity of the framework, influencing its ability to capture multiple perspectives on change, to anticipate enabling conditions and operational barriers and, ultimately, on the feasibility of solutions in real contexts.

In the literature regarding the LFA, this dimension is particularly investigated: the reference manuals recall as an important characteristic its capacity to summarise an in-depth and participatory discussion with stakeholders, however, concrete applications show a top-down setting, especially in development aid chains, where large agencies require standardised logframes from smaller executing partners, the process is reduced to a documentary analysis and a technical fulfilment, and leaves little room for negotiation of meanings with local stakeholders. The literature reports how this top-down dynamic limits inclusiveness and tends to crystallise the model as a function of conformity, rather than learning (Ledda et al., 2024).

Evidence of inclusion limited to managerial levels can be found in the case of passenger maritime services in the Messina Strait (Russo & Rindone, 2023), where the clear and controllable representation of the plane is favoured to support decisions and reporting, overlooking the inclusion and participation of final users (commuters, operators and local communities).

In line with previous observations, the Theory of Change shows wider variability: it can replicate hierarchical configurations or, conversely, open co-creation spaces.

The less inclusive applications occur when the model is guided by the organisations' priority or by implicit format biases, resulting in a narrow mapping of perspectives.

An example is given by the study on the design and implementation of forest-focused supply chain policies (FSPs) in cocoa supply chains in Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana (Addoah et al., 2025), where the planning of corporate strategies to tackle deforestation insufficiently involved small growers: inclusion has often been limited to preferences on marginal aspects (which seedling varieties to distribute or which community micro-projects to finance), without a co-design of the crucial choices on traceability, enforcement and monitoring, which remained top-down.

In a similar manner, the application led by expert of the ToC in the "Our House" case, produced a linear visualisation of desirable outcomes, overlooking central dimensions for residents (such as relational stability and daily care) (Ruff, 2021). In these contexts, the low inclusiveness narrows the semantic field of the ToC, reduces local ownership and weakens the sensitivity of the model to the mechanisms that actually support change.

In participatory models, on the contrary, ToC becomes a process of shared investigation and a provisional product, continuously renegotiated.

In the MENTUPP project (Tsantila et al., 2023), for example, the Theory of Change was built via workshops with an interdisciplinary consortium that brought together clinicians, researchers, employers and workers' representatives: this participatory architecture fostered consensus on outcomes, rationales and assumptions, reducing information asymmetry between organisational levels and strengthening the cultural adherence of psychosocial support tools.

Another evidence is given by the acute-care nurse-centred hand hygiene intervention in US hospital (Sands & Aunger, 2024), where, using a theory-driven approach, the ToC was constructed together with internal stakeholders (nurses, facilitators, hospital managers) so that the impact mechanisms reflected routines, constraints and real incentives of the departments; the evaluation design therefore integrated process and context measures, strictly informed by the logic of the actors.

In the AAS programme in Zambia and the Solomon Islands (Apgar et al., 2017), the ToC was employed alongside participatory action research (PAR) as a co-inquiry device. The paper states that: *"In AAS, TOCs were developed with stakeholders looking forward to describe how change was expected to happen (program design), as well as looking backwards to describe how change had happened (evaluation)."* (Apgar et al., 2017, p. 18)

meaning that local communities, researchers and agencies co-constructed causal narratives, making assumptions and enabling conditions explicit and keeping adaptation spaces open.

Finally, in Italy, in social housing initiatives supported by philanthropic foundations (Camoletto et al., 2017), dialogic evaluation approaches have integrated the ToC with moments of multilateral confrontation (residents, schools, committees, traders, administrations) to bring out relational needs of neighbourhoods and translate them into shared intervention logics; here the design process itself becomes the most powerful tool of social progress, because it builds common languages and mutual legitimacy.

The effects of participation are directly reflected in design depth and data architecture: in top-down regimes, indicators favour standardised outputs and proximate outcomes, functional to comparability and periodic reporting; in co-creative configurations, the Theory of Change incorporates mechanisms and preconditions observable by actors, requires process, context and experience data, and institutionalises feedback loops that make the model reviewable. Inclusivity increases ownership and feasibility by aligning tools and practices with the situated knowledge of implementers and beneficiaries, improving the cultural adherence of solutions, helping to identify operational obstacles, and allowing timely reallocations of resources when evidence contradicts assumptions. Nevertheless, such strengths come with a cost: they require time, competences and ability to manage conflicts between different visions; however, in complex systems, these investments are often what allow the valuation to stop trying only to prove success and actually begin to explain it.

3.3. Current debate on models

The following section provides a concise and critical synthesis of the literature analysis's main findings, to focus on the current debate on the Logical Framework Approach and Theory of Change, and the cross-cutting challenges that condition their use in real impact assessment contexts. The objective is twofold: on the one hand, to bring out the recurring critical issues that explain why and where the models fail; on the other hand, to clarify the reasons for the increasing centrality of ToC in evaluative practice, without evading the criticisms and possible evolutionary trajectories of LFA, nor the zones of overlap between logics that, under certain conditions, may be complementary.

3.3.1. Challenges

The literature analysis confirms that both the Theory of Change and the Logical Framework Approach are a widely applied and recognised key instruments for planning and evaluation, however, their operational translation does not come without obstacles: various difficulties emerge when moving from the conceptual level to practice. The challenges can be grouped in five main domains, contextual and systematic, conceptual, methodological, functional and learning, and organisational and participatory. Each of them affects, on different degrees, the analytical dimensions described in the previous section.

Contextual and systematic challenges are strictly connected to the dimension of context sensitivity. In the LFA case, one of the most frequently cited limitation in the literature is its inability to manage and adapt to complexity, chaos and uncertainty. Many authors highlight how the intrinsic linear structure and the deterministic underlying logic lead to an oversimplification of the reality, the omission of key elements, such as cultural aspects and the totality of stakeholders' objectives. The model is, in fact, characterised by a cause-effect logic which assumes clear and expected relations between input, output and impacts, while international and social development projects require complex, non-linear and often unintended relationships. Moreover, the LFA's basic assumptions frequently do not reflect the current reality, or they result to be inflexible in respect of dynamic situations, making the approach unsuitable for monitoring and evaluation (M&E) of complex systems, which instead call for more dynamic models, adaptable and able to incorporate innovative solutions. In the case of ToC, the operational translation from conceptual framework to practice is also challenging: the literature reports difficulties in moving from theory to implementation, especially when too detailed, it risks becoming unmanageable, collecting outcomes and indicators until becoming a logframe more complex than useful. On the other hand, an excessively simplified representation can lead to overlook relevant contextual factors or to propose patterns that are too linear in respect to the complexity of the intervention. The evaluation phase can also be difficult because it is not always possible to identify and measure the relevant outcome in advance of the intervention, especially when dealing with intangible dimensions, and the evaluation is not always able to fully detect the intermediate steps in the change process.

Conceptual challenges affect mainly the causal architecture. Overall ToC application in real cases confirm its ability to adapt to very different contexts, serving as a useful tool for both design and evaluation; however, two main challenges emerge: the need for greater methodological rigour to prevent ToC from remaining a superficial exercise; and the importance of integrating participatory perspectives and process data to capture the real complexity of interventions. Therefore, while the ToC represents a valuable device to make explicit the change hypothesis and to facilitate the dialogue among stakeholders, its use often reveals ambiguities in terminology and weak theoretical grounding. A first challenge is the absence of a standardised definition and a univocal terminology: concepts as logic model or logical frameworks are sometimes used indifferently with the Theory of Change, creating ambiguity and complicating its quality and complexity evaluation. Adding to this, there is the sophisticated construction process that requires specific skills, time and resources; when such capacity is lacking, the construction of casual assumptions remains narrative rather than analytical, and the link between theory and evidence can be lost.

Similarly, a common limitation of the LFA concerns the difficulties and confusion in terminology and definition of elements; in fact, the terminology adopted by the LFA is often considered ambiguous, generating divergent interpretations and confusion among users. The distinction of different logic levels, for example between “goals”, “outcome” and “output”, are difficult to comprehend and to apply; on the same level, the definition of “indicators” and “means of verification” can represent a challenge, frequently leading authors to propose reformulation or new version of the LFA to overcome the issue and improve the accuracy and effectiveness. In both models, the conceptual weaknesses reflect a common issue: the tension between formal structure and theoretical depth, while the LFA tends to formalise too much, reducing causality to a chain of administrative coherence, the ToC, instead, often remains too conceptual, lacking standardisation and leaving space for subject interpretation.

At an integration level, both instruments face difficulties in combining the analysis with other evaluation tools and methods, but such limitation mostly concerns the LFA. In fact, the literature emphasises its lack of integration with other project management tools – as the Work Breakdown Structure or the Gantt diagram – which makes it difficult to combine with dynamic planning or learning-based evaluations.

Functional and learning challenges influence the functional and temporal orientation of the tools. A weakness of the LFA is its strong donors' orientation, meaning that it

focuses its attentions more on the needs of contributors and on the formal reporting, rather than on the support and learning of real process development. In many cases, in fact, the adoption of the LFA does not come from an organisation's informed choice, but from the need to comply with a requirement imposed by lenders. This favours a bureaucratic use of the tool, aimed to satisfy accountability criteria, over its application as a dynamic instrument able to guide the design and planning and to foster organisational and collective learning processes. Both models suffer from institutional resistance to learning-oriented practices. In organisations familiar to cultures of compliance, evaluative reflection and adaptive management may be perceived as time-consuming or challenging established hierarchies. This resistance undermines both methodological innovation and the use of evidence for decision-making, limiting models to a procedural rather than a transformative role.

Beyond the functional and learning aspects, organisational and participatory challenges also emerge, relating to the cultural and procedural conditions that shape how frameworks are actually used and shared. Especially for the LFA, the emphasis on vertical responsibility, facing upward, results in overlooking more participative and inclusive approaches, limiting the potential of the instrument as a method for dialogue and co-planning with local stakeholders. On the other side, the ToC faces resources and capacity constraints affecting the participatory dimension: the sophisticated construction process requires specific skills, time and resources leading to the participatory dimension to be not always easy to realise and to the possibility of its substitution with more "top-down" approaches perceived as external impositions by lenders.

3.3.2. Why the ToC is currently privileged in impact evaluation

The Theory of Change has progressively established itself as one of the most used tools in the impact evaluation, especially when dealing with complex contexts. Its increasing centrality in the field is explained in the literature by a combination of methodological and practical factors: it responds to a growing demand for approaches capable not only of measuring whether an intervention has produced effects, but capable of clarifying the mechanisms leading to those effects, providing both a narrative and visual framework, connecting intentions, activities, intermediate steps and final outcomes, and making the causal logics explicit. The capacity to deal with complexity is evident in many interventions that take place in dynamic environments, shaped by multiple actors, contextual contingencies and evolving objectives where the ToC is increasingly

valued because it does not impose a rigid model but allows for the representation of multiple pathways of change, accommodating expected and unexpected effects. This adaptability also makes it possible to capture intangible or relational dimensions — such as empowerment, participation or cultural shifts — that conventional indicators struggle to register (Ringhofer & Kohlweg, 2019; Prinsen & Nijhof, 2015).

The literature also highlights that the ToC plays a mediating role between stakeholders fostering dialogue and negotiation, strengthening ownership and accountability in processes that are often contested or fragmented. In this sense, its function is not limited to technical evaluation, but extends to organisational learning and strategic planning, giving evaluators and practitioners a shared map for action. A key advantage is found in the integrative potential of the methodology: it can be combined with both qualitative and quantitative methods, bridging experimental and non-experimental approaches, and complementing theory-driven and data-driven evaluations. This flexibility explains why it is increasingly considered a privileged tool: it not only offers evaluative insights but also contributes to building reflexivity within organisations, helping them to critically assess their own practices and adjust them in real time (International Labour Organization [ILO], 2020; AMU, 2022; LINK 2007 – Social Value Italia, 2018).

The ability to translate its advantages from the theory to the practice and the empirical application, made the Theory of Change increasingly attractive not only for researchers and evaluators, but also for the main institutional actors and international donors, confirming the ToC's centrality both at a global and European level. Organisations as the UK Department for International Development (DfID) – today replaced by Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office (FCDO) – has adopted the ToC as privileged reference for monitoring and evaluation in research and development programmes, acknowledging its capability to provide a robust and adaptable interpretative framework for the entire life cycle of an intervention (Vogel, 2012).

The European Commission's guidelines (EU CAP Network, n.d.) in the matter of impact evaluation, explicitly highlights the importance of *theory-based approaches*, advising the construction of a clear theory of change as precondition in the project and evaluation phases in community programmes. In particular, 2012's guidelines suggest the Theory of Change as valid alternative when dealing with complex evaluation contexts or when is not possible to rely on experimental and quasi-experimental

approaches. The 2014-2020 programming period marked a significant turn: managing authorities were invited to articulate *ex ante* their theory of change, connecting the expected results to local and European objectives, aligned with the political push toward a “result-based policy” (Riché, 2012).

Moreover, the adoption of the ToC by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) and the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) is considered one of the clearest proofs of the affirmation of this methodology in the area of international development (Prinsen & Nijhof, 2015; LINK 2007 – Social Value Italia, 2018).

The trend is visible also in Italy. Associations as Assifero – the national association of all ‘foundations of non-banking origin’ and philanthropic institutions – devoted a great deal of attention on impact evaluation and the necessity to develop methodologies able to capture process’ complexity of social change, enhancing the ToC as a key tool in this direction. In parallel, numerous foundations and funding bodies explicitly require the use of ToC in the evaluations of supported projects, confirming it not only as a widespread methodological choice, but as a genuine institutional expectation (Assifero, 2018).

These examples show that ToC has established itself as the preferred approach to responding to the growing results-based management agenda, addressing the intricate need to demonstrate impact and evidence-based learning.

3.3.3. Critiques and prospects of the LFA

From the literature review, it emerges that the Logical Framework Approach is a tool widely applied and adaptable to many fields. Its main strengths lie in the ability to foster a common language among Governments, donors and beneficiaries, ensuring transparency, comparability and coherence throughout the entire project cycle. Nevertheless, the limitations highlighted in several contexts ask for a deeper reflection; in fact, during its lifespan, the Logical Framework Approach has been the subject of several criticisms, regarding both its theoretical foundations and its practical application.

In addition to the common criticism related to the main challenge and limitations already discussed in this chapter – as the inability to manage and adapt to complexity, chaos and uncertainty, the high donors’ orientation, the lack of integration with other

project management tools and the difficulties and confusion in terminology – the LFA is the subject of further observations.

The cause-effect logic that characterises the model leads to clear and expected relations between input, output and impacts, leaving out of the analysis non-linear and often unintended relationships: in this sense, the tool is criticised for not properly include the risks, the negative and unexpected variable, nor the variability of parameters. To overcome this limit the authors Couillard, Garon and Riznic in their 2009 study proposed a new methodology, called *Logical Framework Approach–Millennium (LFA-M)*. The LFA-M is different from its traditional form for being more consistent with project management framework by ensuring its compliance with the terminology of the PMBOK (Project Management Institute, 2008); moreover, the adoption of a clear terminology, the explicit risks consideration and the focus on the stakeholder involvement, make the LFA-M easier to integrate with other approaches and more effective in the planning phase. The structure behind is not of a linear and static model, but of one able to recognise the projects as complex and dynamic entities, where the adaptability represents a key success factor. Operatively, the construction of the LFA-M involves seven phases, from the analysis of the context, problems and stakeholders to the identification of options, core activities, necessary resources and potential risks. Also the matrix is different from the traditional, the *Logframe-Millennium Matrix (LF-M)* is composed of five columns – Project Commitments, Success Measures, Means of Verification, Risk Events and Responsible Authorities – and four rows – Organizational Value, Scope/Deliverables, Activities and Resources – allowing the project's corporate mission and concrete implementation relationship and a clearer contribution of the individual intervention to the strategic objectives of the organisation. Table 3.2 provides a short description of the information that should be considered to develop the LF-M. The proposed tool has been used at the Canadian Nuclear Safety Commission, in the study for the probabilistic assessment of leak rate through the Steam Generator Tubes Research Project: the results confirmed the approach effectiveness, which proved to be particularly useful in project selection and approval, as a communication tool between the different organisational levels and as a support for maintaining the focus on the objectives to be achieved. By adding the risk management inside the logframe, the LFA-M represents a step forward, in fact this element, introduced by Couillard and taken up by other authors as Ika and Lytvynov (2011), contributed to promote a more proactive approach to managing project uncertainties, reinforcing the likelihood of success and partly filling a gap in

the literature on risk management in international development projects. Nevertheless, other studies, such as Rode et al. (2022), points out how the LFA-M neglects the role of the evaluator and does not offer tools to compare different projects, thus limiting the possibility of having a more comparative and systematic view. On one hand, the LFA-M made the logframe more flexible, integrated and aligned with modern project management tools, on the other hand, it remains incomplete, and its effectiveness depends on the context and concrete methods of application. In the end, despite attempts at renewal, the attention devoted to it by the scientific and professional community has been rather limited: only few authors have analysed its impact and potential in depth, maintaining the use of traditional LFA the most established and recognised focal point in the academic and operational sector of impact evaluation.

	Project Commitments	Success Measures	Means of Verification	Risk Events	Responsible Authorities
Organizational Value	Project rationale and long-term benefits for the client ("why")	Metrics to assess business objectives and long-term benefits	Data needed to measure success and how to obtain it	Risk events affecting project value	Entity/person accountable for alignment with the corporate mission
Scope/Deliverables	Scope/deliverables contributing to organisational value ("what")	Functionalities & quality attributes	How the achievement of the quality objective is to be assessed	Risk events threatening quality objectives (e.g., unproven tech)	Entity/person ensuring project scope is met
Activities	How deliverables are produced (2 nd level of the work breakdown structure)	When activities must be completed	Assessing time objective (e.g., earned value management)	Risks that delay from contractor, staff turnover, etc.	Entity/person ensuring timely completion of activities
Resources	Resources required at high-level (budget, FTEs, permits, contingencies)	Quantity of resources needed and usage tracking	Resource usage monitoring (e.g., accounting system, timesheets)	Risks of lack/insufficient resources impacting activities	Entity/person ensuring resource availability and efficient use

Table 3.2 - Description of the components of the Logframe–Millennium.

Source: Couillard et al. (2009).

A common criticism present in the literature, coming from the accountability purpose, weak stakeholders' inclusiveness and lack of models integration limits, is the threat of the LFA to become a mere technical document, a contract with the sole objective of obtaining approval and financing, thus reducing the opportunity of learning and adapting during the project lifecycle, leading planners to focus exclusively on relevant aspects to satisfy donors, often at the expense of other elements potentially crucial to the effectiveness of the intervention. The isolated use, that do not allow the insertion of the LFA in broader processes of policy analysis, participatory consultation and strategic planning, increase the risk of making the instrument merely a formal requisite, functional to the lenders and ONG's needs but unable to answer to the complexity of real systems. In particular, the paper *The logical framework: an easy escape, a straitjacket, or a useful planning tool?* states that "*the logical framework has nothing to say about certain aspects of organisation and management*" and consequently "*stakeholders and stakeholder concern are not clarified*" (Dale, 2003, p. 58); the author reflects on the confusion in the distinction between strategic and operational planning, which undermines the possibility of smooth integration with other management practices, questioning the effectiveness of the LFA as a planning tool, highlighting its rigidity risks and difficulty of integration with the flexibility required by the projects, synthesised in the metaphor of the "*straitjacket*".

Finally, the confusion around the terminology and definition of indicators, paves the way for another criticism: the challenge of identifying and measuring these indicators and means of verification. Theoretically, the approach asks for specific measurable and reliable indicators, but from a practical point of view their identification represent an obstacle: the most common error is not to distinguish the indicators from the purposes, transforming the instruments for the progresses' measurement in objectives to reach. This challenge becomes even more evident at a higher intervention's levels, for example at the impact level, where it is difficult to identify relevant and significant indicators. In addition, in international development projects, the quantitative indicators often reveal to be inadequate or difficult to apply, making it necessary to resort to qualitative measures. However, the complex and indivisible nature of learning and social change processes limits the possibility of constructing truly representative indicators, resulting in unreliable surrogate measurement, referred in the literature as "*ghost proxy measures*", which ultimately reduce the effectiveness of the entire evaluation tool (Harley, 2005).

Beyond these, there are some other, less frequently referred to, critiques; among them, stand out the lack of an explicit temporal dimension (Golini et al., 2017; 2018), the tendency to produce overly simplistic schematisations (Gasper, 2000; Golini et al., 2017; 2018), the poor emphasis on continuous monitoring and learning (Bakewell & Garbutt, 2005), and the absence of a clear responsibility attribution within the projects (Couillard et al., 2009; Golini et al., 2018). Other authors signal the limited attention to the post-project sustainability (Dale, 2003; Chasanah et al., 2024), the mechanistic vision favoured by the tool learning (Bakewell & Garbutt, 2005; Golini et al., 2018) and its time-consuming nature (Bakewell & Garbutt, 2005). Finally, some researchers highlight the low adaptability to services (Bakewell & Garbutt, 2005; Russo & Rindone, 2023) and the obstacles connected to the management of high dimension matrices (Ledda et al., 2024). These observations are less central in the discussion of the LFA limitations but contribute to strengthening the idea of an instrument that, even if widely diffuse and institutionalised, presents multiple constraints in complex and dynamic context.

Despite the consistent number of criticisms revealed by the literature, the Logical Framework Approach continues to be broadly applied as one of the most consolidated and diffused instruments in development practices. The reasons behind the persistency are numerous and belong both to structural factors and in the perception of concrete usefulness of the instrument.

First, the LFA has imposed itself as global standard mainly because it represents a fundamental prerequisite for financing access from the major international agencies and institutional donors, many NGOs use it because it's required, even if they have internal misgivings. Beyond the institutional aspect, the LFA is considered an instrument able to construct a synthetic but complete view of the project: the logframe provides a condensed overview that allows donors and managers, who are required to manage and compare large numbers of interventions, to quickly gain a clear understanding of the objectives, activities and expected results. Lastly, the Logical Framework is able to reinforce the management responsibility, providing a standard frame for reporting and justifying spending decision, crucial elements in context where accountability to donors play a central role.

The Logical Framework has been the subject of a critical debate, raising question about its future and whether it might be destined to disappear, however, more recent literature suggests that its prospect is not the decline, but rather a transformation and

adaptation. A relevant contribution is given by the article *The Logical Framework Approach, Does Its History Guarantee Its Future?* by Rodríguez-Rivero et al. (2020): the authors through a review of the literature and a survey conducted on 51 professionals in the international development sectors (96% of them confirmed the use of the LFA), reach the conclusion that the instrument's future is not marked by an inevitable decline, but rather than a necessary of transformation. The analysis starts from the understanding that the LFA, as it is today, shows significant limitations and requires substantial improvement; among the most widely shared suggestions are (Rodríguez-Rivero et al., 2020, p. 497):

- the methodological integration of the risk management, indicated as necessary by 74.5% of those interviewed, aimed at understanding alternative scenarios and adaptive answers within the entire lifecycle of the project;
- a better definition of the Objectively Verifiable Indicators and the Means of Verification, 68.7%, essential for both donors, who must justify the investment, and the stakeholders, who needs a clear understanding of the expected results;
- the introduction of the time dimension, suggested by the 64.7%, with the purpose of overcoming the static nature of the model, which does not adequately take into account the weight that the time factor exerts, for example, in risks management.

In addition, the authors reveal as many practitioners suggest strengthening the capacity of the LFA to adapt with methodologies processes oriented and with consolidated project management tools to increase the operational effectiveness and clarify its practical application (Rodríguez-Rivero et al., 2020, p. 498).

Another relevant contribution is given by Ringhofer & Kohlweg (2019). In their paper *Has the Theory of Change established itself as the better alternative to the Logical Framework Approach in development cooperation programmes?* they recognise that the use of LFA has often hardened over time, becoming a bureaucratic tool aimed more at donor-required compliance than in-depth analysis, but at the same time "*the Logframe matrix as a performance management tool seems as popular as ever*" (Ringhofer & Kohlweg, 2019, p. 120) among development financiers. The authors argue that the future of the tool is not signed by its disappearance, rather by its evolution, in fact, many development agencies and donors (such as the European Commission, DFID, GIZ and USAID) are adapting their LFA formats to incorporate elements of ToC thinking, placing greater emphasis on social change and intermediate outcomes.

Overall, the lasting value of the Logical Framework is not questioned: its long history demonstrates its ability to provide a clear and shared summary of projects, promoting common terminology among different actors and simplifying the comparison of interventions. The authors emphasise that, in spite of the critiques and the methodological challenges, the LFA is not destined to disappear, but it will continue to be used in international practices, remaining an established point of reference for governments, donors and non-governmental organisations.

3.3.4. Overlap between logic models and ToCs

By examining the literature and analysing the different applications of the Theory of Change and the Logical Framework Approach, some questions arise about their relationship, opening a discussion about the potential overlap between some uses of ToC and the standard use of LFA, and the broader question of whether the ToC will eventually replace the LFA.

The literature review showed that in environments characterised by minor complexity, such as short projects, standardised interventions or initiatives that must meet predefined funding requirements, the ToC often takes on simpler and more formal forms: the main objective is not the deep change mechanisms' analysis, but the fulfilment of external requests, the need to present a synthetic and easily communicable frame of goals, or to support preliminary planning. Consequently, the representations appear linear, poor in intermediate outcomes and with a limited attention to the explication of assumptions and risks, the stakeholder involvement, when present, is mainly top-down, led by the implementing organisation or the funder. In these applications, the *"TOC becomes nothing more than a complex log frame"*, a mere formal exercise, useful for administrative scopes but not to sustain learning, adaptive and critical evaluation processes (Apgar et al., 2017, p. 29). The main difference between linear ToCs and LFA lies in the former's potential to be developed and enriched to become an advanced tool, able to drive strategic decisions and stimulate learning processes and favour the transferability of results to new contexts, while the latter is confined to standardisation and lack adaptation instruments.

Despite this, there is a conceptual and practical overlap area, where the ToCs and LFA applications coincide, a grey zone where arises one important open question in the literature: will the ToC progressively replace the LFA, or will the two methodologies continue to coexist? If they will continue to coexist, will they further differentiate in their respective areas of application or will they be integrated?

The overlap mentioned finds its roots in the Theory of Change origins: as highlighted in multiple studies, the ToC was born also to answer the critical limitation of other models that shared with the LFA the tendency to be descriptive, rigid and linear. In fact, when the ToC is not properly developed, it risks being reduced to a linear representation, little more than a logframe by another name.

From a practical point of view, this means that not all ToCs represent a real methodological progress, in some context and with a superficial use, they coincide with the LFA, generating methodological redundancy and leading researcher to question if the ToC is intended to replace LFA entirely or, on the contrary, both will continue to coexist. Scientific evidence suggests that a linear and complete replacement is improbable, it is instead expected a gradual evolution, with the Theory of Change as preferred tool in complex interventions while the Logical Framework retaining a certain relevance in less complex contexts or when the need for synthesis and reporting prevails.

The question can therefore be reformulated in pragmatic terms: what determines the choice between linear ToCs and typical application of LFA? The literature identifies several key factors.

Firstly, it is important to consider the nature of the intervention: for complex context, characterised by multilevel and non-linear dynamics, the ToC, also in its more structural versions, is more adequate because it allows the explication of assumptions, uncertainties and articulated causal chains. Conversely, short, easily predictable projects with clear objectives continue to prefer the LFA, thanks to the ability to provide a concise and immediate overview.

Secondly, the valuation and planning scope is to be considered: if the primary objective is the pragmatic management of results and communication with donors, the LFA can results more functional, given the condensed and easily understandable structure; on the other hand, if the goal is to comprehend change mechanism, stimulate organisational learning and adapt ongoing interventions, the ToC offers a richer conceptual frame, even when not applied at its highest level.

A third element to not underestimate regards the donors mandate, in fact, historically, the LFA has been imposed as a standard by numerous funding entities, contributing to its widespread use even when not appropriate to the context. The ToC is gradually gaining ground, but the choice is often conditional to external constraints

organisations operating in sectors where donors expressly require a logframe cannot simply replace it, even if they recognise the greater effectiveness of a ToC approach.

Another factor is represented by the capacity and organisational culture because implementing a ToC, even if in its basic form, require a minimum level of expertise, methodological competences and availability to participative involvement. Limited resources, an organisational culture strongly oriented towards conformity and bureaucracy, push the immediate use of the Logical Framework.

Finally, a significant factor is the perception of the instrument. Some studies consider the LFA as a useful tool for thinking to gain an overview of the project, while others see it as a *"straitjacket"* (Dale, 2003). On the same level, the Theory of Change can be seen as a brilliant and flexible tool, or as a process that is too costly and complex to manage. The choice between a basic ToC or a LFA depends therefore on how the organisation defines the problem and what value it attributes to the assessment.

The analysis shows that the overlap between basic ToC and LFA is not only conceptual but also practical, but in the short to medium term the two methodologies will continue to coexist, with LFA applied mainly in a standardised form and ToC used in a range from the most basic to the fully enhanced versions.

There is another tendency in the literature, compliant with the line of thought that the emergence of ToC did not lead to the abandonment of LFA, but rather to a reflection on how LFA is currently used. This branch of the debate recommends the combined and integrated use of the two approaches. The integration is considered the optimal solution because it can exploit the strengths of each methodology: the ToC is employed for the strategy and the *"why"*, while the LFA for the management and the *"what"*. The Theory of Change provides the narrative explanation of *"why"* a particular pathway of change was chosen, detailing the critical thinking and complex environment underlying the project design and it helps organisations confront complexity, design a route through uncertainty, and see the big picture. The logframe serves as the essential management and measurement tool, it provides the practical blueprint, detailing resources, activities, outputs and indicators necessary for implementation and monitoring (Ringhofer & Kohlweg, 2019; International Labour Organization [ILO], 2020; European Commission, n.d.). The integration involves using the analytical richness and the causal pathways given by the ToC to build and inform the formal logframe (AMU, 2022).

The first action to be taken is to bridge the missing middle. In fact, one of the key integration advantages lies in the ToC's ability to articulate the pathways of change that help bridge the missing middle often hidden in the traditional logframe (Ringhofer & Kohlweg, 2019; Prinsen & Nijhof, 2015): by breaking down interventions into intermediate steps and intermediate outcomes, the LFA matrix can be populated with more accurate and theory-informed results, maintaining coherence across all levels of interventions.

The second requirement is to fully align the logframe with the Theory of Change (International Labour Organization [ILO], 2020): the social value chain represent the crucial steps that translate the theoretical vision into a project pathways oriented toward social impact (AMU, 2022), therefore the intervention logic defined in the logframe must mirror this process, moving coherently from inputs to impact through outcomes (LINK 2007 – Social Value Italia, 2018; European Commission, n.d.).

To support the integration, the European Commission (EuropeAid), between 2014 and 2019, adopted a new Logical Framework format (Table 3.3 illustrate the new Matrix), the Revised Logframe that embrace a result chain terminology.

	Results Chain	Indicators	Baseline Value Indicators	Target Value Indicators	Current Value Indicators	Means of Verification (MoV)	Conditions
Impact (general goal)							
Outcome (specific purpose)							
Intermediate outcomes (results)							
Products							
Activities		Resources Costs				Conditions	

Table 3.3 - Revised Logframe Matrix.

Source: Adapted from AMU (2022).

The first column of the matrix changes its name into “*Results Chain*”, aligning with the project's ToC and reflecting the causal logic that connects activities, outputs, outcomes and impacts (AMU, 2022). The revised structure emphasises the distinction between

the project's sphere of control (where activities and outputs are directly managed) and the project's sphere of influence (which includes outcomes and impacts shaped by broader contextual factors) (LINK 2007 – Social Value Italia, 2018; AMU, 2022). A further improvement includes the introduction of intermediate results, which fill the missing middle by specifying the short-term benefits that lead to behavioural and institutional changes.

Another key enhancement concerns the measurement: indicators now occupy a central role, forming a complete result-measurement system including baselines, target and current values. The addition of the “*Current Value*” column transforms the logframe from a static reporting table into a dynamic tool for continuous monitoring and learning (AMU, 2022).

Moreover, the “*Assumptions*” column is reinterpreted as a space for analytical reasoning rather than formal listing, allowing the integration of the explicit hypotheses and contextual risks identified in the Theory of Change. In this perspective, the ToC complements the Revised Logframe by making underlying assumptions visible and restoring the causal depth that bureaucratic logframes had progressively lost (ILO, 2020; Prinsen & Nijhof, 2015).

Lastly, the ToC provides the conceptual framework that underpins a more rigorous and meaningful evaluation (ILO, 2020). Its explicit causal map enables practitioners to correctly link outcomes to corresponding stages of the intervention and to connect high-level impacts with intermediate “mini steps” along the change process (Nnadozie, 2024). This alignment facilitates better attribution and learning-oriented monitoring systems.

For integration to be effective and maximise its potential, organisations must avoid bureaucratising the ToC approach: the ToC should remain a living, flexible process that supports critical reflection and continuous adaptation throughout the project cycle, while the logframe provides the stable management structure necessary for accountability and coordination. This dual architecture allows evaluation systems to be both rigorous and reflective, sufficiently structured to monitor, but open enough to learn.

It is important to notice that even this combined approach presents some practical challenges, as training staff to master both tools, promoting an organisational culture focused on learning rather than mere compliance, and allocating sufficient time and resources for iterative reflection remain fundamental prerequisites for integration.

When these conditions are met, ToC-LFA integration offers the most promising path forward: an evaluation architecture that connects the explanatory power of theory with the operational clarity of practice.

3.4. Literature gaps

The analysis carried out highlighted the potentials and limitations of both the Theory of Change and the Logical Framework. Specifically, it outlined how the ToC can be employed at different depth levels, ranging from basic application to advanced ones explicitly addressing the hypothesis, contextual dynamics and counterfactual logics; conversely, the literature noted that the LFA remains confined to its linear and standardised logic, showing little adaptability to complex context.

In spite of these insights, the literature lacks a systematic framework able to connect the diverse uses of the ToC with the contexts in which it is applied: numerous studies condemn the rigidity of the LFA or praise the flexibility of the ToC, but none try to conceptualise how the choice and the form are related to the characteristics of the intervention, the complexity of the environment and the organisational skills involved. This absence represents a significant gap, especially when considering the increasing relevance of complex and dynamic context, where evaluation tools are required to go beyond formal compliance and provide genuine learning.

The present research aims to address this gap by developing a taxonomy of uses. A taxonomy designed to map how the Theory of Change positions along a continuum of usages, ranging from the most basic application to the most enhanced, and to relate this spectrum to the characteristics of the context in which the interventions are implemented. In this sense the taxonomy does not provide a rigid dichotomy but rather a conceptual lens that helps interpret the different uses and their practical consequences.

The following chapter will provide a detailed explanation for the taxonomy, and the proposed framework will be articulated and empirically tested in the real world.

4 Methodological proposal: a Taxonomy of ToC applications

The present chapter marks the passage from the research interpretative and descriptive phase, focused on the analysis and the current debate on the different applications of the Theory of Change (ToC) and Logical Framework Approach (LFA), to a proactive phase of systematisation.

The previous analysis highlighted the strong heterogeneity that characterises the ToC applications in the literature: its uses vary in terms of sensitivity and approach to the context, causal structure, degree of methodological integration and in the way it involves stakeholders in the evaluation. This variety, which reflects the versatility of the approach, also leads to a conceptual ambiguity, making it difficult to compare different practices and, consequently, to assess the analytical maturity of each.

To address this need for systematisation, this chapter proposes a model aimed at ordering and interpreting the different uses of ToC, identifying recurring configurations and distinguishing between different levels of analytical and operational maturity. This model takes the form of a qualitative taxonomy, built on the basis of recurring themes identified in the literature and structured along five dimensions that summarise the main characteristics and variation observed in the empirical literature. Rather than imposing a rigid classification, it offers a continuum through which the evolution of ToC practices can be interpreted: from simpler, linear and descriptive uses to more structured and dynamic applications.

While the Literature review considered both the Theory of Change and the Logical Framework Approach, the empirical evidence analysed showed that the LFA tends to remain associated with a single, predominantly linear configuration. For this reason, the present taxonomy focuses exclusively on differentiating configurations of use of the Theory of Change, while acknowledging that traditional applications of the LFA overlap with the most basic and linear forms of ToC.

The proposed taxonomy acts as a bridge between the theoretical review and the subsequent empirical application, translating the plurality of cases identified in the literature into a conceptual model useful for guiding the classification and understanding the different levels of use of the two tools.

4.1. The analytical dimensions

The literature review highlighted the plurality of approaches and interpretations that characterise the use of Theory of Change, and to make this heterogeneity more comprehensible, the analysis referred to five analytical dimensions. Such articulation allowed the construction of a broad and comparative map able to capture the variety of factors the literature recognises as influential in design, implementation and evaluation.

Each of them corresponds to a macro conceptual area that synthesises the main themes that emerged during the review: the first captures how the model approaches the context, variability and uncertainty, the sensitivity to the operating environment; the second examines how causal relationships are articulated and theoretically justified; the third assesses the extent to which the framework combines or interacts with other evaluation approaches and methods; the fourth addresses how the framework is used over time (as a static accountability tool or as a dynamic instrument for learning and adaptation); finally, the fifth analyses the degree of participation and inclusiveness in the design and evolution of the framework.

They are organised according to a progressive logic that moves from the external and contextual features of evaluation frameworks to their internal mechanisms, analytical connections, practical uses, and participatory processes. This allows for a comprehensive view of how ToC operates across different levels, from the scope and context in which it is applied, to the causal reasoning it expresses, the methods it integrates, the purposes it serves, and the ways it is co-constructed and maintained.

The following sections will examine each dimension individually, illustrating its conceptual structure and the role it plays within the classification system. Together, they form the interpretative matrix on which the proposed qualitative taxonomy is based, ensuring the methodological consistency and theoretical integrity of the model.

4.1.1. Context sensitivity

The first dimension, the context sensitivity, focuses on the relationship between Theory of Change, with the environment in which it is conceived, implemented and evaluated. It analyses how the instrument faces the variability, the complexity and the uncertainty that characterise the intervention contexts, recognising that every theory operates within constantly evolving social, economic and institutional systems.

Context-blind models typically embody a linear and prescriptive logic, assuming that relationships between inputs, outputs and outcomes remain valid across different settings, and therefore prioritising internal consistency, replicability and control. In these models, context appears as an external and marginal variable, a frame within which activities are placed, but that does not substantially alter the logical structure of the model. Such an approach risks overstating the universality of mechanisms and underestimating the ways in which institutions, cultural norms, or resource constraints reshape the plausibility and intensity of change. Moreover, context-blindness often leads to rigid planning frameworks that struggle to accommodate unexpected dynamics or evolving stakeholder configurations.

Context-sensitive models, by contrast, conceptualise context as a constitutive and dynamic dimension: instead of assuming stability, they begin by recognising uncertainty, path-dependence and the heterogeneity of intervention environments. Here, causality is not fixed but contingent: actions may lead to different outcomes depending on political incentives, social norms, organisational capacities or economic shocks. This approach demands tools capable of continuous reflection and adaptation. Context sensitivity also implies the ability to see deviations from the plan not as errors, but as signals of underlying system behaviour, inviting learning, feedback loops and iterative revision of assumptions. This does not imply abandoning structure; rather, it requires integrating contextual analysis into the theory of action, ensuring that causal claims remain credible and that interventions respond to the realities of the system instead of imposing an idealised logic upon it. In this sense, the maturity of a model lies in its ability to embed environmental contingencies into its architecture while maintaining conceptual coherence.

To summarise, this dimension distinguishes between universal and decontextualised approaches, and context-sensitive and adaptive approaches. Such distinction is crucial: ignoring contextual variability implicitly assumes that interventions operate in stable, predictable systems, an assumption that rarely holds in real-world settings.

4.1.2. Causal architecture

The second dimension, called causal architecture, considers both the causal structure of the model and the foundations on which the structure is built. It represents an important framework's characteristic in the taxonomy because it describes the model's capacity to make explicit the causal relationship that links activities, results and impacts, and base them on coherent and verifiable reasoning. In other words, it captures the degree of logical depth and robustness that characterises the construction of a ToC, highlighting how the tool manages to move from a mere descriptive representation of change to a well-founded and analytically articulated causal hypothesis.

On the justificatory side, it considers whether the causal links are represented and supported by explicit assumptions, by conceptual reference and empirical evidence. The deciding factor, therefore, lies in the magnitude of the causal reasoning that determines the model's testability: on one hand some applications merely describe what happens, crystallising change into a rigid pattern, limiting the ability to adapt to evidence and generate cumulative knowledge; on the other, some implementations question why and how change occurs, formulating hypotheses about underlying mechanisms and proposing empirical verification methods.

From a structural point of view, instead, the focus is on the causal architecture of the model, more specifically, on the clarity with which the logical connections between inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes and impacts are established. In simpler models, these relationships tend to take on a linear and sequential form, where change is conceived as an orderly progression of stages. In contrast, in deeper and reflective models, the structure becomes more complex, including circular relationships, feedback loops and enabling conditions, recognising that social change rarely follows a unidirectional and deterministic path.

In summary, the logical and causal architecture allows the analysis to distinguish between models that represent the change only in descriptive terms and instruments that analyse the change as a grounded process that can be empirically validated.

4.1.3. Methodological and model integration

The third dimension, methodological and model integration, concentrates on the extent to which the model can be combined or can interact with other evaluation approaches and methods.

In cases with low integration, the ToC tends to operate as self-sufficient instrument, isolated from other approaches and conceived as a model of conceptual representation. In such configurations, the framework provides a neat and coherent change vision but remains confined in the descriptive level, without any dialogue with other instruments that could amplify the strategic and empirical scope.

As the integration potential increases, the model becomes part of a broader evaluative structure, more systematic and able to connect the theoretical representation of change using empirical or comparative analysis methodologies. When this happens, the ToC is combined with complementary approaches – such as Realist Evaluation, mixed methods, Process Tracing and counterfactual analysis – which enhance its ability to generate evidence and test hypotheses for change.

The methodological and model integration, therefore, concerns not only the technical dimension of the joint use of different methods, but also the consistency between the different levels of analysis: theoretical, empirical and managerial. A high level of integration indicates the maturity of the model as an evaluation platform capable of connecting theories, data and tools, promoting organisational learning and the triangulation of evidence.

In summary, this dimension distinguishes between closed models and open, systematic models able to interact with other evaluation instruments and to contribute to the construction of integrated knowledge and decision-making systems.

4.1.4. Functional-temporal orientation

The fourth dimension, the functional-temporal orientation, considers the evaluation purpose and the learning orientation: together these elements can analyse if the Theory of Change is intended as rigid planning and reporting tool, or as a dynamic device for learning and strategic adaptation.

On the functional level, the axis examines the instrument's primary purpose: in some applications, the ToC is developed mainly with an ex-ante objective, to structure the intervention, allocate resources and define performance indicators, or with an ex-post objective to simply evaluate the intervention when it finishes; in other cases, instead, the instrument becomes a means of learning from experience, stimulating discussion between stakeholders and reviewing strategies in light of changes in the context. On one side it takes on a managerial and reporting function, aimed at ensuring control

and measurability of results, on the other side, the purpose shifts towards a more reflective and transformative use.

The temporal dimension is the natural complement to the functional one: a model built with a reporting purpose tends to be static, fixed in linear planning logic and ex-post evaluation, where the success of an intervention is measured on the correspondence between set objectives and achieved results. On the contrary, a model designed for learning is dynamic, it evolves over time through feedback loops, revisions and continuous adapting, recognising that change processes are never completely predictable and that knowledge useful for management is built up gradually, through experience and collective reflection.

This dimension allows the analysis to grasp a crucial point in the instrument study: the distinction between “to prove” and “to improve”. The ToC can be used to prove the effectiveness of an intervention, in terms of accountability to funders and stakeholders, or to improve the quality of future decisions by understanding the mechanisms of change. At one end of the spectrum there are approaches focused on performance and procedural compliance; at the other, there are dynamic, adaptive models that integrate the temporal dimension as an integral part of the organisational learning process. However, in practice, most models fall somewhere along a continuum between these two poles, balancing the control and learning functions to varying degrees.

4.1.5. Stakeholder engagement

Finally, the stakeholder engagement dimension analyses the procedural and relational nature that characterises the construction and management of a Theory of Change, emphasising the degree of participation, inclusion and dialogue that accompany its development. It recognises that the quality and the credibility of a change model do not only depend on the internal logic, but also on the way in which it is elaborated, discussed and shared between involved parties.

In its most restrictive aspect, the ToC can be developed as technical and top-down tool, implemented by experts or external consultants with minimal involvement of stakeholders. In these configurations, the model is pre-defined, based on rational hypothesis or institutional requirements and subsequently communicated to the beneficiaries or operative partners. This approach ensures logic coherence and

methodological rigour, but it risks reducing the model's legitimacy and adherence to the reality of the contexts in which it is applied.

On the opposite extreme, lie the collaborative and co-created approaches, where the constitution of the model becomes a participative process of collective reflection. In these cases, the ToC is developed through continuous dialogue between beneficiaries, implementers, funders and evaluators, all of them contributing with perspectives, experiences and different knowledge. The participation, therefore, is not a formal act, but a generative mechanism of shared learning allowing for questioning initial assumptions and adapting the models to the complexity of real dynamics.

The degree of participation directly affects crucial elements such as legitimacy, ownership and credibility of the model: an open and inclusive process increases transparency and promotes collective ownership of objectives, contributing to the sustainability of evaluation practices; conversely, closed or unidirectional processes can generate resistance, limit learning and weaken the tool's ability to bring about effective change.

To sum up, the process nature underlines the fact that the validity of the model lies not only on the accuracy of its causal logic but also on the quality of the social process through it is built. The procedural dimension thus becomes an indicator of the democratic and reflective maturity of the instrument, capable of integrating the different voices of change into a shared and adaptive design.

4.2. The taxonomy

Based on the results of the literature review, it is possible to outline a taxonomy of uses of The Theory of Change. The taxonomy stems from observations of how the instrument is employed in practices with varying degrees of formalisation, methodological integration and reflective capacity. The objective is to provide a systematic reading of this variety, identifying recurrent configurations that make it possible to interpret the analytical maturity and the conceptual evolution of empirical applications.

The proposed classification is not based on rigid and mutually exclusive categories, but is conceived as a continuum of uses, ranging from models applied in a static and descriptive manner to more dynamic, reflective and learning-oriented configurations:

each group represents a recurring combination of characteristics along the five dimensions identified.

As anticipated before, the taxonomy focuses exclusively on the Theory of Change, as the literature review has shown that it exhibits significant variability in its practical applications, assuming different configurations depending on organisational capacities, institutional pressures and evaluative purposes. The continuum proposed in this taxonomy captures this internal differentiation within ToC applications, rather than a contrast between distinct evaluation models. The lower end of the continuum includes more prescriptive and descriptive uses, where the ToC functions primarily as a structured planning or reporting device. In these configurations, its logic tends to approximate traditional linear frameworks, revealing points of convergence with the conventional use of the Logical Framework Approach. Progressively, configurations display increasing levels of contextual embedding, causal articulation, methodological integration and stakeholder participation, culminating in advanced forms in which the ToC operates as a strategic and adaptive learning framework. This structure allows the taxonomy to be interpreted not as a dichotomy between methods, but as a gradual evolution of evaluative reasoning, from control and accountability to learning and adaptation.

The proposed taxonomy identifies three ideal-typical groups representing recurring configurations in literature:

1. Group 1 – Basic ToCs, which translate the logic of change into an explicit form, but with limited methodological integration and little participatory involvement.
2. Group 2 – Structured ToCs, which present a higher level of theoretical articulation, alignment with evidence and use for adaptive management.
3. Group 3 – Enhanced ToCs, which represent the most mature and dynamic configurations, integrated with empirical approaches and oriented towards learning and organisational reflexivity.

These groups are to be understood as ideal types, meaning they are intended as conceptual schemes constructed to highlight recurring patterns and significant differences between the cases analysed, without claiming to faithfully represent every empirical situation.

Therefore, the taxonomy has an interpretative and organising function, the scope is not to classify the model in a normative way, but to offer an interpretation of its evolution and analytical maturity.

In addition to the distinct uses of each approach, the literature also highlights the emergence of hybrid configurations in which the ToC and the LFA are combined, particularly, the integration is evident in institutional and development cooperation contexts, where it seeks to overcome the limitations of each instrument when used in isolation. In such configurations, the Logical Framework provides a clear structure for operational planning and results management, while the Theory of Change articulates the causal logic, transformation mechanisms and assumptions underlying the intervention. The result is a more comprehensive and articulated evaluation architecture that combines the procedural discipline of LFA with the analytical depth and reflexivity of ToC. These hybrid practices can therefore be interpreted as bridge configurations with a high degree of maturity: they exemplify a methodological convergence in which the rigour of accountability and openness to learning are not in opposition, but progressively integrated. By incorporating these intermediate forms, the taxonomy recognises the adaptive and evolutionary nature of assessment practice, demonstrating that the boundaries between tools are not fixed but dynamic, and that innovation often arises precisely from their intersection. These hybrid practices can therefore be interpreted as configurations positioned at the upper end of the Methodological and model integration dimension, as they embody a deliberate methodological convergence between planning and evaluation tools. Their strength lies precisely in the capacity to combine different analytical functions within a coherent evaluative architecture, enhancing both theoretical robustness and empirical verification.

In the following subsections, each group will be analysed according to a consistent template based on the five dimensions, in order to highlight how structural, functional, procedural, analytical and contextual characteristics vary along the continuum outlined.

4.2.1. Group 1 – Basic ToCs

This group comprises the Theories of Change that present an explicit form but with limited content. They are models that reproduce the classical visual elements and the terminology of ToCs, as causal maps, outcome pathways and logical chains, but they remain conceptually rigid and predominantly linear. The result is a formally coherent

but analytically superficial representation of change, in which explicit theory does not translate into genuine interpretative depth or reflective capacity.

Within the continuum, Basic ToCs represent the initial stage in which the logic of change is formalised as a theory, without implying a substantive shift in analytical or learning capacity. At this stage, the ToC is often adopted for reasons of methodological compliance, institutional alignment or project visibility, rather than as an effective tool for managing complexity.

Context sensitivity. These types of ToCs show low sensitivity to context: the environmental complexity is flattened in favour of uniform and generalisable paths of change; local specificities, resistances and stability effects are disregarded, as change is assumed to be intrinsically positive and linear. This approach makes them effective communication tools but ill-suited to capturing the variability and uncertainty of real systems, as contextual factors remain external to the causal reasoning and are not modelled as part of the change mechanism.

Causal architecture. On the logical level, these ToCs make causality visible through diagrams and outcome pathways, providing an explicit articulation of how change is expected to occur. However, this explicitness remains formal rather than analytical: causal links are schematic, confined to short time horizons or donor-defined; the logic is descriptive and untested, reproducing the sequential rationality of results-based management rather than building a theoretically grounded or empirically testable model.

Methodological and model integration. Basic ToCs operate as stand-alone devices, not connected to complementary methodologies such as Realist Evaluation, Process Tracing or counterfactual analyses. Data are selected to confirm predefined logic, not to test it, consequently, the explanatory power remains weak, and the model shows limited capacity to interact with broader methodological or data-driven systems.

Functional-temporal orientation. From a functional point of view, Basic ToCs are mainly audit and reporting oriented: the change theory is used to demonstrate consistency and predefine a perfect future endpoint (i.e. an ideal, unchanging target that serves as a benchmark for reporting). The temporal perspective is therefore static, learning is marginal, subject to the need to comply with assessment or monitoring standards. This configuration reflects a “prove” rather than an “improve” logic: the model’s function is to certify coherence and predefine a desired end-state, while the

temporal dimension remains static and non-iterative, offering no structured mechanism for adaptive feedback or learning.

Stakeholder engagement. The construction process is generally external and formalised, often imposed by donor monitoring and evaluation (M&E) regimes. These ToCs are developed to satisfy institutional needs and predefined templates, with low internal discussion or effective participation; stakeholders involvement tends to be formal and limited, reducing the critical reflection to a compilation exercise rather than a deliberative process.

4.2.2. Group 2 – Structured ToCs

Structured Theories of Change represent more rigorous and formally developed applications of ToC where the theory becomes both a strategic planning tool and a basis for evaluation. In this case the ToC is a genuine logical structure that links the conceptual plan with empirical investigation, acting as a bridge between conceptualisation and verification, helping to clarify how and why an intervention should produce the expected results.

In the continuum, Structured ToCs are positioned at a middle-high level, representing a qualitative threshold of methodological maturity: compared to Basic ToCs, they show a significant leap forward in terms of logical consistency, participation and analytical integration: although they do not yet achieve the full adaptive capacity of the most advanced configurations, they introduce a solid theoretical and operational structure that consolidates the link between strategy, implementation and evaluation.

Context sensitivity. At this level, ToCs include an explicit analysis of the context: environmental, institutional or cultural factors are recognised as enabling or limiting conditions and are integrated into the model as mediators of change. In spite of this, context is acknowledged analytically but not yet modelled as a dynamic variable capable of reshaping causal mechanisms, with the theory recognising the variability but tending to remain anchored to planned scenarios.

Causal architecture. These ToCs formulate clear and stated causal hypotheses, translating assumptions into verifiable operational propositions; however, verification remains more conceptual than empirical because causal relations are expressed as working hypotheses rather than systematically tested mechanisms. A distinctive element is represented by the ability to fill the so-called “missing-middle” – the middle

ground between activities and long-term results – through maps that include change mechanisms in a logical and plausible way.

Methodological and model integration. The integration is moderate to high, with the ToCs becoming a reference framework for designing the evaluation. Unlike Basic ToCs, integration here is intentional and functional to the testing of causal assumptions, often through mixed methods systems or indicator-based monitoring tools, however, the ability to empirically verify hypotheses remains partial, as the link between theory and data is mediated rather than iterative.

Functional-temporal orientation. Structured ToCs are employed as strategic planning and critical reflection instruments: they are developed ex-ante, to guide the design and definition of monitoring systems, but also ex-post, to verify the validity of the hypotheses formulated and reflect on the lessons learned. Although learning is explicitly pursued, it often occurs ex-post, reinforcing accountability and strategic review rather than supporting continuous adaptation: Structured ToCs thus represent an intermediate point on the “prove–improve” continuum, balancing control and reflection but not yet achieving real-time learning.

Stakeholder engagement. The building process is characterised by participative dialogue aimed at generating consensus between different actors involved. Structured ToCs often arise from workshops or iterative cycles of discussion, in which stakeholders and operators discuss the causal logic and co-construct the model, and the quality of reasoning is strengthened by the diversity of viewpoints and by the establishment of shared assumptions.

4.2.3. Group 3 – Enhanced ToCs

This last configuration represents the most advanced, deep and dynamic form of use of the Theory of Change. In these applications, the ToC is no longer a static product or a planning device, it is conceived as continuous theorising, verification and adaptation process, where the theory becomes a systemic learning device able to integrate conceptual modelling, empirical experimentation and critical reflection in a continuous cycle of knowledge and action. Enhanced ToCs embody fully the analytical and evaluative maturity of the framework, translating the change theory into a research and strategic management instrument.

These configurations are placed at the superior extreme of the taxonomy, representing the climax of methodological progression: they mark the transition from a

representative use of ToC to an explanatory and transformative use, in which the theory not only describes change, but investigates and accompanies it as it unfolds.

Context sensitivity. Enhanced ToCs show the highest level of sensitivity to context and an explicit management of uncertainty, treating contextual factors as integral components of causal reasoning. These models identify, measure and incorporate environmental variables that influence the strength, direction and plausibility of change mechanisms, integrating uncertainty as an explanatory dimension. In doing so, they achieve high validity and systemic robustness, operating effectively in complex and dynamic environments.

Causal architecture. The logic structure is mechanism-focused and systemic in nature. Causality is intended as interaction between actors, resources and contexts, represented through maps that include feedback loops, multi-level interdependencies and connections between micro and macro dimensions. The focus shifts from a linear sequence of results to the causal processes that generate change with a systems-thinking approach: the model seeks plausibility and robustness, representing how contexts modulate the intensity and direction of causal relationships.

Methodological and model integration. The integration potential reaches its highest point: Enhanced ToCs promote advanced integration using multiple and complementary methodologies – such as mixed methods, Realist Evaluation, Process Tracing and counterfactual analysis. The ToC acts as a framework that connects diverse analytical perspectives and aligns theoretical modelling, data collection and interpretative strategies into a coherent system.

Functional-temporal orientation. The main purposes are causal analysis and real-time learning: the aim is no longer only to “prove” impact, but also to explain how and why change occurs. Monitoring and evaluation processes are integrated into the operational cycle of the intervention and provide constant feedback to guide strategic decisions. This configuration represents the extreme of the “prove-improve” continuum: monitoring and evaluation are no longer separate phases but embedded within the intervention’s life cycle. Time is conceived as iterative and non-linear, turning evidence into a resource for continuous decision-making and strategic adaptation.

Stakeholder engagement. The process is continuous, participative and critically reflective: the dynamicity of the ToC is driven by continuous feedback loops and collective sensemaking processes. The involved actors are not just recipients but co-

producers of knowledge, engaged in discussing and redefining causal relationships. Ownership is widespread and the process itself becomes an integral part of organisational learning, with a strong focus on critical thinking and adaptation.

4.3. From conceptual framework to empirical application

The taxonomy presented in this chapter constitutes the result of a theoretical-methodological construction path developed in the initial stages of the work: it offers a conceptual framework integrated to interpret the variety of ToC applications, highlighting the relationship between different levels of analytical maturity, methodological integration and reflective capacity.

The next chapter represents the natural continuation of this path, transferring the model to the empirical level. The taxonomy will be applied to real cases, projects funded by the Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto (FCVA), with the aim of analysing how different Third Sector Organisations employ the Theory of Change across projects, which factors shape different configurations of applications, and what managerial and organisational implications emerge.

At this stage, the conceptual framework assumes an operational function, becoming the analytical tool through which to observe, systematise and interpret the dynamics of the projects examined.

5 Research methodology

This chapter outlines the research methodology adopted to address the research questions guiding this thesis. The study adopts a qualitative research design based on a case study strategy: this choice reflects the need to analyse in depth how evaluation frameworks, specifically the Theory of Change, are used and interpreted within real philanthropic practices.

The empirical focus of the research consists of 18 projects financed by the Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto: its role is to define the strategic, organisational, and operational environment within which projects are designed, funded, and monitored. Our unit of analysis is represented by each funded project.

The chapter therefore clarifies the case setting, defines the units of analysis, explains the case selection logic, and describes the data collection and analysis procedures adopted.

5.1. Case setting: The Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto

The Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto (Community Foundation of the Varese area, hereafter FCVA) is a non-profit philanthropic institution which operates as Ente del Terzo Settore (Third Sector Entity, ETS) in the Varese area, with the mission to promote the culture of philanthropy aimed at sustaining the realisation of projects oriented towards the common good, solidarity and the human, social, economic, civil and cultural development of the territory. Today, the FCVA represents the main actor in philanthropic intermediation in the area, pursuing a strategic role in connecting resources and needs. In this sense, it acts as a local community philanthropy organisation, involved in the enhancement of life quality and in strengthening the community's own capacity to resolve its problems independently. (Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, n.d.; Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025a; Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025b; Fondazione Cariplo, 2025a).

The Foundation was born on 27th July 2001 and started its activity in 2002 on the initiative of Fondazione Cariplo, as part of the broader Fondazioni di Comunità (Community Foundations, FdC) project launched in 1998 (Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025a; Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025b). The aim of Fondazione Cariplo was to promote a widespread presence throughout Lombardy, overcoming the distance created by the separation between banking and philanthropic activities, and support forms of local welfare that are able to understand and respond to local needs (Maino & Ferrera, 2014).

The FCVA is part of the 16 FdCs of the territorial philanthropic model developed by Fondazione Cariplo, which is a Fondazione di Origine Bancaria (Bank-origin foundation, FOB) emerged from the transformation of savings banks in the 1990s and has taken on a role of supporting local welfare and promoting social cohesion: in the case of Fondazione Cariplo, the development of FdCs represented a strategy to extend the principles of strategic philanthropy to a territorial level, valuing the leading role of local communities. The model of FdCs is inspired by the US Community Foundations model, characterised by three distinct elements:

1. Territoriality. FdCs operate in limited areas, with the purpose of supporting sustainable and inclusive development in the relevant areas; in this sense, the FCVA acts as a reference point for the Varese area, by being an observatory and an operational actor regarding emerging needs.
2. Participation and proximity. The community model promotes the active participation of citizens, companies and local organisations; in fact, the FCVA acts as a social facilitator, aiming to strengthen bonds of solidarity and shared responsibility, with the goal to democratise philanthropy, transforming giving into a collective and participatory act.
3. Philanthropic intermediation. The heart of the activity is the capacity to connect donors and beneficiaries, building relationships of trust and managing funds allocated to socially beneficial projects.

(Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025a; Fondazione Cariplo, 2025a; Maino & Ferrera, 2014).

As previously stated, the FCVA is a FdC promoted by Fondazione Cariplo operating in Lombardy and on the Novara and Verbano Cusio Ossola area. Over the years, the Foundation progressively consolidated its assets and its ability to attract local resources, achieving the sustainability objectives set by Cariplo and assuming a stable position in the landscape of local philanthropy. A significant turning point occurred

in 2024 with the subscription to the Registro Unico Nazionale del Terzo Settore (National Register of the Third Sector, RUNTS) and the contextual revision of the Statuto (Bylaws) in compliance with the Codice del Terzo Settore (Italian Third Sector Code). During the same year, a new Board of Directors was appointed, marking the start of a phase of organisational and strategic renewal (Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025a; Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025b).

In compliance with its Bylaws and the Italian Third Sector Code, the Foundation pursues civic, solidarity and social utility purposes, aimed at promoting the enhancement of quality of life and the social, cultural and environmental development within the area. Some of its main purposes are:

- encourage and facilitate donations;
- understand and promote the potential of the local area;
- solicit and select worthy project proposals;
- collaborate with public bodies and Third Sector Organisations.

Governance is ensured by the Board of Directors, the Chairman and an operational structure which together define strategic priorities and oversee project selection, funding and monitoring processes (Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025a; Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025b).

Intervention areas fall within the activities of general interest defined by the Third Sector Code and span a wide range of social, cultural, environmental and educational domains. This thematic diversity provides a heterogeneous empirical setting in which evaluation practices are applied across different types of projects.

FCVA operates in a network of local stakeholders, acting as a link between public, private, and non-profit actors; it collaborates with public entities as the Province of Varese, with Third Sector Organisations that are recipients of calls for proposals, and with individual donors and businesses, to whom it offers philanthropic advisory services and results monitoring (Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto, 2025b; Fondazione Cariplo, 2025a).

5.2. Unit of analysis and case selection

Following Yin (2009), the research adopts a multiple-case study design, in which each funded project constitutes a single unit of analysis. The choice of a multiple-case approach allows for systematic comparison across projects operating within a shared institutional and funding context, while preserving the specificity of each case. Within

each case, the Theory of Change is examined through a set of analytically differentiated dimensions that structure the within-case analysis. These dimensions provide an analytical framework for systematically examining how the Theory of Change is articulated and used within each project. This approach enables in-depth within-case analysis while ensuring comparability across cases sharing the organisational context defined by the FCVA.

The empirical corpus consists of 18 projects: the selection was carried out jointly with the FCVA and primarily focused on initiatives funded under the two main calls, “*Arte & Cultura*” (i.e.: art and culture) and “*Interventi Sociali*” (i.e.: social interventions), in the 2025 funding cycle, complemented by a limited number of extra-call projects aligned with the same thematic areas; within this pool, projects were selected based on the level of financial contribution received. They include five initiatives financed through the call for proposals named “01.2025 *Arte & Cultura*”; ten initiatives financed through the call for proposals named “02.2025 *Interventi Sociali*”; as well as three extra-call projects funded outside the standard call-based mechanisms in 2024 and 2025. This distinction between projects financed under arts and culture calls, social intervention calls and extra-call initiatives is retained solely as a descriptive classification of the empirical material. It is not employed as an analytical stratification or comparative variable but solely serves to document the institutional channel through which projects were financed and to enhance transparency in case selection.

To support replicability and clarity, the following Table (Table 5.1) provides an overview of the selected projects, reporting basic descriptive information for each unit of analysis, including project name, implementing organisation⁵, type of intervention (art and culture, social interventions, or extra-call), project duration and a brief project description. The table has a purely documentary function and does not introduce additional analytical dimensions at this stage.

Project name	Implementing organisation	Project type	Duration (start–end)	Short project description
Project A	Entity Andromeda	Art & Culture	15/06/2025 – 01/05/2026	A high-quality music series promoting cultural inclusion and regional requalification in peri-urban areas

⁵ For confidentiality reasons, both projects’ names and implementing organisations were anonymised. Projects’ names were identified using alphabetical codes (Project A–R). Implementing organisations were assigned neutral fictitious names based on celestial objects (e.g., Entity Mars, Entity Saturn). These labels are purely arbitrary, have no analytical or geographical meaning, and are used solely to ensure anonymity while maintaining clarity and readability throughout the analysis.

Project B	Entity Aquila	Art & Culture	01/07/2025 – 31/07/2026	Co-designing cultural accessibility at <i>Spazio YAK</i> for marginalised audiences and people with disabilities
Project C	Entity Aries	Art & Culture	01/07/2025 – 31/07/2026	Experimenting with innovative theatre participation and diffuse performances for small mountain communities
Project D	Entity Booters	Art & Culture	02/05/2025 – 01/09/2025	Creating a diffuse theatre circuit in neighbourhoods to foster intergenerational and social inclusion
Project E	Entity Cancer	Art & Culture	01/05/2025 – 30/09/2025	A multidisciplinary festival connecting music, art, and sport to support the fight against Parkinson's disease
Project F	Entity Capricornus	Social Interventions	01/08/2025 – 31/07/2026	Educational summer camps to foster autonomy and peer support for children and adolescents with Type 1 diabetes
Project G	Entity Cassiopeia	Social Interventions	01/09/2025 – 30/06/2026	A music therapy programme for individuals with psychic-cognitive disorders to enhance well-being and social inclusion
Project H	Entity Cygnus	Social Interventions	22/09/2025 – 31/10/2026	Social and pre-employment inclusion for adults with autism through digital formatting and graphic design workshops
Project I	Entity Gemini	Social Interventions	01/09/2025 – 31/08/2026	Developing youth empowerment and professional training within a new community hub in Caronno Pertusella
Project J	Entity Leo	Social Interventions	15/09/2025 – 14/09/2026	Stimulating youth protagonism and civic education through the collaborative production of educational podcasts
Project K	Entity Lyra	Social Interventions	01/09/2025 – 31/07/2026	Integrated social and cognitive activities to improve life quality for disabled people and Parkinson's patients
Project L	Entity Orion	Social Interventions	01/09/2025 – 30/06/2026	Strengthening social ties through intercultural and intergenerational educational programs for migrant families
Project M	Entity Pisces	Social Interventions	01/09/2025 – 31/07/2026	Building a decentralised educational infrastructure to combat youth educational and relational poverty in Varese

Project N	Entity Sagittarius	Social Interventions	01/09/2025 – 30/06/2026	Supporting youth resilience by transforming personal vulnerabilities into strengths through expressive and movement arts
Project O	Entity Scorpius	Social Interventions	01/08/2025 – 31/08/2026	Organising educational and therapeutic vacations for vulnerable mothers and children living in community shelters
Project P	Entity Taurus	Extra-call	11/11/2024 – 31/12/2025	Establishing a new evening canteen and social support service for vulnerable individuals in Varese
Project Q	Entity Ursa Major	Extra-call	01/11/2025 – 31/10/2027	Consolidating microcredit and financial education to support vulnerable families and youth life projects
Project R	Entity Virgo	Extra-call	27/06/2025 – 30/06/2026	Realising an open-air Urban Art museum on concrete barriers to connect the city with nature through art

Table 5.1 - Study Cases overview

5.3. Data collection methods

In line with the research objectives, the study relied on multiple sources of empirical material in order to capture both the formal articulation of project designs and the perspectives of the implementing entities.

Two main data collection methods were adopted: documentary analysis and semi-structured interviews. These methods have been applied across all projects according to a common analytical logic, ensuring consistency and comparability among cases. Documentary sources provided the basis for the initial reconstruction of project objectives, activities, and expected outcomes, while interviews have been used to complement and deepen this analysis by incorporating insights derived from direct interaction with project stakeholders.

Figure 5.1 provides a schematic overview of the data collection process and the sequence in which the different methods were applied across cases.

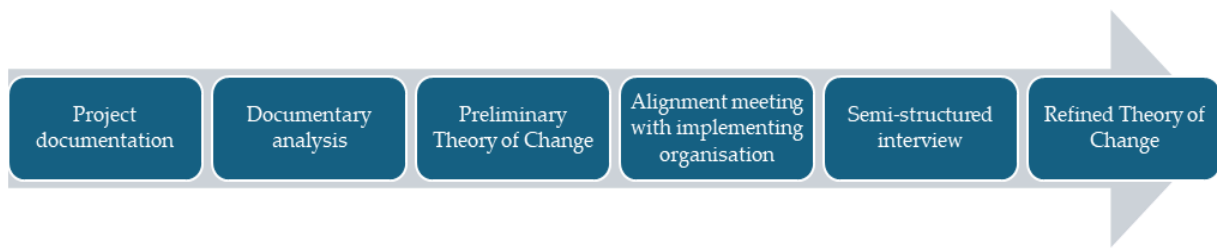


Figure 5.1 - Overview of the data collection process and sequence of analytical steps applied across cases

Although the overall structure of the data collection process was consistent across cases, its implementation allowed limited flexibility in sequencing and timing within the overall research framework. This flexibility did not alter the analytical purpose of the methods employed but enabled their application across projects characterised by heterogeneous contexts and organisational settings.

The following sections describe the two data collection methods in detail, outlining their respective roles within the research design.

5.3.1. Documentary analysis

Documentary analysis constituted the first core component of the data collection process and provides the empirical foundation for the subsequent phases of analysis. For each selected project, the primary documentary source examined was the project proposal submitted during the application phase to the funding call. This document provides the most systematic and standardised account of the intervention, as it formally outlines project objectives, planned activities, target groups, expected outputs, and anticipated outcomes at the time of project design.

The analysis of project documentation served to reconstruct the formal logic of the intervention as originally conceived and to make explicit the causal assumptions embedded in the project design. Rather than treating documents merely as descriptive background material, they were approached as analytical instruments reflecting the ex-ante theory underpinning each project. This perspective allowed the documentation to be used to extract information and to identify implicit expectations regarding how project activities were intended to generate change.

Based on the information derived from the project proposals, a preliminary Theory of Change has been developed for each case. At this stage, the Theory of Change was intentionally constructed in a simplified and linear form, consistent with the nature of the available documentation and with the fact that project proposals are typically

formulated before implementation and monitoring activities begin. The aim was not to produce a comprehensive or finalised evaluative model, but to establish a structured analytical baseline grounded exclusively in formal project descriptions.

The preliminary Theory of Change focused on identifying the main components of the intervention logic, including necessary inputs, key activities, expected outputs, short- and medium-term outcomes and the longer-term changes to which the project intended to contribute. Particular attention was paid to the articulation of causal linkages between these elements, as well as to the identification of assumptions that were either explicitly stated or implicitly embedded within the project narrative. Contextual factors were considered to the extent that they were referenced in the documentation, recognising that project proposals often provide a partial and schematic representation of the environments in which interventions operate.

This document-based reconstruction also played a crucial role in guiding the subsequent interview phase. By translating the content of project proposals into an explicit Theory of Change, the documentary analysis helped identify areas requiring further clarification, validation, or critical examination. In particular, the preliminary Theory of Change served as a reference framework to engage with project implementers, enabling a more focused exploration of how the intervention logic was interpreted, adapted, or challenged in practice.

Importantly, the use of documentary analysis as an initial step ensured a consistent analytical starting point across all cases: since all projects were required to submit proposals following comparable guidelines, the resulting documentation allowed for a degree of standardisation in the reconstruction of intervention logics. This contributed to enhancing comparability across cases, while also making visible variations in the clarity, complexity, and explicitness of project theories at the design stage.

Overall, documentary analysis served as a foundational methodological step, enabling the systematic reconstruction of ex-ante project logics and providing a structured basis for subsequent data collection activities. Its role was not to capture the full complexity of project implementation, but to establish an analytically coherent point of departure from which the Theory of Change could be examined, discussed, and refined through direct interaction with project stakeholders.

5.3.2. Semi-structured interviews

Semi-structured interviews constituted the second main component of the data collection process and played a central role in validating and refining the preliminary Theories of Change developed through documentary analysis. Interviews were designed to explore how project implementers interpreted the intervention logic, how it evolved during implementation and how outcomes and contextual dynamics were understood in practice.

The interview process was articulated into two distinct moments, each serving a different analytical function.

The first moment consisted of an introductory online meeting, during this session, the FCVA presented the objectives and rationale of its monitoring and evaluation initiative. Monitoring and evaluation were framed as a tool to synthesise good practices and lessons learned, ensure coherence between funded projects, identified needs and strategic objectives, and promote transparency and accountability regarding the allocation of resources. This introductory meeting primarily served an institutional and contextual function, clarifying the broader evaluative framework within which the projects were embedded. Moreover, the preliminary Theory of Change developed for each project was presented, with the specific analytical purpose to provide a shared reference point for subsequent discussion and to verify the coherence of the document-based reconstruction with the perspectives of project implementers. Presenting the preliminary Theory of Change at an early stage helped to surface potential misunderstandings or omissions in the initial reconstruction and facilitated a more focused and informed engagement during the interview phase.

The second moment consisted of an in-person semi-structured interview which followed a structured interview guide, developed in line with both the FCVA objectives and this thesis research objectives.

Interviews were structured around five main sections (needs and context analysis, partnerships, strategies and action plan, expected results and financial plan) mirroring the sections required during the application phase of the funding calls and the corresponding project documentation. This structure was intentionally adopted to ensure coherence between documentary sources and primary data collection, while facilitating systematic comparison across cases. Each section was further articulated into three analytical sub-dimensions addressing, respectively, the process of analysis and decision-making, the assessment of results, and the analysis of impact. This design allowed the interviews to capture both operational and strategic dimensions of project

implementation, as well as to explore how outcomes were understood and monitored, and whether relevant changes in context, assumptions, or causal mechanisms had emerged over time. The interview guide combined qualitative and quantitative questions. Quantitative items – such as percentages, numerical indicators, and Likert-scale assessments – were used to support structured comparison across projects and to capture perceived levels of satisfaction and impact. Qualitative questions complemented these measures by eliciting explanatory narratives, contextual interpretations on underlying mechanisms and implementation choices. The complete interview script is presented in Appendix A.1.

With respect to interview participants, the composition varied across projects in line with differences in organisational size, governance structures, and partnership configurations.

Participants included individuals holding strategic roles, such as president or vice president of the lead organisation and, in some cases, with members of partner organisations directly involved in project implementation, as well as operational figures, including project coordinators, educators or other staff members involved in day-to-day implementation. When multiple participants were present, the interview was conducted as a joint session, allowing for the emergence of complementary or contrasting perspectives making it possible to capture differentiated viewpoints on project objectives operational choices, and observed outcomes. The variety in terms of participants across different organisations reflected differences in availability and governance structures among the implementing entities; however, this variability did not affect the comparability or the quality of the data collected, as all interviews followed the same structured guide and addressed a common set of analytical dimensions.

5.4. Data analysis strategy

The analysis of empirical data followed a qualitative and interpretive approach, consistent with the objectives of this study. Given the focus on understanding how funded projects conceptualise their intervention logic and how they operationalise it in practice, qualitative analysis was deemed particularly suitable for capturing assumptions and decision-making processes that cannot be fully apprehended through standardised quantitative measures alone.

The primary data source for the analysis consisted of semi-structured interviews conducted with project implementers. Interview data were transcribed and

systematically analysed through a coding process designed to ensure analytical rigour and traceability between raw empirical material, intermediate constructs and the final interpretive outcomes, allowing for a systematic connection between data, evaluation criteria and theoretical dimensions.

More specifically, each case was analysed with two closely related objectives:

1. to position each case within the proposed taxonomy, by assessing how different domains of evaluation were addressed and the corresponding level of maturity;
2. to understand the underlying reasons and conditions shaping such positioning, by identifying the factors that hindered or enabled the adoption of more structured evaluation practices, as well as situations in which a given level of maturity appeared functionally appropriate to the nature of the project.

These objectives were pursued through a multi-step analytical process articulated around successive interpretive passages that are best understood as part of an integrated strategy in which empirical coding, analytical categorisation and interpretive inference mutually informed each other.

Following transcription, interview data were subjected to an initial phase of open coding aimed at identifying recurrent practices and constraints emerging from the empirical material. This first coding phase remained intentionally close to the interviewees' language and aimed at capturing how respondents described their understanding of needs, activities, outcomes and evaluation practices, as well as the practical conditions under which projects were designed and implemented.

After the initial open coding phase, the analytical process developed along two parallel but interconnected analytical trajectories, each aligned with one of the two objectives defined above.

A first analytical trajectory focused on reconstructing how project implementers conceptualised and articulated their intervention logic. Within this stream, open codes were progressively compared across interviews to identify recurrent patterns in the way needs were defined, causal links were articulated, expected changes were framed, and stakeholders were engaged. This phase aimed at highlighting shared logics and recurring configurations emerging from the empirical material, while preserving sensitivity to contextual specificities. The result of this step was a set of empirically grounded patterns describing different ways in which intervention logics were made explicit, implicit or partially formalised within funded projects.

In parallel, another analytical trajectory addressed the operational dimension of project implementation, with particular attention to how intervention logics were translated into concrete practices of planning, monitoring and evaluation. Here, open codes were examined to identify recurring practices, constraints, or enabling factors, and decision-making processes related to data collection, activities monitoring, outcome evaluation and adaptive management. Pattern identification within this stream allowed the comparison of projects in terms of how systematically and reflexively they engaged with evaluative practices throughout the project lifecycle.

Importantly, these two analytical trajectories were developed iteratively and informed one another throughout the analysis. Patterns identified within each stream were continuously compared against the full set of interview data, ensuring consistency between individual accounts and cross-case regularities, and allowing for the refinement of codes and patterns as analysis progressed.

Building on the pattern identification phase, the analysis related to the first research objective proceeded through a further step of analytical aggregation aimed at defining a set of analytical categories. These represent key domains in which evaluation and intervention logic tools are mobilised within funded projects. They were constructed by grouping empirically identified patterns into broader and conceptually meaningful areas of use, allowing for a structured comparison across cases.

The identification of categories followed an abductive logic: on one hand, categories are grounded in the empirical material, as they emerged from the systematic comparison of patterns recurring across interviews; on the other hand, their definition was informed by the literature on impact evaluation and intervention logic, which provided a conceptual lens to interpret how different practices relate to established dimensions of evaluation design, implementation and use. This theoretical engagement allowed for a consolidation of empirically observed patterns into analytically robust domains rather than imposing predefined categories on the data.

Importantly, these categories functioned as stable analytical axes that are common to all cases and capture how evaluation-related tools and logics are used within projects. As such, all projects can be positioned within each category, albeit in different ways. A total of 20 categories were finally identified, covering themes concerning: the process to identify needs in the project-planning phase; the stakeholders' engagement and satisfaction about the activities, the addressed needs, outputs and outcomes; the post project sustainability and replicability across contexts; the presence and use of monitoring and evaluative tools for impact assessment; the identification of the

“missing middle”, the underlying logic of causal mechanisms and the implicit assumptions; and the implementation of an adaptive management approach rather than a static use of the Theory of Change. For instance, one category, the “Ex-ante needs assessment” captures practices related to the factors that informed the initial needs analysis, including empirical patterns such as *“search for new beneficiaries - market analysis”*, *“horizontal co-design”* or *“dialogue with other territorial realities”*; another category, the “Use of monitoring tools” refers to the method and presence of monitoring tools for activities and outputs, containing patterns such as *“Quantitative and qualitative monitoring system”*, *“Interest in developing a monitoring system”*, *“Quantitative monitoring system”* or *“No monitoring system”*. A complete Table of categories and corresponding patterns, Table A.2.i, is presented in the Appendix A.2. These examples illustrate how categories served to organise diverse empirical practices without implying a hierarchical ordering among cases.

The stability of categories across cases ensured comparability and provided a shared analytical framework within which differences in the articulation and operationalisation of intervention logic could be meaningfully examined. At the same time, the use of empirically grounded patterns as building blocks preserved sensitivity to contextual variation and avoided excessive abstraction.

A similar but methodologically distinct process was adopted for the analysis related to the second research objective. Here, the aim was not to structure domains of tool use, but to identify explanatory families of factors influencing how projects conceptualise and operationalise their intervention logic. In this case, analytical families were derived exclusively from the empirical material.

The construction of these families followed an inductive procedure based on the interpretative similarity of coded excerpts. Interview segments were grouped according to the underlying factors they pointed to, such as organisational conditions, relational dynamics or resource-related constraints, without reference to predefined theoretical classifications. Through iterative comparison, these groupings were refined into a set of logically distinct explanatory families capturing recurrent conditions and mechanisms shaping evaluation-related practices across projects. Table A.2.ii in the Appendix A.2 provides a full overview of extracts and their categorisation across the six families, which are:

1. contextual complexity and problem structure;
2. organisational capacities and evaluation literacy;
3. data availability and knowledge infrastructure;

4. stakeholder and community dynamics;
5. strategic orientation and temporal priorities;
6. governance, design and project architecture.

Unlike the analytical categories developed for the first objective, these families are explicitly explanatory in nature and aim to account for observed differences across cases, rather than to structure areas of practice.

Following the definition of analytical categories and explanatory families, the analysis proceeded through an intermediate interpretive step aimed at assessing how each category was addressed within individual projects. To this end, a set of maturity levels was constructed for each category, with the purpose of capturing the degree to which evaluation-related practices were articulated and formalised within project design and implementation.

These maturity levels took the form of ordinal scales defined within each category. They do not emerge directly from the coding process, nor do they correspond to a simple aggregation of empirical patterns; rather, they constitute an analytical lens developed to interpret the empirical material in a structured and comparable way. Each level was associated with an explanatory label, clarifying the qualitative meaning of increasing degrees of maturity. For example, for the “Ex-ante needs assessment”, the maturity levels are, in descending order, *“evidence-driven assessment”*, *“socio-relational systemic assessment”*, *“consultative-experiential assessment”* and *“bureaucratic compliance”* (complete overview of maturity levels for each category shown in Table A.2.i, Appendix A.2).

Once defined, maturity levels were used to interpret the empirical patterns identified in each case. Patterns were treated as qualitative indicators that informed the positioning of a project within a given category. This step involved an interpretive assessment of how the observed practices, as captured through patterns, aligned with the defining features of the different maturity levels. In this sense, the analytical process moved beyond descriptive regularities toward a more structured evaluative reading of the data.

The attribution of maturity levels resulted from a case-by-case interpretive analysis in which multiple patterns within the same category were considered jointly, allowing the analysis to account for internal coherence and hybrid configurations while avoiding an oversimplified translation of qualitative evidence into discrete evaluative outcomes.

Through this process, each case was characterised by a specific configuration of maturity levels across categories. These configurations provided the empirical basis for the subsequent positioning of cases within the broader taxonomy, while preserving a clear traceability between raw interview data, intermediate analytical constructs and final interpretive outcomes.

Building on the attribution of maturity levels within each analytical category, the final step of the analysis consisted in connecting the empirical findings to the theoretical framework and deriving an overall positioning of each case within the proposed taxonomy. This passage represented the point at which empirical analysis and theoretical interpretation are explicitly integrated.

Each analytical category was theoretically associated with one or more dimensions of the taxonomy, based on the evaluation framework adopted in this study. Categories thus served as an interpretive bridge between the empirical material and the abstract dimensions of the taxonomy: while patterns and maturity levels captured how evaluation-related practices were enacted in concrete projects, categories allowed these practices to be read in relation to broader analytical dimensions. The mapping between categories and taxonomy dimensions was defined *ex ante* on conceptual grounds and applied consistently across all cases. Table 5.2 summarises the mapping between analytical categories and taxonomy dimensions.

Based on this mapping, the positioning of cases within the taxonomy was carried out through an interpretive synthesis of the evidence collected across categories. Rather than relying on a single indicator or category, the positioning emerged from a qualitative inference process in which multiple maturity assessments were jointly considered. This process can be described as a form of pattern matching guided by the theoretical framework: the observed configuration of maturity levels across categories was compared with the conceptual logic underpinning the taxonomy dimensions.

The final positioning of each case therefore results from an analytically informed interpretation that combines empirical evidence, intermediate analytical constructs and theoretical assumptions. This approach enabled the preservation of the richness of the qualitative data while ensuring coherence, comparability and transparency in the positioning of cases across the taxonomy.

Once the positioning of cases within the taxonomy had been established, the analysis moved to addressing the second analytical objective, namely understanding why a given case has a specific level of maturity. While the taxonomy captures how evaluation-related practices are configured within projects, it does not in itself explain

the underlying reasons for such configurations. A further step was therefore required to distinguish between cases in which observed maturity levels result from constraints or limitations, and cases in which they reflect an intentional and functionally appropriate choice.

Taxonomy dimension	Categories
Context sensitivity	Ex-ante needs assessment Iterative needs reassessment Contextual change analysis Replicability and scalability across contexts
Causal architecture	Post-project sustainability Adaptive management Representation of project and activities Intended change Missing middle Implicit assumptions Actor alignment on change vision
Methodological and model integration	Contextual change analysis Use of monitoring tools Impact evaluation framework
Temporal-functional orientation	Budget–activities–outcomes alignment Evidence of sustained change Representation of project and activities Longitudinal use Actor alignment on change vision
Stakeholder engagement	Stakeholder engagement in design phase Stakeholder involvement in action planning Stakeholder and beneficiary satisfaction Stakeholder voice and ownership

Table 5.2 - Mapping of analytical categories onto the dimensions of the taxonomy

To address this question, the analysis focused on the subset of interview excerpts in which respondents explicitly justified, explained or reflected upon the adoption (or non-adoption) and the difficulties in specific evaluation-related practices. Families were then used as an interpretive lens to read the positioning of each case within the taxonomy. For each case, the maturity level observed across taxonomy dimensions was interpreted considering the explanatory evidence provided by respondents, allowing the analysis to assess whether a given positioning was primarily the result of limiting factors, enabling conditions, or a deliberate and contextually coherent configuration. In this way, the analysis made it possible to distinguish between cases that appear “basic” due to constraints or unresolved limitations and cases in which

lower or intermediate levels of maturity are functionally meaningful and aligned with the nature of the intervention.

Through this interpretive step, the data analysis strategy not only supported the comparative positioning of cases but also provides a grounded explanation of the processes and conditions shaping different uses of evaluation tools across projects.

Overall, the methodological framework provided a coherent basis for addressing the research objectives of the study and for interpreting variation across cases in a systematic and theoretically informed manner. The next chapter builds on this foundation by presenting and discussing the empirical findings, moving from the positioning of individual cases to a comparative and critical analysis of maturity patterns and their underlying explanations.

6 Research findings

This chapter presents the results of the research, drawing on the comparative analysis of the case studies introduced in the previous chapters. The presentation of findings follows a three-tiered logic, moving from individual cases to a cross-case analysis and ending with the conditions shaping the level of maturity characterising the different levels of maturity identified.

First, we provide a synthetic overview of all cases, using concise case profiles and structured schemata to position each project along the five dimensions of analysis and within the ToC taxonomy (Basic, Structured, Enhanced). This allows for an understanding of the diversity of approaches and the relative maturity of ToC use across the sample. Secondly, the analysis is organised around five emergent groups: while cases are presented along a continuum, it is possible to identify similar practices. This part highlights the spectrum of ToC utilisation: some cases share comparable characteristics, while others reveal distinct approaches, illustrating the diversity of practice across the sector. Finally, we examine the similarities and differences and the enabling and hindering factors observed across all projects. This involves exploring the features of each group, recurrent strategies, and notable divergences. Individual cases are used as examples to illustrate these patterns, shedding light on the mechanisms, assumptions, and contextual factors that shape the use of the ToC in practice.

By following this structure, from single case to cross-case evaluation, the chapter aims to provide a comprehensive and nuanced understanding of how ToC is applied and interpreted in real-world TSOs interventions, highlighting both commonalities and variations in practice.

6.1. Case positioning

This section presents the positioning of each case study within the proposed taxonomy. The objective of this section is to provide a clear and concise description of how individual projects align with the five dimensions of the Theory of Change

application – context sensitivity, causal architecture, methodological and model integration, functional-temporal orientation, and stakeholder engagement – and to situate each case along the continuum from Basic to Structured to Enhanced use of ToC.

The presentation follows the same structure for all cases, allowing for quick comparison and interpretation. For each case, the following elements are provided:

- case name and organisation;
- interviewees' role;
- short description of the project;
- short analysis of the five dimensions (context sensitivity, causal architecture, methodological and model integration, functional-temporal orientation, stakeholder engagement) level of maturity;
- positioning the case on the taxonomy.

The analysed cases are ordered according to increasing ToC maturity, from those demonstrating a Basic use (where ToC primarily serves as a planning tool with limited reflexivity) to those exhibiting Structured or Enhanced applications, where ToC is actively used to guide implementation, learning, and adaptation. This structure enables a clear overview of the variety of ToC applications across different projects and prepares the ground for the subsequent comparative analysis. By positioning each case individually, it becomes possible to identify patterns, commonalities, and differences across the sample, which will be explored in the sections below.

Case Study: Project N - Entity Sagittarius

Interviewees' role: project representative of the lead organisation

Project overview: the project aims at supporting youth resilience by transforming personal vulnerabilities into strengths through expressive and movement arts.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Strong contextual grounding at design, but limited adaptability in implementation. Maturity level: medium-low
Causal architecture	Coherent but shallow causal logic, oriented toward feasibility and accountability. Maturity level: medium-low
Methodological and model integration	Weak ToC–evidence integration, with limited learning. Maturity level: low
Functional-temporal orientation	Strong operational control, limited learning-in-action. Maturity level: medium-low
Stakeholder engagement	Asymmetric stakeholder engagement limited to direct beneficiaries. Maturity level: medium-low
Positioning along the continuum	

The project adopts a Basic use of the Theory of Change, primarily as a planning and accountability tool. While the causal logic is coherent and aligned with practice, the ToC remains static, assumptions are not used for adaptive learning, and monitoring fails to illuminate the missing middle between activities and impact. These features place the case at the upper boundary of the Basic category, with limited progression toward a Structured use.

Case Study: Project R - Entity Virgo

Interviewees' role: president of the lead organisation

Project overview: the project aims at realising an open-air Urban Art museum on concrete barriers to connect the city with nature through art

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	High contextual awareness at design stage, low adaptability in implementation. Maturity level: medium-low
Causal architecture	Formally articulated causal chain with limited reflexivity and transparency. Maturity level: medium
Methodological and model integration	Weak, nearly absent, integration between ToC and evidence generation. Maturity level: low
Functional-temporal orientation	Strong planning logic, weak learning-in-action. Maturity level: medium-low
Stakeholder engagement	Predominantly informative and consultative engagement. Maturity level: medium-low
Positioning along the continuum	
The project adopts a Basic ToC with a coherent causal structure used to plan, justify, and manage activities. However, it is treated largely as a fixed artefact rather than as a learning device. Assumptions are not critically examined, monitoring and evaluation frameworks are absent, and the missing middle between intermediate change and impact remains weakly articulated.	

Case Study: Project A - Entity Andromeda

Interviewees' role: artistic director, project designer of the lead organisation.

Project overview: a high-quality music series promoting cultural inclusion and regional requalification in peri-urban areas.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	High contextual understanding at design, low adaptability during implementation. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Formally coherent causal chain, limited reflexivity and evaluation depth. Maturity level: medium-low
Methodological and model integration	Monitoring integrated but limited evaluative learning. Maturity level: medium-low
Functional-temporal orientation	Operationally efficient but weakly adaptive. Maturity level: medium-low
Stakeholder engagement	Predominantly informative engagement. Maturity level: low

Positioning along the continuum	
The project uses a Basic ToC: causal links guide planning and management, but the framework functions mainly as a fixed artefact. Learning loops are limited, impact-level evaluation is weak, and the missing middle between intermediate outcomes and long-term impact remains underdeveloped.	

Case Study: Project J - Entity Leo

Interviewees' role: editorial director and a volunteer of the lead organisation, project coordinator of a partner organisation.

Project overview: the project aims at stimulating youth protagonism and civic education through the collaborative production of educational podcasts.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	High relational sensitivity and field awareness, with limited contextual learning. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Normatively strong causal framing with weak operationalisation of causal testing. Maturity level: medium
Methodological and model integration	Predominantly compliance-oriented monitoring with minimal evaluative depth. Maturity level: low
Functional-temporal orientation	Strong execution fidelity combined with low adaptive capacity and temporal rigidity. Maturity level: medium-low
Stakeholder engagement	Formally inclusive engagement with limited co-ownership. Maturity level: medium-low
Positioning along the continuum	
The project lies in the Basic ToCs group. While contextual awareness and stakeholder dialogue are fairly present, causal reasoning remains weakly tested, monitoring is largely input output driven, and learning mechanisms are insufficiently adaptive. The ToC functions primarily as a static planning and accountability tool, preventing full consolidation into a Structured ToC.	

Case Study: Project E - Entity Cancer

Interviewees' role: president of lead organisation and president of partner organisation.

Project overview: a multidisciplinary festival connecting music, art, and sport to support the fight against Parkinson's disease.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Awareness of context at operational level but not integrated into causal reasoning. Maturity level: medium-low (practical sensitivity, theoretical context-blindness)
Causal architecture	Conceptually richer than Basic ToCs but lacks explicit, testable causal links. Maturity level: medium
Methodological and model integration	ToC used stand-alone, limited analytical integration. Maturity level: medium-low
Functional-temporal orientation	Focus on proving results, not adaptive learning. Maturity level: medium-low

Stakeholder engagement	Operational participation without co-construction of theory. Maturity level: medium
Positioning along the continuum	
Project E lies between Basic ToCs and Structured ToCs, leaning toward Basic ToCs. The case demonstrates intuitive causal understanding and actor alignment, but structural weaknesses in context sensitivity, methodological integration, learning orientation, and participatory design prevent it from reaching the Structured ToC threshold. Upward tensions exist in causal reasoning, but these are offset by the ToC's static and reporting-focused use.	

Case Study: Project M - Entity Pisces

Interviewees' role: project representatives of the lead organisation of four partner organisations.

Project overview: the project aims at building a decentralised educational infrastructure to combat youth educational and relational poverty in Varese.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Operational sensitivity exists, but ToC remains largely static and bureaucratic. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	ToC acknowledges systemic change, with partially mapped causal pathways. Maturity level: medium
Methodological and model integration	ToC designed for impact assessment, with limited testing. Maturity level: medium-low
Functional-temporal orientation	Learning remains informal; the missing middle is not addressed. Maturity level: medium-low
Stakeholder engagement	Participation ensures some alignment, but not collaborative theory development. Maturity level: medium-low
Positioning along the continuum	
Project M sits between Basic and Structured ToCs, closer to Basic ToCs. The ToC demonstrates attention to context and multi-level interactions, but remains largely static and procedural, with limited methodological integration, iterative learning, and participatory engagement. Upward potential exists in causal reasoning and emergent strategy, yet systemic learning and stakeholder co-production are not yet fully realised.	

Case Study: Project D - Entity Booters

Interviewees' role: president of the lead organisation, presidents and vice-president of partner organisations.

Project overview: the project aims at creating a diffuse theatre circuit in neighbourhoods to foster intergenerational and social inclusion.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Context-responsive but replicability relies on partner networks and funding. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Action-oriented ToC with weak explicitation of causal mechanisms and assumptions. Maturity level: medium-low

Methodological and model integration	Strong monitoring culture with limited evaluative capacity. Maturity level: medium
Functional-temporal orientation	ToC effective for operational control, less for adaptive or non-linear change. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	Engagement remains formal and consultative. Maturity level: medium-low
Positioning along the continuum	
Project D reflects a practice-driven, process-oriented ToC positioned in the Low Structured configuration: activities are intentionally linked to expected outcomes, and the ToC is effective in navigating contextual disruption and coordinating partners. However, it is constrained by a participation-based view of success, limited articulation of causal mechanisms, and a budget-centric sustainability logic.	

Case Study: Project P - Entity Taurus

Interviewees' role: project coordinator and an educator of the lead organisation

Project overview: the project aims at establishing a new evening canteen and social support service for vulnerable individuals in Varese.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Territorial gap analysis; high context awareness at design stage but no reassessment. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Missing middle partially identified; actions as means to behavioural change. Maturity level: medium
Methodological and model integration	Monitoring and evaluation systems absent. Maturity level: low
Functional-temporal orientation	ToC recognised as revisable and useful for adjustment and interpretation. Maturity level: medium-high
Stakeholder engagement	Relational engagement with beneficiaries; feedback informs practice but no co-design Maturity level: medium-low
Positioning along the continuum	
Project P is positioned within the Low Structured ToCs configuration, with strong contextual grounding, articulated causal logic that frames participation as a pathway to broader relational and behavioural change. The project demonstrates a meaningful learning orientation and a solid relational engagement with beneficiaries while methodological integration and formal evaluation practices remain undeveloped.	

Case Study: Project O - Entity Scorpius

Interviewees' role: president of the lead organisation and a representative of the consulting firm

Project overview: the project aims at organising educational and therapeutic vacations for vulnerable mothers and children living in community shelters.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Dynamic context; ToC guides adaptation, shaped by funder requirements. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Intended for systemic impact, but uncertainties remain superficial.

	Maturity level: medium
Methodological and model integration	Interest in evidence exists, but ToC not operationalised for systematic assessment. Maturity level: medium-low
Functional-temporal orientation	ToC aligns with desired outcomes, but adaptive learning is limited. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	Beneficiaries and stakeholders consulted, with limited participatory engagement. Maturity level: medium
Positioning along the continuum	
Project O demonstrates a partially Structured ToC, acting as a flexible operational guide. Strengths include contextual awareness and active engagement with beneficiaries; limitations are early-stage implementation, hidden assumptions, minimal systematic monitoring, and limited adaptive learning.	

Case Study: Project B - Entity Aquila

Interviewees' role: president and organisational management of lead organisation.

Project overview: the project aims at designing cultural accessibility at Spazio YAK for marginalised audiences and people with disabilities.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Context-aware with emergent strategy; no real-time adaptations yet. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	ToC intended to support systemic impact but largely funder driven. Maturity level: medium
Methodological and model integration	Intent to integrate evidence exists, but ToC remains largely untested. Maturity level: medium
Functional-temporal orientation	Strong operational alignment, with limited flexibility and learning in itinere. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	Medium stakeholder ownership; engagement more participatory than consultative. Maturity level: medium
Positioning along the continuum	
Project B fits a Structured ToC: the ToC informs multi-level causal planning and operational decisions, with strong institutional co-design. Strengths include stakeholder participation and alignment with real-world dynamics; limitations lie in untested assumptions, partial methodological integration, and early-stage adaptation to emergent changes.	

Case Study: Project Q - Entity Ursa Major

Interviewees' role: project manager of the lead organisation

Project overview: the project aims at consolidating microcredit and financial education to support vulnerable families and youth life projects.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	High operational awareness of context, but initial assumptions are rarely questioned. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Conceptually strong, with articulated but partially testable causal hypotheses. Maturity level: medium-high

Methodological and model integration	Partial integration between theory and monitoring; externalised impact assessment. Maturity level: medium
Functional-temporal orientation	ToC serves as operational compass and learning tool, with moderate adaptability. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	Participation supports effectiveness but not collaborative theory development. Maturity level: medium
Positioning along the continuum	
The Project Q case sits in the Structured configuration. The ToC is applied as operational guidance integrating causal reasoning, partial longitudinal monitoring, and community knowledge. However, externalisation, limited iterative adaptation, and absence of full co-design constrain the transition toward the advanced, systemic learning characteristic of Enhanced ToCs.	

Case Study: Project L - Entity Orion

Interviewees' role: project coordinator of the lead organisation and project coordinator of the partner organisation

Project overview: the project aims at strengthening social ties through intercultural and intergenerational educational programs for migrant families.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Territorial knowledge and direct observation but limited iterative reassessment. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Non-linear change, intermediate mechanisms and external factors recognised. Maturity level: medium-high
Methodological and model integration	Quantitative and partially qualitative monitoring and evaluation systems. Maturity level: medium-high
Functional-temporal orientation	ToC used for alignment and accountability, with revision considered possible. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	Beneficiaries and volunteers actively involved in activities; no ToC co-construction. Maturity level: medium
Positioning along the continuum	
Project L is positioned within the High Structured ToCs configuration, reflecting articulated causal reasoning and acknowledges critical change mechanisms, alongside operational alignment and structured monitoring. The project integrates relational engagement while maintaining a predominantly stable and accountability-oriented use of the ToC.	

Case Study: Project K - Entity Lyra

Interviewees' role: president and a volunteer of the lead organisation.

Project overview: the project offers integrated social and cognitive activities to improve life quality for disabled people and Parkinson's patients.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Context-aware design, with limited translation into project adjustments. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Coherent causal logic, with limited interrogation of structural dependencies.

	Maturity level: medium-high
Methodological and model integration	Robust monitoring, with limited impact assessment evaluation. Maturity level: medium-high
Functional-temporal orientation	Strong operational coherence but constrained adaptive capacity over time. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	Stable engagement oriented toward participation with limited co-creation. Maturity level: medium
Positioning along the continuum	
The project adopts a High Structured Theory of Change, characterised by a coherent causal architecture, solid contextual grounding, and consistent alignment between declared theory and practice. However, learning processes remain largely episodic, sustainability is primarily conceived in financial terms, and evaluation is insufficiently leveraged for adaptive management.	

Case Study: Project H - Entity Cygnus

Interviewees' role: president, treasurer and coordinator of the lead organisation;
President of the partner organisation

Project overview: the project offers social and pre-employment inclusion for adults with autism through digital formatting and graphic design workshops.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	High contextual awareness with episodic, rather than continuous, adaptation. Maturity level: medium-high
Causal architecture	Well-articulated causal logic with limited depth in reflexive causal testing. Maturity level: medium-high
Methodological and model integration	Solid monitoring practices, weak evaluative closure. Maturity level: medium
Functional-temporal orientation	Strong planning and accountability orientation with limited adaptive learning. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	High relational engagement functionally aligned but not co-creation. Maturity level: medium-high
Positioning along the continuum	
The project adopts a High Structured Theory of Change, characterised by a coherent and explicit causal logic, solid contextual awareness, and meaningful stakeholder engagement. However, learning remains largely oriented toward validation and accountability rather than adaptive theory revision, and impact assessment is not yet operationalised. These features place the case firmly within the Structured category, without fully transitioning toward an Enhanced use.	

Case Study: Project F - Entity Capricornus

Interviewees' role: president e vice-president of lead organisation

Project overview: the project offers educational summer camps to foster autonomy and peer support for children and adolescents with Type 1 diabetes.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Context-aware but static, with budget-dependent replicability.

	Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Operationally central ToC, supporting adaptation, with some hidden fragilities. Maturity level: medium-high
Methodological and model integration	Robust evidence integration supports understanding and hypothesis testing. Maturity level: high
Functional-temporal orientation	ToC guides operations and monitoring, with limited support for emergent change. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	Strong focus on the target group, with limited participatory ownership. Maturity level: medium-low
Positioning along the continuum	
<i>Project F</i> fits a High Structured/Low Enhanced ToC: the ToC informs project design, operational decision-making, and multi-level causal mechanisms. Strengths lie in methodological integration and operational guidance; limitations include static context analysis, rigid cycles of reflection, and minimal stakeholder co-design.	

Case Study: Project C - Entity Aries

Interviewees' role: president (and artistic director), secretary, vice-president (and organisational director) of the lead organisation.

Project overview: the project aims at experimenting with innovative theatre participation and diffuse performances for small mountain communities.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Strong contextual embeddedness with partial depth in mechanism analysis. Maturity level: medium-high
Causal architecture	Robust and reflexive structure, with residual reliance on activity-based indicators. Maturity level: high
Methodological and model integration	Monitoring logic with partial integration but limited evaluative capabilities. Maturity level: medium
Functional-temporal orientation	Strong feasibility and planning orientation, moderate adaptiveness over time. Maturity level: medium
Stakeholder engagement	Collaborative design with limited participatory depth during delivery. Maturity level: medium
Positioning along the continuum	
The case reflects a Low Enhanced, borderline with a Structured, ToC, with explicit causal mechanisms, adaptive use, and testable assumptions. However, uneven methodological integration and limited impact-level evaluation prevent full consolidation. The ToC functions effectively as a strategic and learning-oriented framework, but only partially as a comprehensive evaluative system.	

Case Study: Project G - Entity Cassiopeia

Interviewees' role: president, two educators involved in project activities and project coordinator of the lead organisation.

Project overview: a music therapy programme for individuals with psychic-cognitive disorders to enhance well-being and social inclusion.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Strong contextual knowledge limits questioning of initial assumptions. Maturity level: medium-high
Causal architecture	Robust causal logic with explicit mechanisms; sustainability as budget dependent. Maturity level: medium-high
Methodological and model integration	Strong monitoring practices, weak formal impact testing. Maturity level: medium-high
Functional-temporal orientation	ToC supports learning over time, with highly individualised pathways. Maturity level: medium-high
Stakeholder engagement	Strong relational engagement and ownership, moving toward participatory learning. Maturity level: medium-high
Positioning along the continuum	
Project G aligns with a Low Enhanced ToC: causally explicit, mechanism-aware, and supported by rich monitoring practices. Its main limitations concern the budget-centric view of sustainability and the absence of a fully operational impact assessment framework, which currently constrain empirical validation of long-term change.	

Case Study: Project I - Entity Gemini

Interviewees' role: project manager, project designer, project coordinator of lead organisation.

Project overview: the project aims at developing youth empowerment and professional training within a new community hub in Caronno Pertusella.

Analysis across the five dimensions	
Context sensitivity	Context-informed but static; scalability leverages existing partner networks. Maturity level: medium
Causal architecture	Strong alignment between ToC and practice, with explicit mechanisms. Maturity level: high
Methodological and model integration	Evidence integration is robust; allows testing and learning from observed outcomes. Maturity level: High
Functional-temporal orientation	ToC central to operations, with learning-oriented monitoring. Maturity level: medium-high
Stakeholder engagement	Structured engagement with partners; broader participation pending. Maturity level: medium
Positioning along the continuum	
Project I sits in the Enhanced ToCs cluster: the ToC actively guides project design, maps causal pathways in detail, integrates mixed-methods evidence, and treats assumptions as testable hypotheses. Limitations include top-down design and incomplete beneficiary engagement, but the framework is well-embedded and positioned for iterative learning and systemic impact.	

6.2. Cross-case analysis

As mentioned in above in this chapter, the cases analysed were individually positioned along the taxonomy according to the five dimensions. This section presents an aggregate analysis, highlighting recurring patterns among the projects. It should be emphasised that these configurations do not represent rigid categories, but rather a continuum of maturity in the management and use of ToC.

Across the sample, five recurrent maturity configurations emerge. These configurations do not represent sequential stages of development; rather, they capture empirically observable patterns in how projects relate activities to outcomes, use monitoring and evidence, support learning over time, and engage stakeholders. Several cases occupy intermediate or borderline positions along this continuum, combining elements associated with different configurations. The positioning of the cases along this continuum is illustrated in Figure 6.1. Each point represents a project, placed according to its overall configuration across the five dimensions. The visualisation highlights both the clustering of cases around recurring configurations and the presence of intermediate positions that confirm the non-rigid, continuum-based nature of the taxonomy.

Each maturity configuration is discussed in turn, as it emerges from the positioning of cases along the taxonomy, and is anchored in empirical evidence drawn from the case studies.

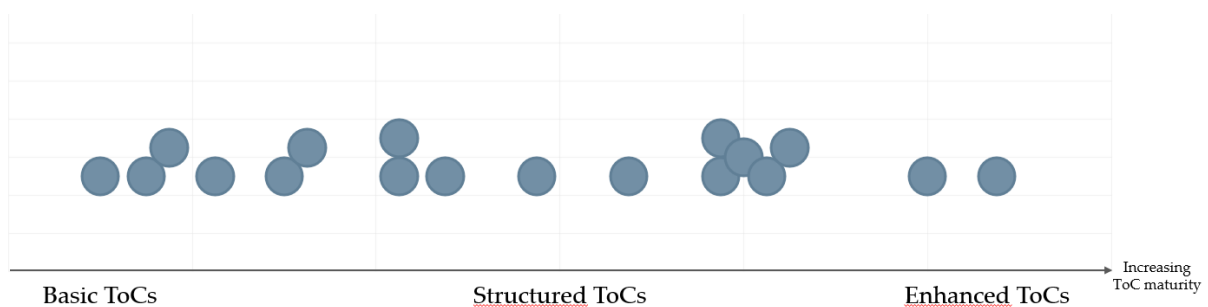


Figure 6.1 - Positioning of the analysed cases along the ToC maturity continuum

6.2.1. Basic ToC configurations

The first maturity configuration identified includes projects positioned within the Basic use of the Theory of Change. In these cases, the Theory of Change is primarily oriented toward planning and operational control, and it functions as a descriptive framework that supports the organisation of activities and the articulation of expected results but remains largely static throughout implementation. Causal links between

activities and outcomes are generally assumed rather than explicitly tested, and the “missing middle” between outputs and longer-term change is weakly articulated.

Across these projects, there is clear attention to context, but this is largely grounded in preliminary analyses that rely on previous experience and existing collaborations rather than continuous or systematic reflection. For instance, in Project N by Entity Sagittarius needs assessments draw on established community relationships and historical knowledge of the target population. On the other hand, for Project A by Entity Andromeda, the initial territorial analysis is carried out with a certain maturity, identifying potential beneficiaries and relevant causal ingredients that are realistic and adequate for the local context, however the initial analysis is not revisited or revised during implementation: the project team explicitly noted that no variations in context were considered within the project timeframe, reflecting a perception of contextual stability and a limited anticipation of external changes. Similarly, the possibility of replicating these projects in other contexts is framed primarily in terms of funding availability, rather than an assessment of how actions could be transferred to address local needs elsewhere. In practice, this implies an assumption that territorial needs are largely homogeneous across different areas.

Within this configuration, the connection between activities and intermediate outcomes (the so-called “missing middle”) is largely unrecognised. Change is often conceived as a linear sequence, in which participation in planned activities is assumed to generate the desired effects without the need for explicit articulation of underlying mechanisms. In Project A, for example, change is primarily framed in terms of audience participation: young people attend concerts, develop an interest in music, and this increased engagement is expected to contribute to broader recognition of the value of cultural investment. This logic reflects a direct and intuitive link between activity and outcome, with limited attention to intermediate processes or alternative causal pathways. Moreover, when explicitly asked about assumptions underlying change, project representatives referred primarily to external enabling conditions rather than to mechanisms internal to the intervention. In the same case, the sustainability and effectiveness of the project were described as strongly dependent on continued economic support and on the availability of substantial communication resources. Funding and investment in promotion were identified as necessary preconditions for achieving participation outcomes, while assumptions related to behavioural change, learning processes, or longer-term cultural effects were not articulated. Instead, in Project R by Entity Virgo interviewees acknowledged that change does not occur in a linear manner and that intermediate mechanisms need to

be activated; however, they were unable to identify or articulate the contextual assumptions that shape the project's operating environment, leaving these mechanisms largely unspecified within the ToC. This illustrates how, in Basic configurations, causal reasoning tends to focus on feasibility conditions rather than on the articulation and testing of assumptions linking activities to outcomes.

Monitoring systems are in place and often adopt a mixed-methods approach, but their use remains focused on recording easily observable outputs. Evaluation frameworks for assessing the results or the impact of activities are largely absent. For example, when asked whether a system for outcome evaluation was planned, Entity Leo reported that no formal evaluation existed and only considered the possibility of conducting a final interview. This highlights that, during implementation, the reflection on results and the use of monitoring data for adaptive purposes are not part of project practice. Similarly, Entity Virgo explicitly reported that neither monitoring nor evaluation systems were considered necessary, as the project was conceived as a continuous programme with stable resources and routines. Across these cases, the absence of outcome evaluation frameworks limits the ability to make visible and assess the intermediate links between activities and longer-term impact.

From a functional-temporal perspective, the Theory of Change in these projects is predominantly used *ex ante*, as a planning and accountability device rather than as a framework for learning over time. The implementation phase is not conceived as a space for revisiting assumptions or adapting causal pathways, and monitoring data are rarely mobilised to inform mid-course corrections. This orientation is reflected in how organisations respond to the possibility of revisiting their Theory of Change during implementation. In Project J by Entity Leo, for instance, when the opportunity to schedule a follow-up moment to revisit and reflect on the ToC during the project was discussed, project representatives indicated that such a revision was not considered necessary. The underlying logic of the intervention was perceived as stable and unlikely to change before the conclusion of the project. This response suggests that the ToC is conceived as a fixed planning reference rather than as a hypothesis to be interrogated and adjusted over time. The same vision was shared also by Entity Virgo and Entity Andromeda. As a result, the temporal use of the ToC remains static and primarily serves to demonstrate delivery and coherence *ex post*, rather than supporting adaptive learning *in itinere*.

Stakeholder engagement in the Basic group is minimal and largely unidirectional. Beneficiaries are informed about activities, but co-design or participatory approaches

are absent: stakeholder involvement is primarily procedural rather than substantive. In Project N, for instance, the community's awareness of the project is still limited: the broader community and non-institutional stakeholders are rarely considered in shaping project activities, confirming that in these cases, the ToC serves a functional purpose for project management but does not support reflective or adaptive practices.

Taken together, projects in the Basic group demonstrate a coherent operational use of the Theory of Change: activities are executed according to plan, outputs are monitored, and the overall project trajectory is predictable. However, the projects show limited engagement with causal reasoning, stakeholder co-creation, or evaluation of outcomes. The ToC acts as a descriptive roadmap rather than a tool for reflection or learning, and its application remains tightly bound to the initial project design and planning assumptions.

6.2.2. Hybrid ToC configurations (Basic–Structured)

Beyond these Basic configurations, a set of projects occupies an intermediate position along the continuum, combining elements of operational stability with early attempts to articulate causal reasoning more explicitly. These cases do not fully depart from a Basic use of the ToC but display emerging features that signal a partial transition toward more Structured configurations.

Across this configuration, attention to context appears more articulated than in Basic cases. Projects such as Project E by ENTITY CANCER, Project D by Entity Booters, and Project P by Entity Taurus demonstrate an ability to recognise contextual dynamics during implementation and, in some instances, to respond to external shocks or evolving needs. In Project D, for example, the project logic explicitly incorporated new needs that emerged in the post-pandemic context, adapting activities to address changes in social participation and intergenerational interaction. However, this contextual responsiveness is not systematically translated into revisions of the ToC itself. Context is treated as an operational variable to be managed rather than as a source of learning capable of reshaping causal assumptions. This tendency is also reflected in the way projects build on previous experiences. In Project E the ToC draws heavily on prior project cycles and consolidated practices, which are reworked and adapted to new funding opportunities. While this contributes to feasibility and continuity, it also reinforces the stability of the underlying ToC, which is rarely questioned or revisited during implementation. As a result, flexibility is visible at the level of activities, but the causal structure underpinning the intervention remains largely unchanged.

With respect to causal architecture, these projects exhibit an increased awareness of the link between activities and intended outcomes, yet the articulation of causal mechanisms remains implicit. Change is often framed as the cumulative effect of coordinated actions, with limited attention to testable causal hypotheses. In Project D, for example, the ToC supports coordination among partners and facilitates responsiveness to contextual disruptions, but assumptions about how participation leads to longer-term change are not explicitly examined. Similarly, in Project E, causal reasoning is intuitive and grounded in practitioners' experience, but it lacks formalisation and systematic testing, limiting its potential for critical reflection.

Monitoring practices in the borderline Basic/Structured cases are generally more developed than in the Basic configuration, yet they remain primarily oriented toward accountability and operational oversight: data collection often includes qualitative elements and reflects a genuine interest in understanding project progress, but it is rarely mobilised to interrogate the Theory of Change or to assess intermediate outcomes. In Project M by Entity Pisces for instance, monitoring activities support alignment with planned objectives and provide reassurance regarding implementation fidelity, but they do not feed into a structured evaluation of whether and how expected changes are occurring. A similar pattern emerges in Project D, where data are collected throughout implementation but are not organised within a coherent evaluation framework. Across these cases, the absence of explicit outcome evaluation frameworks contributes to a persistent gap in the "missing middle" between activities and longer-term impact.

From a functional-temporal perspective, early signals of a shift away from exclusive *ex ante* use of the ToC can be observed. The ToC increasingly supports coordination during implementation and helps manage ongoing activities. At the same time, it is not consistently treated as a framework to be revisited or refined over time. In Project M, the possibility of revisiting the ToC was framed as relevant primarily at the end of the project, for reporting purposes, rather than as part of *in itinere* learning. These responses indicate that, within this configuration, the ToC is still conceived as a stable planning reference rather than as a hypothesis to be interrogated and adapted during implementation. On the other hand, one case stands out, Entity Taurus, for Project P, reported that revisiting the ToC represents an opportunity to modify, correct, and intercept emerging dynamics, not only to verify alignment but to understand how and why certain mechanisms are (or are not) producing change.

Stakeholder engagement in these cases tends to be more active than in Basic configurations, particularly with direct beneficiaries and partner organisations. Stakeholders contribute to refining activities and addressing immediate needs, enhancing implementation effectiveness. However, engagement remains largely consultative or functional. In Project P for example, project representatives noted that operators and volunteers could potentially be involved in reflecting on the ToC, but such involvement had not been implemented. As a result, participation strengthens delivery and contextual alignment without substantially expanding the learning capacity of the ToC.

Overall, projects in the Borderline Basic/Structured configuration reveal a transitional use of the Theory of Change. The ToC begins to support coordination, coherence, and contextual responsiveness, yet it continues to function predominantly as an operational guide rather than as a dynamic learning device. The partial articulation of causal logic, the limited use of monitoring data for evaluative purposes, and the absence of systematic theory revision constrain the evolution toward a fully Structured configuration. These cases highlight how the formal presence of a ToC does not automatically translate into reflective or adaptive use, underscoring the importance of how, rather than whether, the ToC is applied in practice.

6.2.3. Structured ToC configurations

A more consolidated pattern emerges in projects positioned within the Structured configuration, where the ToC assumes a clearer and more explicit role in shaping project logic and implementation. Compared to Basic and transitional configurations, these projects display a more systematic articulation of causal pathways and a stronger internal coherence between activities, outcomes, and intended change. In these cases, the ToC functions as a shared reference framework that informs project design and delivery, moving beyond a purely descriptive role, while still revealing limits in its use as a fully adaptive or evaluative device.

Context sensitivity in Structured configurations is generally robust at the design stage and supported by continuous attention to field conditions during implementation. In Project B by Entity Aquila, for instance, contextual analysis is closely linked to the co-design of activities with institutional and community partners, and project representatives described how ongoing interactions with users and stakeholders inform operational choices. In Project Q by Entity Ursa Major the ToC is informed by long-standing engagement with local communities and by continuous observation of beneficiaries' trajectories. Interviewees described how emerging challenges and

unexpected responses from participants are discussed within the project team, however, no substantial co-design exists. However, across these cases, contextual information is primarily used to confirm the plausibility of the initial ToC rather than to prompt systematic revisions of assumptions during implementation. Interviewees reported that contextual changes are discussed within project teams, yet these discussions do not consistently translate into explicit modifications of the ToC framework.

Causal architecture represents a key distinguishing feature of the Structured configuration. All cases identified as Structured show articulation of causal pathways and some evidence of them being linked to intermediate outcomes, reflecting an effort to make the logic of change visible and internally consistent. In Project O, by Entity Scorpius interviewees described change as a process conditioned by critical factors rather than as a linear chain of activities and results, activities are framed as means of change, and conditions of success and failure are partially identified. Project representatives demonstrated the capacity to distinguish between controllable elements and external contextual influences beyond their direct control. Similarly, in Project B, intermediate mechanisms are acknowledged and activities are classified according to their transformative function. Across these Structured cases, causal reasoning is articulated and discussed; however, assumptions are generally treated as stable reference points rather than as hypotheses subject to systematic empirical testing.

Monitoring and evidence generation are more developed in this configuration and typically integrate qualitative and quantitative data. In Project B monitoring practices are explicitly aligned with the multi-level structure of the ToC, capturing information at the level of activities, partnerships, and user experience. However, the use of data remains largely oriented toward tracking progress and demonstrating coherence between planned and implemented actions. The explicit outcome evaluation framework is still partial, and monitoring results are only sporadically mobilised to assess whether intermediate outcomes are unfolding as expected. In the case of Entity Ursa Major, instead, monitoring supports longitudinal observation of beneficiaries' paths and informs internal discussions about effectiveness. However, impact assessment activities are externalised and benefit from specialised expertise: this arrangement introduces a degree of distance between data collection and beneficiaries' lived experiences, which limits the extent to which evaluative findings are directly informed by in-depth, contextualised interaction with participants.

From a functional–temporal perspective, the ToC in Structured configurations provides a stable reference for decision-making throughout implementation. Project teams refer to the ToC to ensure alignment between objectives and activities and to verify that the project remains consistent with its initial design. While interviewees across cases stated that the ToC could be revisited both during and at the end of the project, such revision is primarily framed as a way to check whether the project is “on track” and to confirm coherence between planned and implemented actions: monitoring data inform operational adjustments and support accountability in itinere, but they rarely trigger structured reflection on causal assumptions or substantive revisions of the ToC. The use of the ToC therefore remains predominantly oriented toward control and consolidation rather than toward iterative learning or theory refinement.

Stakeholder engagement in Structured configurations is more stable and integrated into project operations than in previous configurations. Beneficiaries and partners are involved in implementation and provide feedback that contributes to project effectiveness. In Project B, stakeholder participation is embedded in co-design processes, while in Project O, engagement supports alignment with beneficiaries’ needs and organisational missions. Nevertheless, in the first case, when co-design exists, that involves mostly institutional stakeholders; in the second case, in which direct and indirect beneficiaries are involved, they contribute with knowledge and practical insights and their role in shaping causal reasoning remains limited.

Across these cases, projects in the Structured configuration demonstrate a coherent use of the ToC as a planning and coordination framework, with clearly articulated causal pathways and more developed monitoring practices than Basic and transitional configurations. At the same time, the ToC is not yet consistently used to support adaptive learning or systematic outcome evaluation, positioning these projects as analytically robust but still limited in their capacity to revise and test causal assumptions over time.

6.2.4. Hybrid ToC configurations (Structured–Enhanced)

Within the Structured configuration, some projects exhibit features that extend beyond operational coherence and toward more reflexive uses of the ToC. These cases occupy a boundary position between Structured and Enhanced configurations, where the ToC is increasingly treated as a tool for reasoning about change rather than solely for guiding implementation.

Context sensitivity in this group is both operational and reflective. In Project F by Entity Capricornus and Project H by Entity Cygnus contextual awareness is grounded in deep knowledge of beneficiaries' everyday experiences, which shapes both the design of activities and the identification of relevant behavioural and motivational mechanisms. Similarly, in Project C by Entity Aries, contextual embeddedness is strong and grounded in sustained interaction with territories and audiences. The project demonstrates an ability to recognise shifts in social and cultural dynamics, which are acknowledged as relevant to the project's Theory of Change.

Causal architecture in these cases is explicitly articulated and treated with a higher degree of reflexivity, demonstrating awareness of the mechanisms through which activities are expected to generate change and make efforts to map intermediate outcomes. In Project L by Entity Orion, interviewees explicitly acknowledged that change does not unfold in a linear manner and that mere participation in activities is not sufficient to generate impact; moreover, they recognised that each action contributes in different ways to multiple outputs, outcomes, and longer-term effects, and that change depends on a combination of contextual and relational conditions. Similarly, in Project K by Entity Lyra, activities are clearly connected to relational and cognitive improvements, and in Project H, skill development is explicitly linked to social inclusion and employability pathways. Despite this clarity, causal assumptions are not systematically treated as hypotheses to be tested. Across cases, interviewees tended to refer to these assumptions as stable reference points rather than as elements subject to critical verification or revision over time.

Monitoring and evidence use further distinguish this transitional group: projects collect rich qualitative information and use monitoring data to reflect on project evolution. In Project F, interviewees reported the use of structured data collection tools to track participation, engagement, and changes in beneficiaries' attitudes and behaviours, indicating a clear interest in linking evidence to the ToC. In Project K and Project H, monitoring supports ongoing oversight of project implementation and beneficiary participation. In Project C, monitoring practices support reflection on participation and engagement, but the evaluation of longer-term outcomes is still under development. Interviewees described ongoing difficulties in defining an appropriate evaluation framework, particularly in relation to capturing complex and non-linear forms of change. At the same time, they expressed strong interest in developing an impact assessment approach that could integrate qualitative dimensions and address counterfactual reasoning, demonstrating a high level of

reflexivity about both the possibilities and the limits of evaluating cultural and social impact.

In the borderline Structured/Enhanced configurations, the functional–temporal orientation dimension reach the same level of maturity as in the previous group. In Project L, for instance, interviewees stated that it makes sense to look at the map during the project to check whether activities remain aligned with initial intentions, but not necessarily to modify it. Similarly, in Project C, the ToC is expected to remain unchanged unless significant external factors intervene, and revision is primarily associated with reporting or accountability purposes. Across these cases, therefore, in itinere reflection tends to support control and coherence rather than structured learning. While the possibility of revision is acknowledged, the ToC is not consistently treated as a provisional hypothesis to be interrogated and adapted through systematic feedback loops.

Stakeholder engagement in this configuration shows increased depth, particularly in relational terms. Beneficiaries and local actors are involved through ongoing interactions that allow project teams to gather experiential knowledge and feedback during implementation. In Project K for example, both direct and indirect beneficiaries are regularly engaged throughout the project, and these interactions support reflection on beneficiaries' trajectories and emerging needs. Such exchanges contribute to adjusting activities and delivery modalities and are recognised by project teams as relevant for understanding how change unfolds in practice. However, this relational engagement does not consistently extend to the co-construction or revision of the ToC itself. While stakeholders' feedback informs interpretation of results and supports adaptive adjustments at the operational level, they are not systematically involved in questioning assumptions or reshaping causal pathways. As a result, stakeholder engagement strengthens implementation and sense-making, while the learning capacity of the ToC remains only partially developed.

Overall, projects at the Structured/Enhanced boundary occupy a critical position along the continuum, demonstrating how the Theory of Change can move from coherence toward learning, while highlighting the challenges involved in consolidating adaptive and evaluative use over time.

6.2.5. Enhanced ToC configurations

Finally, two projects are positioned within the Enhanced configuration, representing the most integrated use of the ToC observed in the sample. In these cases, the ToC

functions as a central reference for learning, reflection, and adaptation throughout the project lifecycle, rather than as a primarily operational or descriptive framework.

In Project I by Entity Gemini, the Theory of Change is explicitly articulated and systematically linked to both operational decisions and evidence generation. Contextual analysis is not confined to the design phase but is revisited throughout implementation, allowing the project team to interpret emerging signals and adjust strategies accordingly. Interviewees described the ToC as a shared reference that guides reflection on observed outcomes and supports alignment among different project roles, indicating a high level of internalisation of causal reasoning. In Project G by ENTITY CASSIOPEIA, sensitivity to context is expressed through close attention to individual beneficiaries' trajectories, which are understood as highly heterogeneous and shaped by specific personal and relational conditions. This approach reinforces the project's responsiveness to contextual variation, particularly at the individual level.

Causal architecture in this configuration is articulated in a detailed and mechanism-oriented manner. The ToC explicitly maps intermediate outcomes and the relationships linking activities, objectives, and longer-term change. Assumptions are treated as provisional and open to revision, and interviewees reported that the ToC should be updated both during implementation, when monitoring reveals misalignments, and at the end of the project. Revision may concern both the expected outcomes and the causal links connecting activities and results. In Project G, causal reasoning is strongly grounded in individual change processes: the ToC acknowledges multiple, non-linear pathways of change, reflecting the belief that outcomes cannot be standardised across beneficiaries. As a result, causal assumptions are explored through individual trajectories rather than through generalisable patterns.

Methodological integration differs across Enhanced cases but remains a defining feature of the configuration. Project I combines monitoring and evaluation within a mixed-methods framework that supports both outcome assessment and learning. Quantitative and qualitative data are systematically used to reflect on whether observed changes align with the Theory of Change and to refine causal assumptions. In Project G, monitoring practices support reflection on participation and engagement, but the evaluation of longer-term outcomes is still under development: interviewees described the evaluation of longer-term outcomes as intentionally cautious and highly individualised, reflecting the view that beneficiaries' trajectories are not directly comparable. While this approach enhances sensitivity to individual contexts and

change processes, it also constrains the development of shared evaluative frameworks capable of supporting cross-case learning and systematic validation of outcomes over time.

From a functional–temporal perspective, projects in the Enhanced configuration display a markedly different use of the ToC compared to all other configurations. In these cases, the ToC is explicitly conceived as a framework to be revisited and revised over time, rather than as a fixed reference established at the design stage. The temporal dimension of ToC use is therefore closely linked to monitoring practices and to moments of collective reflection during and after implementation. In Project I, interviewees stated that the ToC is expected to be reviewed and updated both in itinere and at the end of the project. Revisions are informed by monitoring data and are triggered when misalignments or unexpected developments emerge during implementation. Importantly, this process is not limited to adjusting activities but extends to revisiting desired outcomes and to reassessing the relationships between activities, objectives, and outcomes. The ToC is thus treated as a learning device that supports continuous interrogation of project logic over time. Similarly, ENTITY CASSIOPEIA stated that the ToC should be revisited both during the course of the project and at its conclusion. Here, temporal revision is closely connected to reflection on individual beneficiaries' trajectories and to the evolution of intervention strategies. Although the forms and timing of revision are less formalised than in Project I, the ToC is nonetheless understood as a dynamic reference that can evolve in response to observed changes.

Finally, stakeholder engagement extends beyond implementation and begins to involve reflection on change processes. In Project G, interviewees expressed the intention to broaden participation in future revisions of the Theory of Change, involving music teachers and potentially representatives of beneficiaries. This reflects an emerging openness toward participatory reflection on causal pathways, even if co-construction of the ToC is not yet fully institutionalised.

Overall, projects in the Enhanced configuration illustrate the most integrated use of the ToC observed in the sample, combining explicit causal articulation, systematic use of evidence, and a learning-oriented temporal approach. While differences remain in how evaluation and participation are operationalised, these cases consistently treat the ToC as a dynamic reference for reflection and ongoing interrogation of project logic.

The cross-case analysis shows that differences in Theory of Change maturity are associated with distinct patterns in how the ToC is used across project design,

implementation and evaluation. Comparing the configurations highlights systematic variations in the articulation of causal logic, the role attributed to monitoring, and the ways in which learning and adaptation are incorporated into project routines. Rather than reflecting a linear progression, these configurations capture a range of situated uses of the ToC, shaped by project objectives, organisational arrangements, and evaluative practices. The interpretation of these patterns, and of the conditions under which different configurations emerge and persist, is developed in the following section.

6.3. Conditions shaping ToC maturity

The maturity levels identified in the previous section should not be interpreted as stages along a linear or normative path of development in the use of the ToC. Instead, they reflect different ways in which the ToC is introduced and used within Third Sector projects. The analysis shows that remaining at a basic level, moving toward more structured uses, or adopting advanced configurations does not simply depend on a stronger or weaker commitment to evaluation. Rather, these configurations emerge from how the ToC is understood and mobilised in practice, and from a set of conditions and project characteristics that shape which forms of use are considered feasible, relevant, or appropriate.

A shared starting condition across all analysed projects concerns the way the ToC entered organisational practice. In all cases, the ToC was analytically reconstructed within the research process rather than being a fully established organisational tool. While some organisations had prior exposure to the concept, such as Entity Gemini, Entity Aquila, ENTITY CASSIOPEIA, and Entity Aries, this familiarity did not necessarily translate into routine or systematic use. In most other cases, the ToC was largely unknown before the interviews. As a result, the observed uses of the ToC reflect not only different levels of maturity, but also different initial conditions in terms of familiarity and readiness to engage with theory-based reasoning. Empirically, all cases that reported some degree of prior familiarity with the ToC, even if this familiarity was often partial, abstract and not previously translated into systematic practice, are positioned within the Structured or Enhanced configurations. In these cases, exposure to the framework facilitated a more immediate engagement with causal reasoning and with the idea of using the ToC as a reference for structuring project logic, contributing to their positioning beyond Basic configurations. Conversely, among projects with no prior exposure to the ToC, different responses to its introduction emerged: while some

organisations approached the framework with openness and curiosity, others displayed hesitation or resistance toward engaging with it beyond a purely formal or instrumental level. These divergent initial responses help explain why projects with similarly limited prior knowledge of the ToC can follow different trajectories along the continuum of maturity. To capture this distinction, it is useful to differentiate between knowledge of the ToC and reflexive orientation toward evaluation. Limited knowledge represents a structural constraint: organisations may lack conceptual tools, methodological skills, or prior experience to autonomously articulate and revise a ToC. Reflexive orientation, by contrast, concerns the degree to which organisations perceive value in interrogating project logic, assumptions, and outcomes over time. Empirically, these two dimensions do not always align. In some Basic configurations, limited knowledge of the ToC is accompanied by low reflexive orientation, resulting in resistance to revisiting project logic during implementation. For instance, in Project J by Entity Leo and in Project M by Entity Pisces, interviewees indicated that revisiting the ToC during implementation was not considered necessary, reflecting both unfamiliarity with theory-based evaluation and a broader organisational culture not oriented toward monitoring and learning in itinere. In contrast, other projects with similarly limited prior knowledge display a different orientation. In Project D by Entity Booters, for example, interviewees expressed openness to revisiting the ToC during implementation if adequate external support were available, while also acknowledging that such a process would not be feasible autonomously. This stance differs markedly from explicit disinterest and instead points to a form of constrained reflexivity: awareness of the potential value of theory-based reflection combined with recognition of internal limitations. Across cases, limited evaluation literacy, lack of dedicated tools, and gaps in methodological skills recur as shared characteristics rather than as isolated shortcomings. These features are especially evident among smaller or less formalised TSOs, where evaluation is rarely institutionalised as a distinct organisational function. In such contexts, a Basic use of the ToC can represent a reasonable and proportionate entry point into evaluative thinking, aligned with available capacities and organisational priorities. At the same time, differences in reflexive orientation help explain why some projects remain stably positioned within Basic configurations, while others move toward more Structured or borderline configurations when opportunities for support, learning, or experimentation arise.

Beyond individual familiarity with the ToC, organisational structuring emerges as a relevant condition shaping how the framework is mobilised and sustained over time. In particular, the presence and location of evaluative competencies within the

organisation influence both the depth and the continuity of ToC use. Projects positioned toward the Structured and Enhanced configurations tend to be associated with organisations in which project design and evaluation are recognised as specific functions. For example, Entity Gemini's interviewees described the presence of an internal function dedicated to project development and impact evaluation. This organisational arrangement supports a systematic engagement with the ToC and contributes to its use as a shared reference for reflection, learning, and adaptation. The internalisation of evaluative competencies facilitates continuity across project phases and enables the ToC to be revisited in response to emerging evidence, contributing to the advanced positioning of this case within the Enhanced configuration. A different organisational arrangement characterises Entity Ursa Major, where impact assessment activities are partially externalised. According to data, the project collaborates with a specialised evaluation consultancy, Centrale Valutativa, which provides methodological expertise through sociologists, methodologists, and statisticians. This collaboration is explicitly framed as learning-oriented, with the aim of supporting the project team in using evaluative insights during implementation. From an empirical perspective, this arrangement enables access to specialised competencies that would be difficult to develop internally and supports the adoption of structured evaluation practices. At the same time, the externalisation of evaluation introduces a different set of implications for ToC use: while specialised support can enhance methodological rigour and learning potential, it may also create a degree of separation between evaluative processes and the everyday contexts in which interventions unfold. The extent to which evaluation remains closely connected to beneficiaries' lived experiences and to project teams' ongoing decision-making depends on how external expertise is integrated into organisational routines. In this sense, Project Q occupies a boundary position: evaluative capacity is present and qualified, yet partially mediated through external actors, shaping a form of ToC use that is reflective but not fully internalised. Both configurations can support learning-oriented uses of the ToC, but they do so through different mechanisms and with different implications for reflexivity, ownership, and continuity. This helps explain why organisational arrangements contribute to the positioning of projects along the maturity continuum, without determining it in a deterministic way.

The analysis further shows that lower levels of organisational formalisation do not necessarily correspond to weaker contextual understanding or limited stakeholder sensitivity. In several cases, less structured and more informal organisations display a strong engagement with the design phase and with the identification of needs. This

form of contextual grounding does not primarily derive from formal participatory mechanisms, but from the fact that organisational actors are themselves embedded within the communities addressed by the intervention. In projects such as Project F by Entity Capricornus and Project H by Entity Cygnus, key organisational figures share lived experiences with the target groups as indirect beneficiaries. This proximity contributes to a nuanced understanding of needs and constraints and informs project design choices. Empirically, such embeddedness is associated with high sensitivity to context and with strong commitment to beneficiaries, even in the absence of formalised evaluation structures. At the same time, this experiential embeddedness operates independently from the organisation's capacity to formalise evaluative reasoning. While it supports relevance and alignment with local conditions, it does not automatically translate into more articulated or reflexive uses of the ToC. In several cases positioned within Basic or lower Structured configurations, strong contextual grounding coexists with limited articulation of causal assumptions and with restrained use of theory-based evaluation tools. This distinction helps explain why some organisations exhibit high contextual awareness and relational engagement while remaining positioned at lower levels of ToC maturity, highlighting that proximity to context and evaluative formalisation constitute analytically distinct dimensions.

Beyond initial conditions, the configuration of projects plays a central role in shaping how and to what extent the ToC is mobilised. Differences in project objectives, target populations, and intended forms of change influence the relevance of different uses of the ToC and the degree of articulation required to support them. Across the cases, a key distinction emerges between projects primarily oriented toward enabling access to activities or services, and projects that explicitly aim to generate changes in behaviours, perceptions, or social relations that extend beyond participation itself. In projects oriented toward access and participation, the identification of needs is often grounded in a clear diagnosis of gaps in service provision or opportunities. In *Project A* by Entity Andromeda, for example, the project is built on an articulated qualitative and quantitative analysis of the cultural context, highlighting a marked discontinuity in concert music provision across the involved provinces. The analysis identifies the absence of musical offerings and the presence of a potential “non-public” as the core need to be addressed. Within this configuration, the context is considered relatively stable over the project timeframe: the primary objective is to activate participation where no offer exists, rather than to modify pre-existing behaviours or attitudes. As a result, participation in concerts is treated as a sufficient indicator of change, coherently

aligning the project within a Basic configuration of ToC use. A different configuration emerges in projects that, while also centred on participation in activities, frame participation as a means rather than an end. In Project P by Entity Taurus, the provision of evening meals responds to an urgent service gap created by the closure of an existing canteen. However, the project explicitly articulates broader objectives related to reducing social isolation, fostering trust, and supporting pathways toward re-engagement with social services. Here, participation in meals is not understood as the primary outcome, but as an entry point for deeper changes in beneficiaries' behaviours and perceptions. This difference in project ambition implies a need for more articulated causal reasoning and for a ToC capable of explicating intermediate outcomes linking service provision to longer-term change. These contrasts show that projects with similar activity structures may require different uses of the ToC, depending on how change is conceptualised: when participation is an end in itself, a stable and restrained ToC can be sufficient; when participation is a means to behavioural or relational change, limited causal articulation becomes constraining and more Structured uses of the ToC gain relevance. Differences in maturity configurations thus also reflect how projects define and pursue change. Remaining within a Basic configuration can be fully appropriate for projects whose objectives are circumscribed and participation oriented. However, when projects explicitly frame their objectives in terms of deeper cultural, behavioural, or relational change, limited maturity in ToC use becomes more problematic. This is illustrated by Project R by Entity Virgo, where ambitious objectives related to sustainability awareness, territorial identity, and social aggregation coexist with weak integration between the ToC and evidence generation, limited reflexivity during implementation, and minimal stakeholder engagement. In such cases, the gap between declared ambitions and the use of the ToC constrains the project's capacity to support learning and to make sense of change processes over time.

The phase at which projects were observed further contributes to explaining variations in the use and articulation of the ToC. In many cases, interviews were conducted relatively early in the project lifecycle, often two to four months after the start of implementation, within projects typically designed to run for approximately twelve months. At this stage, several dimensions of change are still unfolding, and certain effects — such as those related to durability, broader stakeholder responses, or longer-term outcomes — cannot yet be meaningfully assessed. This was explicitly acknowledged by interviewees in projects such as Project N by Entity Sagittarius, Project L by Entity Orion, and Project J by Entity Leo, all of which were observed shortly after project start and where respondents repeatedly emphasised that it was

“too early” to comment on sustained change or longer-term effects. As a result, difficulties in responding to questions concerning enduring change, emerging unintended effects, or shifts in attitudes and practices should not be interpreted as signs of superficial analysis or linear conceptions of change. Rather, they often reflect the simple fact that the project had not yet reached a phase in which such observations could reasonably be made. In these situations, the absence of articulated evidence on longer-term outcomes is less an indication of limited evaluative capacity than a consequence of the timing of data collection in relation to project development. At the same time, the analysis also shows that timing alone does not fully account for differences in how projects engage with evaluative questions. Even when observed at comparable stages of implementation, some organisations were able to articulate early signals of change, reflect on emerging responses from beneficiaries or stakeholders, and discuss potential trajectories of impact. This is the case, for example, in Project H, interviewed only a few months after project start, where interviewees nonetheless reflected on initial behavioural and relational changes among participants. Similarly, in Project Q, interviewed shortly after the beginning of implementation but within a project designed to last two years, respondents were able to reason about early outcomes and longer-term change trajectories, drawing on ongoing engagement with beneficiaries. These contrasts suggest that while project phase sets important constraints on what can be observed and assessed, it does not determine evaluative orientation. Rather, temporal conditions interact with organisational capacities, reflexive practices, and expectations about what kinds of knowledge are considered meaningful at different moments of the project lifecycle. In this sense, “early stage” does not uniformly translate into limited reflection but amplifies existing differences in how projects approach learning and evaluation over time.

Beyond organisational and procedural factors, the analysis highlights a set of limits to ToC use that are intrinsic to the nature of certain interventions and explicitly recognised by the organisations themselves. In a limited number of cases, highly individualised pathways of change are treated as a defining feature of the project. In Project G and in Project Q, interviewees described change as unfolding through heterogeneous and non-linear individual trajectories, which resist standardisation and comparison. In these configurations, outcomes are observed and discussed at the level of individual experiences, while the construction of shared evaluative models is intentionally limited. This does not reflect a lack of interest in impact, but a conscious prioritisation of contextual sensitivity over generalisability, which constrains the forms of ToC use considered appropriate. A different, more widespread limitation

emerges in projects working primarily with children or adolescents. In Project M and in Project J, interviewees explicitly expressed caution in attributing observed changes to the project alone, acknowledging that beneficiaries' behaviours and trajectories are shaped by multiple external influences, including family, school, and peer environments. As a result, claims about durable or long-term change are deliberately avoided, particularly when projects are observed at early stages. This restraint reflects an explicit awareness of attribution limits rather than evaluative weakness. In both configurations, limits to impact assessment are recognised and articulated by project teams during the interviews. The extent to which organisations choose to engage in more demanding evaluative efforts depends on whether they consider it meaningful or appropriate to invest resources in overcoming these intrinsic constraints. As with limited prior knowledge of the ToC, these limits do not automatically prevent evaluative development, but they require deliberate commitment and support to be partially addressed.

Overall, the analysis shows that the absence of progression toward more Structured or Enhanced uses of the ToC cannot be interpreted uniformly as a weakness. In many cases, restrained or Basic configurations reflect a coherent alignment between project objectives, the nature of the intended change, and what can reasonably be observed at a given stage of implementation. Under these conditions, limited articulation of long-term outcomes or causal mechanisms reflects proportionality and contextual awareness rather than insufficient evaluative capacity.

At the same time, the findings indicate that non-evolution becomes more problematic when limited use of the ToC persists beyond what project scope and target characteristics would justify, and is not accompanied by reflexive engagement with assumptions, data, or learning processes. In these situations, the ToC remains static not as a deliberate choice, but as an unexamined default, constraining opportunities for adaptation and learning.

The distinction between coherent non-evolution and limiting stagnation thus lies less in the maturity level itself than in the degree of reflexivity surrounding the use of the ToC. Where organisations recognise the limits of their evaluative approach and remain open to revisiting project logic, restrained configurations retain a dynamic and potentially evolutive character. Where such reflexivity is absent, non-evolution risks becoming a substantive limitation rather than a coherent configuration.

7 Discussion and Conclusions

The previous chapter presented the empirical findings of the study, analysing how the Theory of Change is applied across a set of Third Sector projects and identifying recurring patterns of use along five analytical dimensions. Through the positioning of individual cases and the construction of cross-case groupings, we highlighted different configurations of Theory of Change use, ranging from Basic to Structured and Enhanced, as well as a set of transitional and borderline forms. These results provide a detailed picture of how the Theory of Change is mobilised in practice, revealing both systematic differences and shared tendencies across projects.

These findings confirm that the Theory of Change, in practice, does not operate as a monolithic framework but as a flexible and context-dependent device, whose analytical depth and functional orientation vary according to organisational conditions, project characteristics and institutional environments. The empirical analysis highlighted not only differences in positioning along the continuum, but also a set of enabling and constraining factors that shape the level of analytical maturity achieved in each case.

This chapter builds on those results to reflect more broadly on their implications. Returning to the initial research objectives, namely, to systematise the heterogeneous uses of the Theory of Change through a conceptual taxonomy and to explore how and to what extent such configurations are observable within Third Sector Organisations, the discussion revisits the relationship between normative models and situated practices. The proposed taxonomy, developed on the basis of the literature review, is here reconsidered in light of its empirical application, assessing its interpretative coherence and explanatory potential.

Moving beyond description and classification, the discussion seeks to clarify what these findings reveal about the nature of evaluative maturity in Third Sector contexts, about the conditions under which more reflective and integrated uses of the Theory of Change emerge, and about the tensions between accountability-driven and learning-oriented approaches. On this basis, the chapter articulates the academic and

managerial contributions of the study, reflects on its methodological boundaries, and outlines directions for further research.

Through this final reflection, the thesis aims to contribute to an understanding of impact assessment practices in the Third Sector, highlighting the Theory of Change not merely as a technical planning instrument, but as a contingent and evolving organisational capability, shaped by context, resources and institutional logics.

7.1. Interpreting the findings

The findings, which describe variation in the use of the ToC, also invite a reconsideration of how analytical maturity is conceptualised within Third Sector Organisations. The purpose of this section is therefore not to restate empirical results, but to interpret their broader implications for theory-based evaluation and for the understanding of maturity as a situated and relational construct.

7.1.1. From normative models to observed practices

A key contribution of this study lies in the shift from a normative understanding of the Theory of Change to an analysis grounded in its observed uses in practice. The proposed framework focuses on how it is mobilised within projects, and on the functions it performs in relation to planning, coordination, accountability, and learning, without assessing whether projects adopt the ToC in accordance with predefined standards or ideal models. In this sense, the taxonomy introduced in Chapter 5 was conceived not as a ranking device, but as an interpretative tool aimed at making sense of variation.

Normative approaches to the ToC typically emphasise completeness, internal coherence, and explicit causal articulation as indicators of quality. While such criteria are valuable for guiding design and evaluation processes, they tend to obscure how the ToC operates in real organisational contexts. Applied rigidly, they risk interpreting partial, simplified, or static uses of the ToC as deficiencies, without considering whether these uses are proportionate to project objectives, organisational capacities, or evaluative needs. In contrast, the analytical framework adopted in this research treats variation in the use of the ToC as an empirical object of inquiry rather than as a deviation from an ideal standard.

By focusing on uses rather than forms, the framework makes it possible to observe that the same instrument can serve different purposes across projects and over time. In some configurations, it functions primarily as a planning and coordination device,

supporting operational alignment and reporting. In others, it operates as a reflective tool that structures discussion around assumptions, intermediate outcomes, and learning. These differences do not emerge when quality is assessed solely through formal characteristics; they become visible only when attention is directed to how the Theory of Change is embedded within decision-making processes and organisational routines.

This shift in analytical focus also has implications for how maturity is conceptualised: rather than treating maturity as an intrinsic attribute of the ToC itself, the framework conceptualises maturity as a property of use. Maturity levels reflect configurations in which specific functions of the ToC become salient, depending on context and purpose. As shown in the empirical analysis, limited or Basic uses of the ToC may coexist with high levels of contextual awareness or stakeholder engagement, while more articulated models may remain weakly integrated into practice. These patterns would be difficult to interpret within a purely normative framework, which tends to conflate formal sophistication with evaluative capacity.

Analysing the uses of the Theory of Change further enables a more nuanced interpretation of stability and change. The framework does not assume that projects should necessarily progress toward increasingly complex or reflexive applications of the ToC. Instead, it allows for the identification of coherent configurations in which restrained uses are aligned with project scope and evaluative aims, as well as configurations in which limited use becomes constraining. This distinction would be blurred by approaches that equate maturity with progression along a single developmental path.

Overall, the methodological value of the proposed framework lies in its capacity to make visible the plurality of ways in which the Theory of Change is understood and enacted within the Third Sector. By shifting the analytical lens from idealised models to situated practices, it supports interpretation rather than prescription, and provides a basis for engaging critically with diversity, hybridity, and transition in theory-based evaluation.

7.1.2. The taxonomy as a continuum

Another key contribution of this study lies in the use of a taxonomy conceived as a continuum: instead of assigning projects to fixed and mutually exclusive types, it is designed to capture gradations, hybrid configurations, and transitional forms in the use of the ToC. This approach reflects the empirical observation that projects rarely

conform neatly to predefined models, and that meaningful differences often emerge within, rather than between, idealised categories.

The taxonomy is therefore not intended to classify uses of the ToC in a binary or hierarchical manner. Instead, it provides an analytical lens through which trajectories of maturation, internal tensions, and incoherences in practice can be interpreted. By positioning cases along a continuum, the framework makes it possible to identify not only relatively stable configurations, but also borderline and transitional forms that would remain obscured within more rigid classificatory approaches. As evidenced in the cases funded by the FCVA, these intermediate positions proved particularly informative: they revealed how different dimensions of ToC use may evolve unevenly and how elements associated with more advanced configurations can coexist with more limited or static applications.

Adopting a continuum-based taxonomy also supports a more nuanced interpretation of change over time. The framework accommodates selective evolution, partial adaptation, and even deliberate stability without assuming linear progression toward increasingly “mature” forms of ToC use. The empirical analysis showed that projects may strengthen certain dimensions while leaving others relatively unchanged or may remain at a Basic level in ways that are coherent with their scale, objectives, and evaluative needs. In this sense, the continuum does not encode a developmental imperative but enables interpretation without imposing a teleological logic.

Importantly, structuring the taxonomy as a continuum also avoids conflating analytical differentiation with normative judgment. By framing maturity levels as configurations rather than benchmarks, the framework supports comparative analysis without implying that higher levels necessarily represent superior practice. This distinction is particularly relevant in the Third Sector, where diversity in missions, target groups, organisational capacities, and funding conditions challenges the applicability of uniform evaluative standards.

In this way, the continuum operates less as a classificatory grid and more as a dynamic interpretative space, within which configurations can be read in relation to their internal coherence and contextual alignment. The value of the taxonomy does not lie in fixing projects into predefined categories, but in illuminating patterns of variation and degrees of integration that would otherwise remain implicit. Yet identifying these patterns is only a first step. To understand the reason why specific configurations take shape, stabilise, or remain transitional, it becomes necessary to examine the organisational, contextual, and institutional conditions that influence how the ToC is

enacted in practice. It is to these conditions, and to their implications for the meaning of analytical maturity, that the discussion now turns.

7.1.3. Reflection on conditions shaping the maturity

The cross-case analysis presented in Chapter 7 showed that analytical maturity does not depend solely on structural characteristics of projects, but also on how organisations relate to the ToC as a framework. A particularly relevant distinction emerged between projects in which the ToC was already known and embedded within organisational practice, and those encountering it for the first time.

Projects with prior familiarity with theory-based approaches tended to position themselves more easily within Structured or Enhanced configurations of ToC use. In these cases, the ToC was not perceived as an external requirement but as a recognisable analytical tool, which facilitated its integration into planning and reflection processes. Conversely, projects approaching the ToC without previous exposure often began from more Basic configurations. However, the empirical material suggests that this initial positioning is not always fixed, as it also depends on how the model is approached: where interest, curiosity, and willingness to experiment were expressed, even in the absence of prior expertise, trajectories of potential evolution became visible. This observation has important implications, as it suggests that maturity should not be interpreted as a stable organisational attribute, but as a project-specific and time-bound configuration. The positioning observed in this study reflects how the ToC was mobilised within a given intervention, at a particular stage of organisational development. In several cases, interviewees explicitly expressed openness to further development if adequate support were available. Analytical maturity, therefore, appears less as a static level and more as a dynamic potential, contingent upon learning opportunities and organisational engagement.

At the same time, the analysis indicates that not all projects necessarily benefit from moving toward more integrated configurations. In interventions characterised by clearly circumscribed objectives and limited strategic scope, maintaining a streamlined and planning-oriented use of the ToC may represent a coherent and proportionate choice. In this sense, some Basic configurations closely align with the logic traditionally associated with the Logical Framework Approach, as discussed in Chapter 5. Rather than signalling an incomplete or deficient application of the ToC, these configurations reflect an alignment between evaluative architecture and project rationale. The absence of evolution, in such cases, should not automatically be interpreted as stagnation.

Taken together, these findings point toward a differentiated understanding of how analytical maturity can be supported. For projects that demonstrated interest and predisposition to deepen their use of the ToC, the main constraint often appeared to be not resistance but uncertainty about how to operationalise more advanced configurations. Expressions such as *“We would like to develop a system for long-term impact assessment, but this is beyond our capabilities; we would need support.”*⁶ suggest that targeted accompaniment, for example in co-designing coherent monitoring and evaluation systems or structuring reflective moments, could enable meaningful progression along specific dimensions of the taxonomy.

By contrast, for projects that did not display particular interest in expanding their use of the ToC, the challenge may lie less in technical support and more in awareness and framing. Where the ToC is perceived primarily as an additional administrative burden, its potential as a learning device remains latent. Encouraging a shift in perception, from compliance to strategic utility, may therefore constitute a precondition for any substantive evolution.

Rather than prescribing uniform pathways of advancement, these reflections suggest that support strategies should be differentiated, taking into account organisational starting points, expressed motivations, and project characteristics. Analytical maturity thus appears not as a universal benchmark toward which all projects should converge, but as a situated configuration emerging at the intersection of organisational readiness, project characteristics, and evaluative ambition. From this perspective, the taxonomy does not prescribe evolution; it makes visible the conditions under which different forms of ToC use become coherent, viable, or transformative.

7.2. Contributions of the study

7.2.1. Academic contribution

The primary academic contribution of this study lies in the development of a multidimensional taxonomy designed to systematise the heterogeneous uses of the ToC within impact assessment practices. While the literature acknowledges the flexibility and adaptability of the ToC, it often describes its applications in fragmented or case-specific terms, making comparison difficult and leaving conceptual ambiguities unresolved. By identifying five analytical dimensions and structuring

⁶ Excerpt from Entity Aries's interview

them into a continuum of configurations, this research offers an integrated framework capable of capturing variation without reducing it to rigid categories.

Unlike a classificatory approach that would distinguish sharply between models or treat more complex applications as inherently superior, the proposed taxonomy is conceived as an interpretative continuum. It enables the analysis of hybrid forms and transitional configurations, allowing the coexistence of different evaluative logics within a shared analytical architecture. In doing so, it contributes to clarifying the relationship between the ToC and other theory-based approaches, including configurations that overlap with the logic of the Logical Framework Approach, without framing such overlaps as conceptual inconsistencies.

A second contribution concerns the reconceptualisation of analytical maturity: instead of equating maturity with technical sophistication or with progression toward increasingly integrated configurations, the study conceptualises maturity as a situated and relational construct. The empirical findings show that different levels of ToC articulation may be coherent with distinct project characteristics and organisational capacities. Maturity, therefore, does not represent a universal developmental trajectory but reflects the degree of alignment between evaluative architecture and contextual conditions. The reframing challenges implicit evolutionary assumptions present in parts of the impact evaluation debate and introduces a contingency-based understanding of maturity in the Third Sector.

Finally, the study provides empirical grounding for the proposed framework through its application to a set of projects supported by the Fondazione Comunitaria del Varesotto. The positioning of cases along the continuum and the identification of heterogeneous configurations demonstrate the interpretative robustness of the taxonomy and its capacity to illuminate patterns that would remain implicit within more normative approaches. In this sense, the contribution is not only conceptual but also methodological, as it bridges literature-based systematisation with qualitative empirical analysis.

7.2.2. Managerial implications

The findings of this study suggest that managerial approaches to the ToC within Third Sector Organisations should move beyond implicit assumptions that equate increasing sophistication with better practice. A first implication concerns proportionality: greater analytical integration and methodological refinement are valuable only insofar as they generate meaningful strategic returns. Projects differ significantly in scale,

temporal horizon, organisational structure, and systemic ambition; consequently, the evaluative architecture adopted should reflect this diversity. Introducing highly articulated and resource-intensive configurations where they are not required may result in formal compliance rather than substantive learning. In this sense, sophistication does not automatically imply improvement. Coherence with project rationale and adequacy to organisational capacity represent more meaningful criteria than advancement along an abstract scale of maturity.

A second implication relates to the non-fixed nature of positioning along the taxonomy: the empirical analysis indicates that the use of the ToC is not a stable organisational trait, but a configuration shaped by familiarity and openness to the model. Projects encountering the ToC for the first time may initially adopt simplified configurations; however, where curiosity and willingness to experiment are present, trajectories of potential development become visible. This suggests that support strategies should be differentiated rather than standardised. For organisations that demonstrate interest in deepening their evaluative practices, the main constraint often lies not in resistance but in uncertainty about how to operationalise more structured configurations. Targeted accompaniment may enable progression along specific dimensions without imposing unnecessary complexity. By contrast, where the ToC is perceived primarily as an administrative requirement, the challenge may be less technical than cultural. In such cases, fostering awareness of its strategic utility becomes a precondition for any meaningful evolution.

A third implication concerns the organisational embedding of the ToC. When confined to proposal documents or reporting templates, the ToC tends to remain static and compliance oriented. Its added value emerges when it becomes integrated into decision-making routines, collective reflection, and adaptive management processes. Strengthening dialogical and iterative practices around the ToC may therefore have greater impact than merely increasing formal detail or expanding causal maps.

Finally, the study highlights the indirect, yet significant role played by funding entities. The expectations embedded in funding schemes and reporting requirements contribute to shaping the evaluative logics that organisations adopt. Where accountability is framed predominantly in terms of predefined outputs and measurable deliverables, more linear and planning-oriented configurations are likely to prevail. Where space is created for reflection and learning, more integrated and reflexive uses of the ToC may emerge. Foundations and funding bodies thus do not

merely regulate evaluation practices; they participate in modelling the conditions under which different forms of analytical maturity become viable.

Taken together, these reflections suggest that effective support strategies should not aim at universal advancement toward more sophisticated models. Rather, they should recognise that sophistication is not inherently superior, that coherence outweighs complexity, and that adequacy to context and organisational readiness is more meaningful than advancement for its own sake.

7.3. Limitations and future research

While the findings of this study contribute to clarifying the heterogeneous uses of the ToC within Third Sector Organisations, they must be interpreted within the boundaries of the research design adopted. As with any qualitative and contextually grounded inquiry, the scope of the conclusions is shaped by methodological choices, empirical focus, and analytical framing. A critical reflection on these limitations not only strengthens the internal coherence of the study but also helps identify promising directions for future research.

7.3.1. Limitations of the study

The first set of limitations concerns the empirical scope of the study. The analysis was conducted on a set of projects funded by a single community foundation operating within a specific territorial and institutional ecosystem. Although the selected cases display internal heterogeneity in terms of objectives and organisational profiles, they nonetheless share a common funding framework and operate within a relatively coherent governance environment. This contextual concentration enhances the depth and comparability of the analysis but inevitably limits the external generalisability of the findings. The configurations identified and the conditions shaping different uses of the ToC are therefore to be understood as situated within a particular segment of the Third Sector, rather than as universally representative of all organisational contexts in which theory-based evaluation tools are adopted.

A second group of limitations relates to the qualitative and interpretative nature of the research design. The positioning of projects along the proposed continuum is based on document analysis, semi-structured interviews, and analytical coding conducted by the researcher. Although this approach enables in-depth understanding of organisational reasoning and contextual nuance, it also implies a degree of interpretative mediation. The taxonomy does not function as a quantitative scoring

instrument with predefined numerical thresholds; rather, it operates as a conceptual framework guiding comparative interpretation. As such, different researchers applying the same taxonomy to the same cases might produce partially divergent assessments, particularly in borderline or transitional configurations. This does not undermine the validity of the framework but highlights its reliance on qualitative judgment and reflexive analysis.

Furthermore, the study captures the use of the ToC at a specific moment in time. The empirical material reflects how the ToC was understood and enacted within projects during the period of observation and interview. It does not constitute a longitudinal examination of how evaluative practices evolve across multiple funding cycles or organisational phases. As discussed in the previous sections, analytical maturity emerged as a configuration that is project-specific and temporally situated. However, the present research design does not allow for direct observation of long-term trajectories of development, regression, or transformation. The dynamic potential identified in some cases therefore remains analytically inferred rather than empirically tracked over time.

Finally, the study does not assess the effectiveness of different configurations in producing measurable social impact. The taxonomy is designed to interpret variation in the use of the ToC, not to rank configurations according to outcome performance. While more integrated or reflexive uses may plausibly enhance organisational learning, this research does not establish empirical links between maturity levels and project success indicators. Any inference regarding the relative effectiveness of different configurations would require a distinct research design integrating impact measurement and comparative outcome analysis.

Taken together, these limitations delineate the interpretative boundaries of the study. They do not diminish the conceptual contribution of the taxonomy, but they clarify the conditions under which its findings should be understood: as contextually grounded, qualitatively interpreted, temporally situated, and analytically focused on configurations of use rather than on impact outcomes.

7.3.2. Future development

The limitations outlined above open several avenues for further research, aimed at refining and deepening the analytical framework proposed in this study.

A first direction concerns the extension of the empirical base beyond the specific segment of the Third Sector analysed here. Applying the taxonomy to organisations

operating in different institutional environments (i.e. public administrations, international development agencies, social enterprises, or hybrid public–private partnerships) would allow for testing its interpretative robustness across diverse governance regimes and accountability logics. Comparative applications across national contexts could further illuminate how regulatory frameworks, funding cultures, and professional norms influence the configurations of ToC use. Such cross-contextual analyses would not only assess the transferability of the continuum-based taxonomy but could also reveal whether certain dimensions assume greater relevance in specific institutional settings.

A second promising direction involves the introduction of a longitudinal perspective. The present study captures the positioning of projects at a specific moment in time, interpreting maturity as a project-bound and temporally situated configuration. However, the findings suggest that positioning along the continuum is not necessarily stable. Future research could therefore investigate how configurations evolve across funding cycles, organisational growth phases, or repeated exposure to theory-based evaluation frameworks. Longitudinal case studies would make it possible to observe whether and how organisations move across configurations, whether such movement is linear or cyclical, and which forms of support or institutional change contribute to sustained development. This perspective would offer a more dynamic understanding of analytical maturity, moving from inferred potential to empirically documented trajectories.

A third line of development concerns the methodological operationalisation of the analytical framework proposed in this study. In the present research, the taxonomy functions as a qualitative interpretative device, supporting comparative analysis through analytical coding and reflexive judgment. While this approach allows for contextual sensitivity and depth of understanding, future research could explore a more structured operationalisation of the five dimensions. More specifically, subsequent studies could develop measurable indicators or scaled assessment criteria associated with each dimension, enabling the integration of qualitative insights with quantitative analytical techniques; such advancement would allow for broader comparative analyses across larger samples, strengthen inter-rater reliability, and facilitate statistical exploration of patterns across configurations. A mixed-method research design combining qualitative case analysis with quantitative measurement tools could therefore contribute to enhancing the empirical robustness of the continuum-based taxonomy, while preserving its interpretative richness.

Another relevant avenue for future research concerns the relationship between configurations of ToC use and broader organisational or impact-related outcomes. While the present study focuses on interpreting variation in evaluative configurations, further inquiry could investigate how different forms of ToC use interact with organisational learning processes, strategic alignment, or impact-related performance. Exploring these relationships in diverse contexts would contribute to a deeper understanding of the practical implications of different evaluative configurations, without presuming a linear association between higher levels of maturity and superior results.

Finally, further research could investigate more explicitly the role of funding bodies and governance arrangements in shaping evaluative configurations. Comparative studies across foundations or funding schemes with differing accountability expectations and support mechanisms could shed light on how external institutional pressures and incentives influence the evolution of ToC use. This would contribute to a more systemic understanding of analytical maturity as a co-produced phenomenon, emerging not only from internal organisational capacities but also from the broader evaluative ecosystem in which organisations operate.

Taken together, these avenues point toward an expanded research agenda capable of consolidating and extending the insights developed in this thesis. By broadening the empirical scope, introducing temporal depth, enhancing methodological operationalisation, and examining the relationship between configurations and impact outcomes, future studies could further clarify the conditions under which different forms of ToC use generate strategic and social value.

7.4. Conclusions

This thesis addressed the conceptual and practical heterogeneity that characterises the use of the ToC within the Third Sector, responding to the need for greater analytical clarity in a field marked by fragmented applications and normative expectations. Starting from the observation that the literature presents multiple, and often fragmented, applications of the ToC and related frameworks, the study aimed to develop a structured taxonomy capable of systematising such variation and to examine how these configurations are observable in practice within a defined organisational context.

The empirical analysis conducted on projects funded by a community foundation confirmed that the ToC is indeed mobilised in diverse ways. Rather than identifying a

uniform pattern of adoption, the findings revealed differentiated configurations of use, ranging from planning-oriented and relatively linear applications to more integrated and reflexive forms. These configurations did not appear randomly distributed; instead, they reflected distinct combinations of organisational familiarity, engagement, and contextual alignment. The analysis further demonstrated that positioning along the proposed continuum is neither fixed nor inherently progressive. It is shaped by project-specific characteristics and may remain stable, evolve selectively, or stabilise in forms that are coherent with organisational capacities and evaluative ambitions.

The central contribution of the thesis lies in the development and empirical application of a multidimensional taxonomy conceived as a continuum. By articulating five analytical dimensions and structuring them into interpretative configurations, the study offers a coherent framework for comparing heterogeneous uses of the ToC without reducing them to binary classifications or hierarchical stages. The continuum-based structure allows for the identification of hybrid and borderline forms, capturing the uneven evolution of different dimensions and avoiding simplistic developmental narratives.

A further conceptual implication concerns the reconceptualisation of analytical maturity. The findings support a contingency-based understanding of maturity: higher maturity does not correspond to greater complexity or methodological sophistication; rather, it emerges as a situated configuration reflecting the alignment between evaluative architecture, organisational readiness, and project rationale.

Overall, these insights contribute to reframing the debate on theory-based evaluation within the Third Sector. The ToC should not be interpreted solely as a technical instrument for causal modelling or reporting, nor as a normative benchmark of evaluative excellence. Instead, it appears as an organisational device whose meaning and function are shaped by how it is embedded within routines, decision-making processes, and governance arrangements. Recognising this plurality does not dilute standards; rather, it clarifies the conditions under which different configurations become viable and meaningful.

Ultimately, the study suggests that the challenge for Third Sector Organisations is not to converge toward a single ideal model of ToC use, but to cultivate coherence between evaluative practices and organisational purpose. By providing a structured yet flexible interpretative lens, the proposed taxonomy contributes to understanding this alignment and offers a basis for more context-sensitive approaches to impact

assessment. In doing so, it highlights that the value of the ToC lies not in formal sophistication alone, but in its capacity to sustain informed, context-sensitive, and strategically coherent organisational action.

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A Appendix A

A.1. Interview script

GUIDING QUESTIONS FOR MONITORING INTERVIEWS

Section 1: Needs and context analysis (coherence and relevance)

The objective is to ensure that the project is aligned with the real needs of the community.

Analysis process:

- 1.1. What elements of the local context most influenced the needs analysis?
- 1.2. What tools were used to identify needs during the design phase?
- 1.3. What difficulties did you encounter in analysing and monitoring needs during the project?
- 1.4. Were participatory meetings held during the design phase? If so, how many?
- 1.5. Were there any updates following the initial needs analysis? If so, when and why?
- 1.6. What tools are used to capture changes in the context?
Were stakeholders involved in the design phase? How many and what percentage of the total?
- 1.7. Did anything emerge from these meetings that changed or confirmed your understanding of the needs?

Analysis of results:

- 1.8. To what extent did the project address the priority needs identified compared to those initially identified?
- 1.9. Which needs were best addressed, and which were least addressed? Why?
- 1.10. What was the community's perceived level of satisfaction with the interventions carried out?
- 1.11. How do you interpret this level of satisfaction?
- 1.12. What qualitative evidence did you gather to confirm this level of satisfaction?

- 1.13. Were any changes made in response to community feedback? If so, what were they?

Impact analysis:

- 1.14. Did the project contribute to improving the quality of life or reducing the initial problems? How?

Section 2: Partnership (involvement and collaboration)

The objective is to ensure the active participation and contribution of local partner organisations.

Analysis process:

- 2.1. How many formal meetings were organised with local partners?
- 2.2. Who participated in the formal meetings?
- 2.3. What was the average participation rate?
- 2.4. How many informal meetings were organised with local partners?
- 2.5. What was the average participation rate?
- 2.6. What kind of contribution did the informal meetings make compared to the formal ones?

Analysis of results:

- 2.7. How many significant contributions or operational proposals were received from partners?
- 2.8. What contributions did you receive?
- 2.9. How many of these were incorporated into the project?
- 2.10. Why were some proposals not incorporated?
- 2.11. What was the overall level of satisfaction of the partners with the methods of involvement and how many took on active and specific roles?
- 2.12. What facilitated or hindered their active involvement?

Impact analysis:

- 2.13. Did the partnership generate increased collaboration between local authorities that continued beyond the project? How?
- 2.14. Did the involvement of the partnership increase the effectiveness of the project?

- 2.15. What specific elements of the partnership increased the effectiveness of the project?

Section 3: Strategies – action plan (implementation and management)

The objective is to ensure that activities are carried out on schedule and that stakeholders are properly involved.

Analysis process:

- 3.1. What percentage of activities have started compared to the initial schedule?
- 3.2. Which activities have experienced significant delays or advances, and what were the main reasons?
- 3.3. Have stakeholders been involved? If so, to what extent? Indicate the role, frequency and manner of stakeholder involvement.

Results analysis:

- 3.4. What percentage of activities have been completed compared to the initial schedule?
- 3.5. How many stakeholder liaison events have been held?
- 3.6. Were substantial changes to the activities necessary compared to the initial plan? If so, why and in what areas?
- 3.7. What operational issues arose and how were they handled?
- 3.8. What factors facilitated the implementation of the activities?

Impact analysis:

- 3.9. Did stakeholders perceive the project to be effective?
- 3.10. Please explain your answer.
- 3.11. Can the management model and operational strategies be replicated in future interventions? If so, which elements are considered replicable and under what conditions?

Section 4: Expected results (outputs and outcomes)

The objective is to achieve measurable and meaningful outputs and outcomes. This section is essential for data aggregation.

Analysis process:

- 3.1. Have monitoring tools been put in place? If so, which ones?
- 3.2. For each tool indicated, what is being monitored?
- 3.3. How often has data on outputs and outcomes been collected?

3.4. Why were this frequency chosen?

3.5. Were there any difficulties in collecting data or in data quality? If so, what were they?

3.6. Were approximations or estimates necessary? If so, what methods were used and what are their limitations?

3.7. Is there an outcome evaluation system in place? If so, what is it?

Analysis of results:

3.8. How many direct and indirect beneficiaries were reached compared to the initial target?

3.9. How were indirect beneficiaries counted, and what criteria were used to define and estimate them?

3.10. What percentage of the targets were achieved?

3.11. How satisfied are the beneficiaries with the results achieved?

3.12. Please explain your answer: how is this satisfaction measured and what qualitative elements explain the score?

3.13. What changes have been observed in the behaviour/conditions of the beneficiaries?

Impact analysis:

3.14. Is there a perception of lasting improvement on the part of the beneficiaries?

3.15. On what elements is this perception based?

3.16. Has evidence been collected that suggests lasting change? If so, what evidence?

3.17. Are the actions implemented considered scalable and/or replicable? What conditions make them so?

3.18. Is continuity of the actions planned beyond the end of the project?

3.19. Please explain your answer. If yes, how is this continuity guaranteed and who will support it?

Section 5: Economic plan

The objective is to ensure the economic sustainability and consistency of the project budget.

Analysis process:

- 5.1. Is there a detailed budget plan? If so, how is it structured?
- 5.2. How often is economic performance monitored?
- 5.3. How is monitoring carried out?
- 5.4. What percentage of total expenditure is monitored?

Analysis of results:

- 5.5. What were the main differences between the planned budget and actual expenditure, and what percentage did they represent?
- 5.6. What factors led to any savings or extra costs?
- 5.7. Were any budget revisions necessary?
- 5.8. What was the number of resources raised through donations (if applicable) compared to the fundraising target set?
- 5.9. Was the budget consistent with the results achieved?
- 5.10. Explain the criteria used for scoring and the evidence to justify it

Impact analysis:

- 5.11. What strategies were implemented to ensure the continuation of the main activities beyond the end of the project?
- 5.12. Is the project expected to be integrated into the ordinary activities and budgets of the organisation and its partners?
- 5.13. Were new partnerships established because of the project? If so, how many and of what type?

A.2. Data analysis strategy

Table A.2.i presents the integrated analytical structure used to interpret the interview data, linking inductively identified empirical patterns to analytical categories and to the corresponding levels of maturity defined within each category. The table documents the transition from raw empirical evidence to an evaluative interpretation of how each analytical area is addressed across cases.

Categories	Maturity levels	Empirical patterns
Ex-ante needs assessment	Evidence-driven assessment	Qualitative needs analysis of a fragile context
		Search for new beneficiaries - market analysis
		Horizontal co-design
		Market analysis
	Socio-relational systemic assessment	Existing active collaborations
		Dialogue with other territorial realities
	Consultative-experiential assessment	Needs analysis based on previous experience
		Reworking of previous projects
	Bureaucratic compliance	Presentation of opportunities - co-design (top-down)
Iterative needs reassessment	Dynamic adaptive assessment	Changes in response to new/different needs that have emerged
		Updates in response to new needs that have emerged during meetings with stakeholders
	Structured periodic reassessment	Update in progress required
		Update in progress planned
		Confirmation of identified needs
	Static need assessment	Na: meetings not held
		No update
		No changes (meetings with the community held but time constraints)
		No changes (meetings with the community held)
		No changes (no meetings with the community)
		No changes despite negative feedback
Contextual change analysis	Proactive variation analysis	Analysis of changes through direct observation
		Comparison with past context surveys - analysis of interviews
		Analysis through open dialogue with stakeholders
		New needs emerged
	Advisory monitoring of changes	Analysis of changes through feedback
		Analysis of changes through meetings
		Analysis of changes through questionnaires
	Confirmatory analysis	Confirmation of initial needs
		No changes in context detected
	Variation assessment not held	Na: meetings not held
		Context perceived as stable
		No tools for changes in context
Stakeholder engagement in design phase	Substantial co-design	Meetings with non-institutional stakeholders
		Meetings with volunteers
		Questionnaires for stakeholders
	Formal co-design	Meetings with stakeholders
		Meetings with institutional stakeholders

		Continuous dialogue with institutional stakeholders: co-design
	Top-down co-design	Participatory meetings with partners
	Co-design absent	Meetings with non-institutional stakeholders - absent
		Meetings with stakeholders - absent
		Meetings with institutional stakeholders - absent
Stakeholder involvement in action planning	Stakeholders' participation in activities	Stakeholders involved in activities/action plan
		Involvement through activities and working groups
	Stakeholders informed on activities	Involvement through informal exchanges of information
		Involvement through interviews and meetings
	Stakeholders not involved in activities	Stakeholders not involved in activities
Post-project sustainability	Ownership and market capacity	Sharing with the local community is required
		Ad hoc planning tied to local territories
		Partnership necessary
		Possibility of entering the market
		Commitment to beneficiaries is required
	Operational continuity and adaptive management	Continuation of certain actions already in place
		Attention to emerging opportunities
		A dedicated physical location is required
	Financial constraints	Financial resources are required
Replicability and scalability across contexts	Transferability based on mechanisms	Available context and collaborations
		Necessary analysis of the territory
	Competence based planning	Partnership necessary
		Necessary resources and specific skills
	Financial constraints	Necessary economic resources
Adaptive management	Strategic resilience	Unforeseen events overcome through adaptation
		Operational critical issues identified and resolved through flexible organisation
	Structured adaptation	Critical issues in terms of timing - preliminary organisation essential for managing critical issues
		Critical issues identified and resolved through preliminary organisation
	Static compliance and blindness	Critical issues not identified
Budget–activities–outcomes alignment	Strategic integration function-impact	(budget) defined in advance with careful consideration
		(budget) detailed by function
		(budget) supply and demand system satisfied
		(outcome) fully achieved
		(budget) based on previous experience

	Operational-procedural correspondence	(budget) consistent with that planned
		(outcome) coherent with the plan
	Administrative-accounting compliance	(budget) detailed by nature
		(outcomes) complex to evaluate
Use of monitoring tools	Continuous and adaptive monitoring	Quantitative and qualitative monitoring system
		Quantitative (and partly qualitative) monitoring system
	Difficulty on implementation	Limited qualitative and quantitative monitoring system (based on operator requests)
		Interest in developing a monitoring system
		Desire for qualitative monitoring system (difficulty: timing)
	Bureaucratic monitoring	Quantitative monitoring system
		Monitoring system considered unnecessary (ex-ante planning)
		No monitoring system
Impact evaluation framework	Mixed-method framework	Quantitative and qualitative evaluation system
		Quantitative (and partially qualitative) evaluation system
		Interest in counterfactual analysis
		Recognition of complexity in impact evaluation
	Structured framework but limited or externalised	Outsourced evaluation system
		Evaluation system in place but complex to follow
	Difficulty on implementation	Evaluation system in the process of definition
		Desire to carry out evaluation and reporting
	Framework absent	Evaluation system unclear at this stage of the project
		No evaluation system in place
		Evaluation system considered unnecessary
Stakeholder and beneficiary satisfaction	Substantial ownership and behavioural validation	Positive: direct observation of behaviours
		Positive: willingness to continue activities beyond the end of the project
		Positive: supply and demand system satisfied
	Social engagement and reflexivity	Positive: increased engagement / participation
		Positive: presence of a debate reflecting interest
	Functional alignment	Positive: feedback collected
		Positive: from testimonials
		Positive: activities respond to identified needs
	Contextual and timing awareness	Na: broad and complex context that must be analysed and evaluated on a case-by-case basis
		Na: not detectable at this stage of the project
	Contextual disconnection	Negative: community not interested at this stage
		Negative: from feedback and social media

	Informational void	Negative: broad context with little stimulation towards the project
		Na: community not identifiable
		Na: no data collected
Evidence of sustained change	Substantial change evidence	Positive: observable change in behaviours
		Positive: results achieved
		Positive: supply/demand system satisfied
		Positive: observable change in previous experiences
	Perceived value	Positive: increased engagement
		Positive: collection of beneficiary statements during interviews
		Positive: project potential emerging
		Neutral: change of vision but the influence in their life is limited
	Theoretical potential and context barriers	Na: project in its initial phase
		Neutral: complex context
		Neutral: the subject of the project is a complex issue and cannot be described as 'lasting'
		Neutral: external influences that cannot be predicted in the future
		Na: external behaviours not observable
Representation of project and activities	Causal-strategic integration	Toc as a faithful translation of practice
		Classification of activities based on transformative function
		Activities as a means for change
		Classification of activities based on impact
	Operational-reflective alignment	Looking at the logic of the project beyond the activities
		Toc as a faithful translation of practice
	Descriptive-bureaucratic compliance	Toc as an external artefact (from call for proposals/evaluator)
		Classification of activities based on dedicated resources
Intended change	Systemic and relational transformation	Systematic change
		Focus not only on direct beneficiaries but also on the network and context
		Transformative function of activities
		Recognition of individual change - relational change with the internal environment - relational change with the external environment
	Behavioural evolution and strategic hypothesis	Toc as a hypothesis of change
		Toc as a hypothesis of change driven by participation
		Focus on behavioural change

	Linear conformity	Toc as a hypothesis of change but attention to participation in activities
Missing middle	Systematic and analytical causality	Intermediate links and conditioning factors identified
		Non-linear change
		Change is conceived as a process conditioned by critical factors
		Ability to identify conditions for success/failure
	Conditional operational transition	Intermediate links partially identified
	If-then logic	Change is conceived as a linear chain
		No identification of intermediate links
		Vision of critical issues at the operational level
Implicit assumptions	Critical and systematic assumptions	Uncontrollable implicit assumptions recognised
		Recognition of the influence of the external context
	Functional - operational assumptions	Little recognition of implicit assumptions
		Implicit assumptions based on controllable and practical elements
	Linear logic conformity	Unrecognised implicit assumptions
		Focus on controllable elements
		Focus on necessary economic resources
Longitudinal use	Adaptive learning	Focus: to improve
		Orientation: learning
		Reflection on the perception of those who construct the toc
	Structured accountability monitoring	Focus: to prove
		Orientation: accountability
		Toc as a reporting tool
	Static and bureaucratic conformity	Toc as a static tool
Stakeholder voice and ownership	Substantial ownership	Substantial participation
		High stakeholder engagement
	Medium stakeholders' ownership	Medium/high stakeholder engagement
		Medium stakeholder engagement
		Medium/low stakeholder engagement
	Formal participation	Low stakeholder engagement
		Formal participation
Actor alignment on change vision	Focus on change and alignment	Alignment between actors
		Centrality of change
		Alignment - NA: only one actor present
	Focus on activities and misalignment	Non-aligned actors
		Centrality of operations

Table A.1.i - Analytical linkage between empirical patterns, categories and maturity levels

The following table, Table A.2.ii, reports interview excerpts that provide explanatory insights into project choices and practices and classifies them into interpretive families. The coding supports the interpretation of case positioning by highlighting enabling factors, constraining conditions and situations in which the observed level of maturity is functionally appropriate to the project configuration.

Family	Coding of extract	Empirical pattern extracted
Contextual complexity and problem structure	High problem complexity	Very complex context and scope of work
	Environmental uncertainty	Complex context characterised by unforeseen events
	Limited transformability	The subject of the project is a complex issue, and it is not possible to talk about lasting change
	Beneficiary heterogeneity	It is difficult to evaluate because people are complex and diverse
	Outcomes beyond project lifecycle	Some outcomes extend beyond the end of the project
	Post-project access constraint	No evaluation system: no access to beneficiaries in the long term
	Long-term access limitation	Difficult access to beneficiaries beyond the end of the project
	Beneficiary vulnerability	Complex nature of beneficiaries: lack of openness and trust
	Context-dependence	Relevance of the social context of beneficiaries
Organisational capacities and evaluation literacy	Skill gap but motivation to improve	Willingness to evaluate but lack of skills
	Limited adaptive capacity	Lack of skills for toc review
	Lack of tools	Lack of tools for stakeholder satisfaction
	Reflexive awareness	Critical reflection on lack of skills
	High evaluation literacy	Very high evaluation skills
	Methodological openness	Interest in counterfactual analysis
	Outsourced evaluation	Outsourcing of evaluation
	Delegated evaluation	Support from external professionals
Data availability and knowledge infrastructure	Data scarcity	Lack of up-to-date data
	Low data granularity	Historical and aggregated data
	Qualitative data gap	Difficulties in collecting data for needs analysis
	Monitoring data instability	Difficulties in collecting data for monitoring
	Participation constraint	Limited participation
	Selective data use	Selective use of collected data

	Qualitative orientation	Desire for qualitative monitoring
	Missed learning opportunity	Missing focus groups
Stakeholder and community dynamics	Territorial embeddedness	In-depth knowledge of the territory
	Institutional legitimacy	High territorial legitimacy
	Community knowledge and understanding	The community knows each other, there is credibility and trust that allows for easy movement
	Effective partnership	Effective relationship with partners
	Resource pooling	Sharing resources with partners
	Affective engagement	Emotional involvement of partners
	Stakeholder ambiguity	Difficulty identifying stakeholders
	Engagement constraint	Difficulty involving stakeholders
	Partial ecosystem support	Incomplete territorial support
	Limited visibility	Low knowledge of the project
Strategic orientation and temporal priorities	Action-oriented strategy	Priority on actions
	Time pressure	Critical timing issues
	Strategic postponement	Decision not to initiate assessment in the short term
	Sufficiency logic	Assessment deemed unnecessary
	Temporal constraint	System not in place: time needed
	Evaluation out of scope	Assessment not being considered
	Process-oriented view	Assessment system not in place: focus on continuity, it is a process rather than a project
Governance, design & project architecture	Project in early stage	Project in initial phase
	Tight deadlines in design phase	Limited time for needs analysis
	Structural blind spots	Difficulties for indirect beneficiaries
	Hyper-customisation	Different evaluation for each beneficiary
	Scope overflow	Needs beyond the scope of the project
	Formal governance	Highly structured governance

Table A.2.ii - Classification of explanatory interview excerpts into interpretive families

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